

FOREWORD BY TONY ROBBINS



GROW YOUR BUSINESS BIGGER AND
FASTER THAN YOU THINK POSSIBLE

The
Science
of
Scaling

DR. BENJAMIN HARDY
AND BLAKE ERICKSON

FOUNDERS OF SCALING.COM

Praise for Dr. Benjamin Hardy

The Science of Scaling is transformative. Its scaling framework and philosophy is a road map for both startups and mature companies to create incredible growth and performance. I truly believe if a founder or leader embraces the paradigm shift this book offers, they can rapidly scale their company—no matter the size.

— **Robert C. Gay**, former senior managing director and chair of the management committee of Bain Capital

It's rare that a book marks a paradigm shift and remodeling of an entire field of thought. This book redefines business strategy and scaling. I actually wish I'd written this book. It perfectly encapsulates the simple strategies I've used to help our business leaders achieve seemingly impossible goals again and again.

— **Tony Robbins**, #1 *New York Times* best-selling author, global entrepreneur, investor, philanthropist, and the world's #1 life and business strategist

The Science of Scaling is a paradigm-shifting, breakthrough book because it represents a break with traditional thinking about growth, leadership, and culture. Hardy and Erickson reframe scaling not just as a strategic challenge but as a leadership imperative: your “floor” becomes your culture and your clarity becomes your competitive edge. A bold, compelling, and timely guide for leaders ready to raise both their ceiling and their floor.

— **Stephen M. R. Covey**, *New York Times* and #1 *Wall Street Journal* best-selling author of *The Speed of Trust* and *Trust & Inspire*

ALSO BY DR. BENJAMIN HARDY

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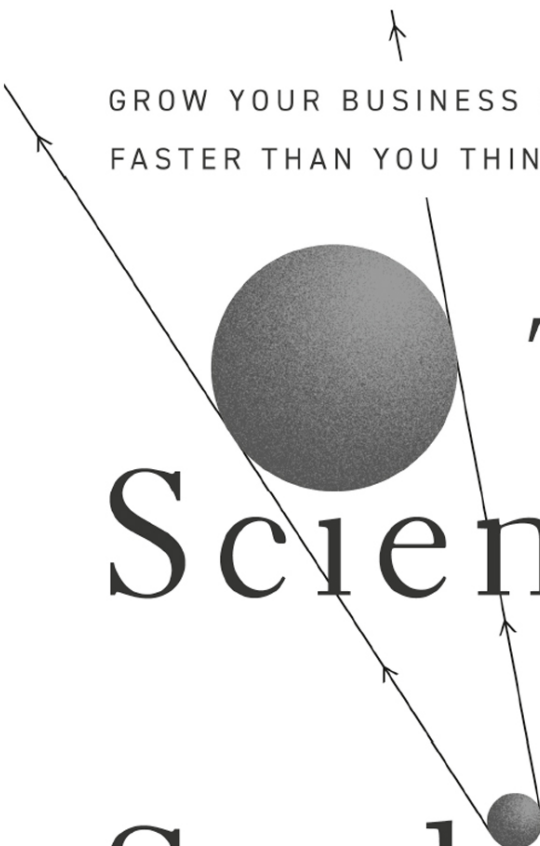
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Dedication:

For Daniel and Fernanda Amato

You never change things by fighting the existing reality. To change something, build a new model that makes the existing model obsolete.

— BUCKMINSTER FULLER, SYSTEMS THEORIST, IN *CRITICAL PATH*^{[1](#)}

What man actually needs is not a tensionless state, but rather the striving and struggling for a worthwhile goal, a freely chosen task.

— VIKTOR F FRANKL M.D., IN *MAN'S SEARCH FOR MEANING*^{[2](#)}

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FOREWORD

There's a moment in every achiever's life when they realize the reason they're stuck isn't because they lack intelligence, talent, or ambition—it's because they've been aiming too small.

Over the past four and a half decades, I've worked with some of the most driven, disciplined, and daring individuals on earth—founders, visionaries, athletes, and leaders. Early in their journeys, they grow rapidly. They innovate. They take bold risks. They defy odds. But then something happens. They succeed just enough to get comfortable. They shift from scaling to sustaining. From creation to maintenance. From compounding to incremental.

And that's where the dream begins to die.

What Dr. Benjamin Hardy has done in this book is nothing short of extraordinary. *The Science of Scaling* is not just a book about business growth—it's a complete reorientation of how we think about achievement itself. It's a paradigm shift. A model for geometric growth rooted in one of the most powerful truths I've ever experienced: Breakthroughs are not born from certainty—they're born from unreasonable goals, urgent timelines, and emotionally compelling reasons why.

Here's what most people never understand: The key to exponential growth isn't having the perfect plan. It's having a massive, seemingly impossible target—one that forces you to think, operate, and execute differently. One that demands innovation instead of imitation.

In my own life, I've applied this exact approach again and again—long before I knew Ben or this framework. Whether it was feeding 100 million people in a single year or growing from one small business to now 114 companies generating over \$9 billion in annual revenue, the pattern was always the same: set a goal that redefines the game, create powerful

emotional reasons that pull you through inevitable challenges, and set a deadline that doesn't give you the luxury of procrastination.

That is the science of achievement. That is the DNA of scaling. And Dr. Benjamin Hardy has captured it with clarity, precision, and practicality.

In fact, as I read this book, I found myself nodding, smiling, and thinking: This is it. This is the pattern—the unspoken psychology—that every extraordinary achiever I've known or studied has followed, whether consciously or unconsciously. From the outside, it may look like strategy. From the inside, it's a mindset. A standard. A demand.

This book will give you that mindset—and more importantly, it will give you the tools to act on it.

It's rare that I read something and think, "I wish I had written this." But this is one of those rare books. It codifies what works. It takes what is often dismissed as "unrealistic" and shows you how to make it your new normal. It shifts you from the metrics of comfort to the math of compounding.

And perhaps most importantly, it reminds you of this: Realistic goals are rarely inspiring. And uninspiring goals rarely transform businesses—or lives.

So if you're a business owner who wants to stop inching forward and start leaping. . . .

If you're an entrepreneur or leader who's ready to break free from the limits of logic and step into the power of strategic audacity. . . .

If you're looking for the clearest, most actionable blueprint I've seen for creating exponential impact. . . .

Then don't just read this book—study it. Digest it. Apply it.

Because this isn't a book about scaling.

It's a book about becoming the kind of person—and building the kind of organization—that can't help but scale.

Step in. The journey starts here.

— **Tony Robbins**, #1 *New York Times* best-selling author, global entrepreneur, investor, philanthropist, and the world's #1 life and business strategist

INTRODUCTION

The Science of Scaling

Am I going crazy?

The President was losing more and more sleep.

He couldn't keep a specific idea out of his head. But it seemed too bizarre. He'd lose his credibility if Congress, and even the country, knew he was taking this seriously.

I think I'll mention it, but just keep it basically an afterthought . . .

Yeah, that's what I'll do.

On May 25, 1961, President John F. Kennedy presented to Congress what he felt were extremely “urgent” national needs. Specifically, he was deeply concerned about the broader state of the world, and whether tyranny or freedom would spread.

For Kennedy, it was an actual *race*—and within the decade, one of these two forces would win out.

In the thick of the Cold War, Kennedy detailed some of the weapons the Soviets were imposing—intercontinental strike forces, large conventional war forces, and a well-trained underground attack force in “nearly every country.”

He stated:

With these formidable weapons, the adversaries of freedom plan to consolidate their territory—to exploit, to control, and finally to destroy the hopes of the world's newest nations; and they have ambition to do it before the end of this decade. It is a contest of will and purpose as well as force and violence—a battle for minds and souls as well as lives and territory. And in that contest, we cannot stand aside.

He then shared with Congress his multipronged approach to winning the race of freedom vs. tyranny before the end of the decade. His considered pathways to win this race included:

1. Promoting economic and social progress at home
2. Promoting economic and social progress abroad
3. Strengthening partnerships of self-defense, such as NATO
4. Increasing military defense and intelligence shields
5. Increasing civil defense
6. Disarmament, or the reduction and withdrawal of military forces and weapons
7. Advancing space exploration

The last item on his list was radically different from the other six more traditional paths to peace and influence.

It seemed out of place, even a distraction.

Yet, advancing space exploration was pressing on Kennedy's mind, even keeping him up at night. Just six weeks prior to this urgent congressional meeting, Yuri Gagarin of the Soviet Union became the first man in outer space. Gagarin spent 108 minutes orbiting the Earth on the *Vostok 1* spacecraft and returned to Earth an instant legend.

"Space" seemed an unlikely path to convert the world to freedom and democracy. But the situation was becoming increasingly fraught to Kennedy. It seemed only extreme measures would suffice, not common ones.

1. *Perhaps, just maybe, doing something big in outer space could garner global attention?*
2. *If the Soviets continue to lead in space innovation, would the world turn to their ideology?*
3. *And if the world does turn to tyranny, what would the repercussions be?*
4. *Could it end freedom as we know it?*

Though Kennedy couldn't keep these thoughts at bay, he still wasn't convinced. Even still, he felt it at least worth mentioning space to Congress. He'd keep it as mostly a footnote, a final concept to the more sensible and likely solutions presented before.

He did point out, though, that space had never really been a priority for the United States, and that perhaps it should be. Regarding space advancement, he stated, "*We have never specified long-range goals on an urgent time schedule, or managed our resources and our time so as to insure their fulfillment.*"¹

A little over a year later, on September 12, 1962, Kennedy made what would become one of the most famous and world-changing speeches of all time.

His speech not only stunned the 40,000 people attending live at Rice University Stadium in Houston, Texas. It also emboldened the entire U.S. and much of the world.

His speech made clear that Kennedy's mind had changed. In his private speech to Congress the year before, space was a fringe and unsure concept.

Now, though, space was *the strategy*.

The super priority.

The crux to winning the "freedom" race before all was lost.

Only "something bold," to use his words, would work.

Rather than trying seven things, only one path was viable enough to spread global freedom, though it wasn't clear they could actually execute on that path.

We choose to go to the moon in this decade . . . because that goal will serve to organize and measure the best of our energies and skills, because that challenge is one that we are willing to accept, one we are unwilling to postpone, and one which we intend to win.²

Kennedy gave NASA 7 years, 3 months, and 18 days to achieve that seemingly impossible goal.

One year after his transformational speech, Kennedy was in Dallas attempting to unify his Democratic party ahead of the 1964 election, where he hoped to be re-elected. Especially in the South, there was tension between various factions of the Democratic party.

To energize the city and their political party, a Democratic motorcade was orchestrated through Dallas. In the center of the long line of cars snaking through the city, Kennedy and his wife, Jacqueline, stood waving from a convertible limousine. Traveling down Elm Street in the Dealey Plaza, Kennedy was shot in the back of the head by a sniper rifle at 12:30 p.m. central time.

He was pronounced dead 30 minutes later at the Parkland Memorial Hospital.

In the country's heartbreak, Kennedy's impossible "moon goal" became the healing balm.

Commitment and conviction converged, increasing the unity and focus of that singular objective.

Five months before the allotted deadline, on July 20, 1969, Neil Armstrong and Buzz Aldrin walked the moon's surface for 21 hours, 36 minutes. They then spent the next 3.5 days returning home to Earth, parachuting and splashing down in the Pacific Ocean near Hawaii.

Kennedy's big bet of "putting a man on the moon and returning him safely" was a reality, and the resultant effect as he intended it.

With such a monumental achievement, all eyes looked to the United States for leadership. Freedom would reign over tyranny.

Politically, the United States was the undisputed global superpower.

Technologically, the United States was the lead innovator. The process of getting to the moon required innovating and developing technologies that continue to impact us today. Things like GPS, smartphones, CAT scans, water purifiers, enriched baby formula, and laptops are all byproducts of Kennedy's moon bet.

From Neil Armstrong's "one small step" through the next 50 years, the United States never looked back, becoming the wealthiest nation in the history of the world. Conversely, Soviet Russia shamefully regressed to the mean, fading from prominence.

This story, of course, isn't new.

Yet, despite this being one of the most commonly cited and cliché leadership and business anthems ever, most people *still miss* the primary lesson from this story. This missed lesson, it turns out, explains why most businesses fail.

A NEW SCALING FRAMEWORK

A goal properly set is halfway reached.

— JOHN DOERR, VENTURE CAPITALIST AND BILLIONAIRE, IN *MEASURE
WHAT MATTERS*³

The purpose of this book is to show you how to scale your business to seemingly impossible levels, and to do so rapidly.

To achieve this aim, I will introduce you to what we call *The Scaling Framework*. Until now, there has never been a clear, evidence-based, and reliable framework for aggressively scaling your business.

The first step of The Scaling Framework can only be understood once you realize what people still get wrong about Kennedy’s speech.

He didn’t just declare some massive vision.

He literally set an impossible goal. And from there, he realized that only the most direct path could work—not multiple paths.

There’s a fundamental difference between a “bold vision” and an “impossible goal.”

Most leaders don’t take Kennedy’s concept to its full conclusion. Sure, they may rah-rah themselves and try something big. But they don’t commit themselves to a seemingly impossible goal. Instead, they set *attainable goals* and expect moon-level results.

Setting attainable goals sets you up for catastrophic failure (and indeed, it is why most businesses fail today). The reason is simple, yet misunderstood.

It’s obvious to people and organizations that they should have goals—even stretching goals. Without goals, you can’t know where to focus. What people fail to comprehend is that *their entire reality*—what they see, what they do, the choices they make, everything—is *filtered by their goals*.

A person’s goals literally drive everything they do and are the core separating factor between humans and other species. This insight is the byproduct of cutting-edge research in both positive psychology and neuroscience.^{4,5,6,7,8}

It may seem counterintuitive, but if you’re pursuing attainable goals, then your business is likely far more complex (and stagnant) than you think. If

you're pursuing attainable goals, you're likely doing many things that are not only ineffective, but damaging.

Goals enable you to filter your experience in the present and make decisions.^{9,10,11,12} Consequently, the goals you set have enormous implications not only in how you operate in the present but also in the direction and results you create.

If you set the wrong goal, you'll be unable to filter the signal from the noise. Your life and business will either stagnate and stall due to complexity or you'll scale in entirely the wrong direction.

For attainable goals, the perceptual filter is too dull to separate the signal from the noise. With such goals, you can't filter and find the most powerful pathways forward among the near-countless options you could pursue. Frankly, attainable and linear goals justify you in maintaining not only your existing system and process but also your existing assumptions and beliefs.

Elon Musk has said, **“The most common mistake of a smart engineer is to optimize a thing that should not exist.”**¹³

This quotation effectively encapsulates most businesses, and it's why most won't and can't scale. The majority of what most people are doing is “optimizing [things] that should not exist.” Rarely is a business not only focusing on what matters and what can scale but also systematically weeding out all that “should not exist,” which can never scale.

The majority of entrepreneurs and businesses are mired in complexity and lying to themselves about what's going on. A dear friend, a near billionaire, told me that most entrepreneurs will never scale because they don't stop lying to themselves (much more on this later).

For a goal to be effective, it needs to be a hot knife, not only cutting cleanly through your fears and faulty assumptions but also ripping your entire business to shreds, leaving only the most relevant and scalable signal.

More than something to hit, goals are psychological and strategic *tools* for filtering what matters from what doesn't. When you have a goal that's so big it seems impossible, and a deadline so short it seems absurd, you are forced to:

1. More accurately and honestly filter everything you're currently doing, being left to acknowledge that the majority is a distraction based on sunk cost bias or lack of accountability.

2. More powerfully filter for the most innovative and teleporting pathways (and partners) you otherwise couldn't see or find.

When you commit yourself to a seemingly impossible goal—in both scale and timeline—you quickly see that almost everything in your current business (and possibly your life) is “optimizing [things] that should not exist.”

Though initially humbling, this clear and honest filtering enables you to simplify and remodel what you're doing in a far more scalable way.

In both the management and psychological literatures, “stretch goal” is the common term for these types of goals, though “stretch goals” have rarely been well defined. In a research article titled *The Paradox of Stretch Goals: Organizations in Pursuit of the Seemingly Impossible*, Duke management researcher Dr. Sim Sitkins and colleagues defined a stretch goal as “an organizational goal with an objective probability of attainment that may be unknown but is seemingly impossible given current capabilities (i.e., current practices, skills, and knowledge).”¹⁴

A stretch goal, then, is a *seemingly impossible goal* given your current knowledge and capabilities. From this definition and for the remainder of this book, we will use “impossible goal” as a replacement for “stretch goal.”

Sitkins further states in that article:

Pursuing goals that are seemingly impossible might stimulate exploratory learning specifically because radically new approaches are required, [and] because [impossible goals] involve extreme redefinitions of what an organization is capable of being or achieving, they can capture, shift, and refocus attention.

Dr. Sitkins's remarks highlight a few crucial insights that impact your ability to scale:

1. An impossible goal is one you don't initially know if you can achieve, but is one you currently lack the capability to achieve in this moment.
2. These types of goals involve an “extreme redefinition” of what your organization can be and achieve.

3. Through this redefinition, the attention and focus of your organization shifts to distinctive and unique paths and approaches.

Impossible goals not only redefine what your organization is and can be, but they also force you to more *clearly define* your organization.

They force focus.

Most businesses are not well defined.

Most businesses are diluted, overly complex, and lack clarity.

The Scaling Framework solves these common missteps, and is comprised of three elements:

- Frame
- Floor
- Focus

Your *frame* is what you see, and is **based on your goals**.

Your *floor* is what you filter out, **defining what you don't do**.

Your *focus* is what you filter for, **defining the paths and partners you develop to realize your goal**.

If you're ready to scale, then setting and pursuing a seemingly impossible goal—in both scale and timeline—is the first step. The reason an impossible goal is the first step is because only a goal of that level enables you to filter your current business and future prospects with the rigor needed to scale.

From the reference frame of an impossible goal, *almost nothing will work*. Therefore, such a goal serves as a razor-sharp filter for your current situation and decisions.

Take, for example, Mark Young, a friend of mine. When he learned The Scaling Framework, he immediately saw that his businesses had become diluted, complex, and unscalable. After reading an advance copy of this book in March of 2025, he told me, “Ben, I’m changing all of my companies. From now on, they will all only do one thing.”

One of Mark’s companies, Jeckyll & Hyde Advertising, is an agency that specializes in getting physical consumer products into retail stores like Walmart. They’ve helped hundreds of fledgling products get into retail stores, scale, and often sell for hundreds of millions of dollars.

Take, for example, Wax-Rx, an all-in-one earwax cleaning kit, which came to Jeckyll & Hyde while doing approximately \$1 million in revenue and unable to get into stores like Walgreens. With Jeckyll's help, Wax-Rx 5x'd their sales within nine months, leveraged that success to get into Walgreens, then became the #1 product in its space, now being sold in over 50,000 retail stores throughout the United States.

Mark explained to me that despite being the absolute best in the world at helping people both get into and succeed in retail, that over the previous few years they'd become diluted and unfocused.

"We lowered our floor, offering a broad array of lesser services because people were asking for them."

"What do you mean?" I asked Mark as he explained this to me.

"Well, the truth is: Yes, we began offering cheaper services, such as social media ad campaigns and Amazon product campaigns because people wanted them. But the real reason we lowered our floor and offered many competing services was *fear*. We'd been told that everything was going digital, and we didn't want to be left behind. Our model is based on selling mass retail and scaling our retail products through mass media, which is traditional TV. That's who we are, and no one can compete. And due to fear, we stopped owning that."

At the time Mark read this book, Jeckyll & Hyde Advertising had been around for over 30 years and was doing \$20 million in revenue. Immediately upon finishing the book, he decided that within three years that they'd be doing \$100 million in revenue (more on the psychology of time and extreme deadlines in [Chapter 2](#)). To reach that \$100 million scale-goal, they'd have to raise the floor and eliminate everything muddling their focus. No more optimizing what shouldn't exist.

Mark explained to his team that they were going to eliminate all service offerings outside of who they really were as an agency, at the highest and clearest level. They had 10 clients that were below the floor, utilizing the lesser services they provided.

One of these clients was particularly frustrating, demanding far more time and resources than they were worth. Mark told his team, "This client needs to go away because they don't fit who we are. However, what I will do is explain to them who we really are and give them the opportunity to use us the way they should be using us."

This particular client had an innovative women's make up cleaning solution they were selling on Amazon. They were on a \$4,000 monthly retainer for an Amazon ads service with Jekyll & Hide. Mark told them:

Look, you're wrong in how you're approaching your business. Amazon is a retailer, not a business model. If you keep building your business around Amazon, your business will stagnate and die within 18 to 24 months. If you're going to scale this product, let alone survive, you need to bring \$300,000 to us. We will get you into mass market retail stores and blow your brand up through mass media on TV. You have to make a choice: either play with the big boys or keep grinding out what you're doing for the rest of your life.

Mark's team was shocked that this client, who seemed cheap and stingy, was very open to this much higher and distinct service offering.

Part of what made Mark so convincing was the dead clarity of his impossible goal. That higher frame forced a level of honesty Mark hadn't required of himself, his team, or his clients for years. But given the impossible goal of \$100 million in three years, and the refined definition that he gave to Jekyll & Hyde, Mark's conviction went through the roof.

He knew who they were, what they offered, and what they could do.

He didn't need to apologize about that.

He didn't need to dilute himself by offering lesser things to people who didn't get it. If potential clients weren't ready for the scale Jekyll optimized for, then they were below the floor and rejected.

In the book *Relentless: From Good to Great to Unstoppable*, Tim Grover, the performance coach of NBA superstars like Michael Jordan, Kobe Bryant, and Dwyane Wade, wrote:

Go a different way, excel in another area, while everyone else is just competing for space in the same pool. You don't become unstoppable by following the crowd, you get there by doing something better than anyone else can do it, and proving every day why you're the best at what you do. You must know someone like this: He can do everything. This week he is a blogger and a songwriter and a motivator, last week he was teaching tennis two nights a week and working as a sushi chef. You listen to him and feel as if you've never done a thing in your life.

Until you listen more closely and discover that like a lot of people, this is someone dabbling in a lot of things and succeeding in none . . . I want to hear someone say, “I do *this*.” Ask Kobe what he does, and he says, “I give out numbers.” Numbers? “Yep, I gave them eighty-one, I gave them a triple double, I gave those guys sixty-one.”¹⁵

Operating from an impossible goal *forces you to define yourself*. Most people are afraid to do this, afraid to own their convictions.

Impossible goals are so massive they weed out common thinking, common approaches, and common excuses.

They are a reality check, a gut punch.

Are you serious or not?

Are you clear or not?

If not, then get clear.

Remove everything that shouldn't exist, which you've been maintaining for one reason or another. No more justification.

If you can't say, “We do *this*,” then you're undefined, diluted, and cannot scale.

The primary reason companies don't scale is the same reason people don't scale: *The entrepreneur is lying to themselves*.

Anytime a person goes below the floor, they are unclear on who they are and what they're doing. They're diluting and distracting themselves, and others. They aren't becoming the absolute best at what they do. They aren't making the impact they could be making.

Anytime you go below the floor, you're in the noise. You're making your business complex by doing multiple things at a more mediocre level than you want to admit.

You can't scale a complex system.

You can't scale noise.

You can't scale if you're too afraid to define yourself and commit.

By raising the frame so high and actually establishing a scale-goal, Mark filtered his business and clients far more rigorously. That rigor and honesty transferred directly to how he spoke to his clients.

“Look, this is who we are and what we can do for you. Play big or go somewhere else.”

Because of his extreme clarity, *Mark was no longer noise* to his clients, with their multiple conflicting services. The conviction they now spoke in

defining themselves and their single service was a complete signal to the right people.

No dilution.

No competition.

No competition for two reasons: 1) they really were the best at this, and 2) they spoke with extreme clarity and conviction about what they did, as well as what the client would need to do to succeed. No one else was that clear. Almost everyone else in the market is diluted and unfocused, following the crowd, and offering far too many mediocre products and services.

In a follow-up interview with that client a few days later, the client accepted the new and better plan and wired the \$300,000 initial investment to really blow up their product and brand.

There was another part of Mark's conversation with this client, which reflected Mark's higher floor, honesty, and accountability. He told this client:

I want you to understand: Part of this conversation we're having today is my fault. We did the wrong thing for you. We never should have allowed you to play in this little pool, building your business solely around Amazon. We gave you bad advice, and that's on me. I did it because you came in the door and said, "We can't afford this," and instead of telling you what you needed, we told you what you wanted to hear. We shouldn't have told you what you wanted to hear. We should have told you what you needed to hear. Today, I'm going to tell you what you need to hear, which is that if you don't take this product to mass market and mass retail, then you're going to fail within 18 months or less.

The client got it and is now making much bigger moves to success. Several of their other clients made the same decision.

In less than two weeks of Mark learning The Scaling Framework, Jekyll & Hyde was a radically simpler and clearer system. They'd eliminated all lesser-product offerings that muddled their brand and weakened their power. They'd eliminated all below-the-floor clients that wouldn't or couldn't play at the level Jekyll offered.

And something else happened that shocked the team even further.

It dawned hard on Mark that when they'd lowered their floor as a business, offering a multitude of lesser services, *they stopped filtering for and focusing on* the types of clients they really wanted. With Mark's newfound conviction and intensity, especially as it related to his scale-goal of hitting \$100 million in revenue within three years, he began having some very powerful conversations with potential clients and how he could help them.

One person was a friend who was a big doctor, who offered health supplements and coaching. Mark told this doctor that his supplements, which already did \$10 million in revenue, could be doing \$500 million in revenue if he went for mass market and retail. The doctor wanted to scale and agreed that to do it, they'd have to follow Mark's plan. Within a few days, they got a deal that produced nearly \$10 million in revenue for Jekyll & Hyde.

They were no longer optimizing what shouldn't exist.

They'd simplified their model and focus so they could scale.

And they actually had a scale-goal, which forced a much higher rigor of both strategy and psychology in all they did.

Again, all of this occurred within two weeks of Mark learning and embracing The Scaling Framework. There's a final kicker for Mark that happened during those two weeks, which shocked even him, but told me he really got the message: His commitment to his impossible goal led him to realizing most of his other companies were creating complexity and dilution of focus. He began the process of selling most.

Mark is just one of many case studies we will share with you in this book. Some of the stories are even more profound, like Alicia Ault, who'd spent five years stagnating with her innovative software company, only to scale over 1,000x in a single year applying The Scaling Framework. Or like Stephanie, the CEO of a long time family business that finally got the clarity and confidence to sell off their legacy products and chose a more scalable path, making possible a jump from a low eight-figure revenue to hundreds of millions within a few short years.

My co-author Blake Erickson and I developed The Scaling Framework through training thousands of people just like Mark, and just like *you*, to go from small and stuck businesses to scaling them to a size they could only dream of.

And rapidly.

In fact, as you'll learn later in this book, if you're not scaling aggressively, you are likely dying slowly. There's no in between.

Small and incremental goals, as well as overly long-term goals, are bad filters that enable bad decisions that compound over time, making it increasingly unlikely you'll scale. The longer you wait to scale, the less likely it will happen.

When someone learns The Scaling Framework, whether they're a company doing \$1 million or \$1 billion in revenue, fear often kicks in. Unlike Mark, there is typically a lag of application. It takes a paradigm upgrade to realize and appreciate that what you're currently doing isn't scalable. If you keep doing what you're doing, stagnation is the best scenario. Yet, once a person begins applying the framework, *they immediately start scaling*.

And so will you.

Another friend who read an advance copy of this book, a billionaire and legend in private equity who's been part of hundreds of scaling processes, told us that this book changed his mind on something. Before reading this book, he didn't think scaling was a possibility for most people and most businesses, particularly large enterprises. Yet, in his own words, "The *paradigm shift* this book offers, if fully embraced, can enable any size company to scale—big or small."

The insight that with the right paradigm or frame, anyone can be a visionary leader and scaler surprised him, *and gave him hope*.

He also stated that "this book defines how the best CEOs operate, and shows how to be at the extreme tail of the bell curve. While all forces push a leader and a company to the mean and to security, if a company applies the framework in this book, they'll be at the extreme tail in outcomes and impact." He noted that while reading the book, he reached out multiple times to his family office, which manages multiple billions, and the byproduct was them re-simplifying their focus by making key shifts out of investments and sectors that don't align.

Most who speak of scaling do so tactically. Conversely, this book will reframe your psychology and strategy.

Before you finish reading this book, you'll experience a paradigm shift so profound that it will change how you see everything. You'll realize you've been playing small and operating linearly out of fear. You've been below your floor.

You'll be emboldened to set an impossible goal, and you'll quickly see the power of using that goal to filter everything inside and outside of your business. You'll increase your honesty and rigor, removing many things you've been justifying but no longer can.

What once slowed you down will stop existing.

Your path will become clearer and more distinct.

Your progress and learning will 10x or more.

You'll identify and laser in on crucial insights and innovations no one else is looking for.

You'll find and work with only the best of the best—those who produce 100x to 10,000x the results of the average employee or partner.

Before you finish reading this book, *you'll see everything differently*.

You'll even see how Kennedy could have likely gotten a man on the moon in three years, not seven.

WHERE DID THE SCALING FRAMEWORK COME FROM?

Unfortunately, good strategy is the exception, not the rule.

— DR. RICHARD RUMELT, IN *GOOD STRATEGY BAD STRATEGY*¹⁶

In 2015 during the first year of my PhD in organizational psychology, I started blogging about how to apply psychology to business. Within a few months, my blogs were being read by millions of people monthly. By the time I graduated with my PhD in 2019, I was one of the world's top bloggers and a professional author with a seven-figure training company.

Rather than sticking to the academic path, I went straight into the cutthroat world of business coaching and consulting. In addition to training thousands of leaders in my own program, I also worked directly with some of the top business coaches and leaders in the world.

In that process, I co-authored a trilogy of entrepreneurial strategy books with Dan Sullivan, a man who has coached over 20,000 entrepreneurs in the past 50 years. That trilogy has sold over a million copies. I also wrote a book on the emerging science of “future self,” which became one of the

fastest-selling books in various parts of Asia, including South Korea and Japan.

In mid-2023, after finishing my final book with Dan Sullivan, *10x Is Easier Than 2x*, I felt strongly that I needed to return to the drawing board. Though I'd learned a lot the previous decade in my PhD research, training companies myself, and working with people like Dan, it was clear to me there was still a huge and unresolved problem: *Most people, even those getting guidance and training, don't know how to scale their business.*

Scaling is the exception, not the rule, and even though there were hundreds of gurus and academics teaching this, none of them had clients who consistently were able to achieve results.

This wasn't acceptable to me.

I spent the next two years reading hundreds of books and thousands of research studies on the subjects of business strategy and psychology. In addition to my studies, I continued training thousands more leaders and businesses on my developing insights, seeing consistent patterns and problems emerge as people tried to scale.

Given the obvious rarity of scaling and profound results, it was clear that traditional and popular thinking on both the subjects of *strategy* and *psychology* were muddled, confusing, and even derailing. If someone wanted to learn how to effectively scale a business, it would likely take them years or decades to filter through the endless popular and scientific material on these subjects.

Without question, there is powerful and important research and insights in both of these fields, though often buried in noise or improperly framed. It wasn't my initial intent, but to provide something transformative and effective, it became clear that I'd need to create an entirely new and simplified model. I partnered with Blake Erickson, a world-class leader and trainer, to refine this model.

It's been noted by the Harvard psychologist Dr. Steven Pinker that psychology as a discipline is misorganized and mistaught. The billionaire investor Charlie Munger agreed with Pinker's sentiments, stating, "Psychology [is] significantly daft," and that "a lot has been discovered, but no one mind has put it all together in proper form. And it should be done because it wouldn't be that hard to do—and it's enormously important."¹⁷

Everything here could also be said about strategy.

Buckminster Fuller said, “You never change things by fighting the existing reality. To change something, build a new model that makes the existing model obsolete.”¹⁸

The Scaling Framework is a new but tested and effective model at the intersection of psychology and strategy. Though clean and simple, the strategic insight and application of The Scaling Framework is *extremely rigorous*, and will require you to remodel your thinking and assumptions, as well as your business and team.

Where previous models are overly complex and diluted, The Scaling Framework is specific and intentional: *to help you grow your business bigger and faster than you think possible.*

This book and the framework taught herein marks the beginning of an important movement: *a movement where scaling becomes simplified and normalized.*

By simple we don’t mean easy. There are painful, often heart-wrenching decisions you’ll need to make in order to scale, which you’ve been avoiding. But until you simplify your system and focus, you won’t scale. This book will show you how.

By normalized, what we mean is that this book and framework will make it normal for *millions of businesses to scale*. To this point, the topic of scaling has been made overly complex by academics and bastardized by copywriters and online marketers. The Scaling Framework and this book bring much-needed science, sophistication, and rigor to this crucially important topic.

The promise of this book is clear and simple: *Apply The Scaling Framework and you’ll scale your company bigger and faster than you think possible.*

Now is the time.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

The hefty price for accepting information uncritically is that we go through life unaware that what we've accepted as impossible may in fact be quite possible.

— DR. ELLEN LANGER, HARVARD PSYCHOLOGIST, IN *MINDFULNESS*¹⁹

I wrote this book for leaders who are ready to scale their companies by *10x or more within the next three years*. These are the exact types of leaders we work with in our training company, Scaling.com.

The truth is, most companies aren't ready to scale. Despite an incredibly high ceiling and potential, most keep their floor low and achieve a fraction of what they could have. Their growth is stagnant.

This book will help you grow exponentially. And, in fact, from our view, if you're not scaling exponentially, that tells us you're below your floor. Though requiring courage and conviction, you can do this.

You can scale 10x (or more) within three years.

Are you ready?

There are two groups of businesses that should not read this book.

The first group are those who don't want to aggressively scale. There's nothing wrong with this. Many simply want a lifestyle or passive-income business. These are people who would never establish a true scale-goal, such as reaching 9- to 10-figures revenues in their business at all, let alone in the next few years.

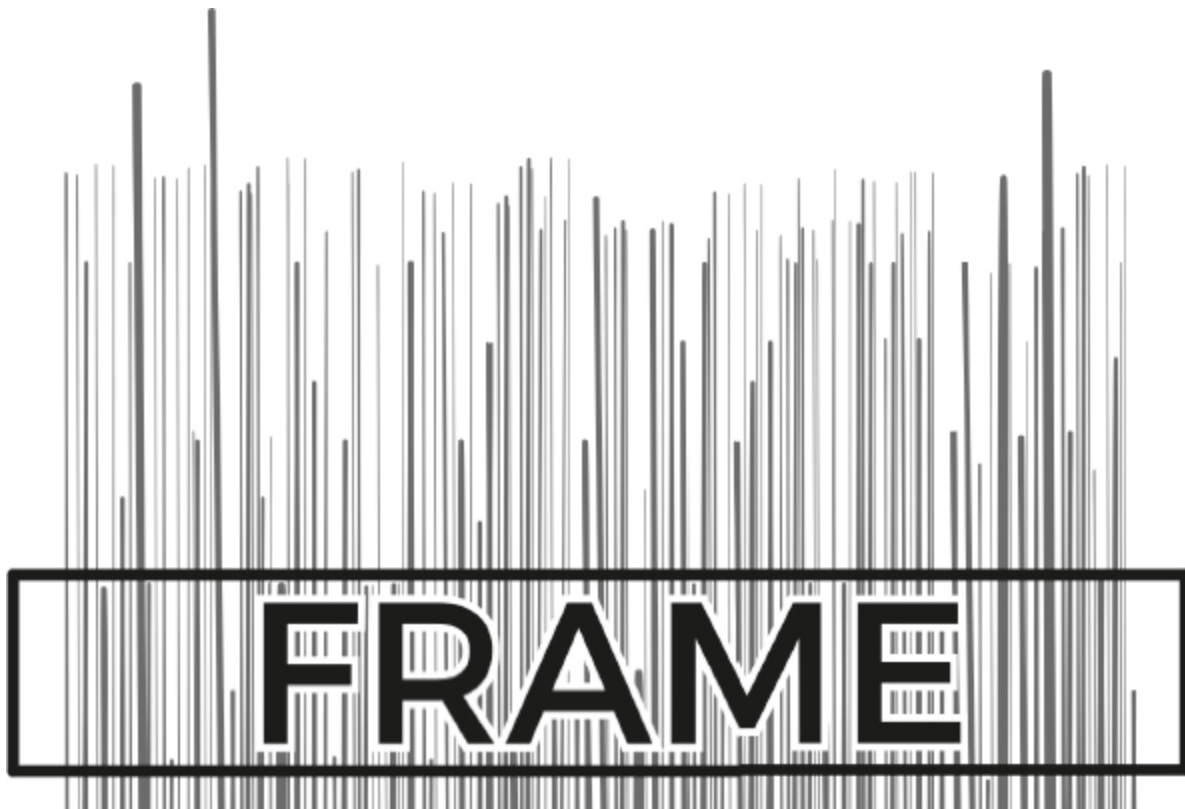
The second group are those lying to themselves, telling themselves they are scaling but are actually stagnant. The most common way this is exemplified is when a leader builds their company around themselves. They are the king or queen of the castle and reflect what Jim Collins describes as "*the leader with 1,000 helpers*."²⁰ Though brilliant and talented themselves, those in this second camp can't scale beyond themselves unless they make the changes needed.

If you're one of those two groups of people, 1) you don't want to scale, or 2) you're building your business around yourself, then either this book

will change your paradigm and elevate your vision, or it's not for you.

To scale in the most effective and efficient way, you'll need a goal so impossible that it forces you out of your existing role, into something simpler and more focused. You'll need a far more innovative path and simplified business. You'll need 10x better people working with you than you have now. All of this you can do.

In summary, if you're ready to scale and willing to remodel your assumptions and business to do so, this book will show you how. It will simplify the scaling process for you, helping you achieve goals that currently seem impossible. If you're not ready or interested, that's okay. *The Science of Scaling* is not for you.



Your frame or perspective determines what you see and is based on your goals. It determines what is relevant and irrelevant. Small or linear goals are an ineffective filter, keeping you stuck in complexity and noise.



When you raise your frame or goal to a seemingly impossible level, almost everything becomes irrelevant, falling below the floor. There are very few, often only one, viable pathways to an impossible goal. Consequently, these types of goals are highly strategic and enable you to filter out dead ends that distract others and to filter for the most potent paths you otherwise couldn't find. Until you face the truth and raise your floor, you're lying to yourself and are caught in the noise. Once you raise your floor and eliminate what shouldn't exist, rapid scaling occurs. The floor defines what you don't do.

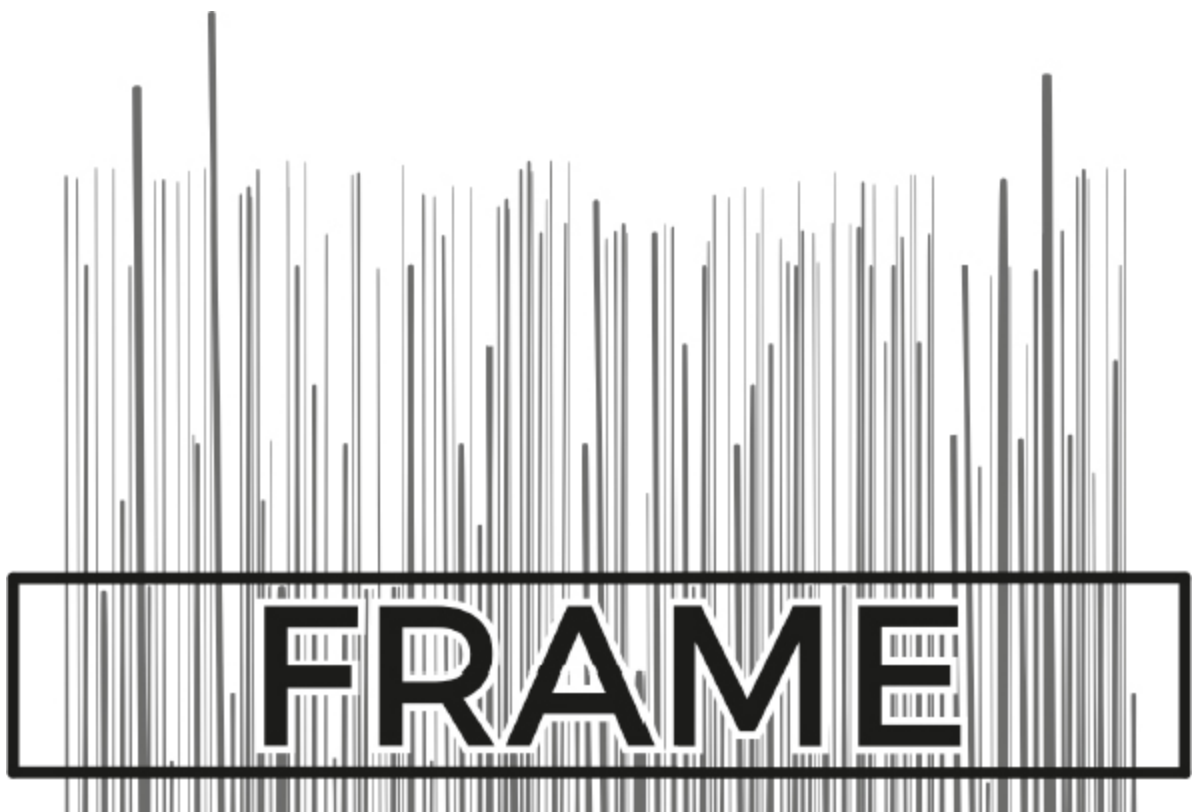


FOCUS

To effectively scale, you build a simple system focused on the highest signal. You cannot scale a complex and contradicting system. Most people and most companies are unwilling to choose a focused path.

PART 1

CHANGE YOUR FRAME



CHAPTER 1

Set a Goal So Big You Think It's Impossible

Even today few [businesspeople] understand that research, to be productive, has to be the “disorganizer,” the creator of a different future and the enemy of today. In most industrial laboratories, “defensive research” aimed at perpetuating today predominates.

— PETER DRUCKER, IN *THE EFFECTIVE EXECUTIVE*¹

Alicia Ault had been working in the credit industry for 20 years—since 2004. Primarily, her business was one-on-one coaching, helping people improve their credit scores to achieve their financial goals.

What set Alicia apart was her extensive expertise and in-depth knowledge of the credit industry.

By 2009, just five years into her career, Alicia began envisioning a software solution that could fill critical gaps in the credit industry—offering consumers an easier, more transparent way to improve their credit and achieve financial goals.

At the time, there was no simple, affordable solution giving clients a step-by-step plan to reach their financial goals—whether that goal was buying a home, financing a car, consolidating debt, or lowering interest rates. Instead, the industry relied on about 50,000 expensive “credit repair” companies that often started by disputing negative items on credit reports. While disputes might provide a quick boost, they rarely helped clients achieve lasting results or financial success. Most clients were left paying high fees without improving their long-term creditworthiness.

Alicia's idea was to create a software solution beginning with the client's specific financial goal, then analyzing their credit report and score to generate a customized action plan. The plan would include step-by-step instructions and vetted resources—such as secured credit cards or credit-building loans—to help them reach their goal.

Although a groundbreaking concept, like many innovative ideas, it remained an idea in Alicia's mind for nearly 10 years before she took action.

By 2019, after a decade of additional experience and working with thousands of clients, Alicia decided it was time to bring her idea to life. She partnered with a skilled software developer, and together they built LevelUp Score—the tool she knew could transform the credit repair process and empower anyone looking to improve their credit and financial situation.

Even after building the most innovative credit repair tool in the industry, Alicia was overwhelmed in her coaching business, managing day-to-day responsibilities, and raising her kids. She was too busy in the grind of maintaining her business and personal life that she had no room to scale LevelUp Score.

By early 2024, it smacked her in the face that her “busyness” was stopping her from advancing in her life.

She was stagnating, not scaling.

She was below the floor.

While talking to a friend, Alicia was asked why she worked so hard. Alicia responded, “I work hard so that one day I don't have to work so hard.”

Hearing those words out loud shocked Alicia. She realized she had said the exact same phrase 20 years earlier at the start of her career.

Now, 20 years in, Alicia was disturbed to find herself still stuck in the same busy rut. But this time was different—she had LevelUp Score and a reliable partner who ensured the software stayed up-to-date with evolving trends, regulations, and demands in the credit and financial industry.

Following that pivotal conversation, Alicia committed to promoting LevelUp Score and introducing it to the market.

In between coaching calls in her primary business, as well as in the evenings and on weekends, Alicia reached out to credit repair companies. She personally explained how LevelUp Score worked, provided hands-on walk-throughs to demonstrate its value, and showed how it could streamline their processes while delivering better results for their clients.

She had a 100 percent conversion rate.

Every time she spoke with someone from a credit repair company, they immediately recognized how LevelUp Score could enhance their services and provide greater value to their clients. An obvious game changer.

Unlike traditional services that offer dispute resolution and little other instruction, LevelUp Score provided tailored action plans for just \$3 per output. In addition to the step-by-step plan for the clients, the embedded affiliate resources—such as credit-building tools and financial products—created additional revenue streams for credit repair companies. This added value increased client lifetime value (LTV) and generated additional income through affiliate links, making it both affordable for the client and highly profitable for credit repair companies.

By the end of March 2024, 10 credit repair companies were actively using LevelUp Score with their clients, generating \$200 in monthly revenue to LevelUp Score. Though it wasn't much, Alicia knew she was on to something.

At the beginning of Q2, 2024, Alicia joined our training program and learned The Scaling Framework. In the onboarding process, she committed to achieving a seemingly impossible goal within 90 days.

Alicia set her impossible goal as having 100 credit repair companies using LevelUp Score by the end of Q2. She figured that, although it would be a stretch given her busy schedule, she could find the time for the 90 to 100 calls it would take.

Quickly, though, Alicia realized her “impossible goal” wasn't really *impossible*.

Despite it being a big jump, going from 10 to 100 clients in only 90 days, this goal only meant being a lot *busier*. On top of everything she was already doing, including her full-time coaching business, she now had the weight of 100 or so cold calls to accomplish.

It was painful and mind-numbing even to consider.

Alicia's 100-client goal was *linear*, not “impossible.”

An *impossible goal* is one you don't know how to reach, and one that requires radically new approaches and paths to realize. These goals redefine what your company can be, and force you to more powerfully define who you are, what you do, and who you serve.²

As Alicia learned more of the science of impossible goals, and the fact that her future was the primary force shaping her life, she realized her

“impossible goal” of 100 clients in 90 days didn’t meet the criteria of seeming *impossible*.

It didn’t disrupt and simplify her present.

It only made her present more crowded and noisier.

Alicia decided to embrace the concept of impossible goals and take a bold step. Instead of aiming for 100 credit repair companies using LevelUp Score by the end of Q2 2024, she committed to 1,000 companies using it—10 times her original goal.

“As soon as I changed that goal to a thousand, I knew there was absolutely no way I’d be able to reach it with my current situation. There was no way. It was very impossible for me,” she told me on a follow-up call a few months after her initial 90-day onboarding process. *“It was so impossible that my current thinking and approach wouldn’t get me there.”*

After setting her 1,000-client goal, Alicia sat down and journaled as many possible ways she could think of to make it happen. Admittedly, in her own words, “Most of my ideas were really bad, like posting in Facebook groups for credit repair companies.”

But she was trying.

One day, while thinking about her impossible goal, a pathway came to her in the form of a question: *“Why aren’t you calling software companies that are already marketing to your market?”*

It suddenly became clear to Alicia that several software companies in the credit industry were already serving the exact audience she wanted for LevelUp Score. Companies like SmartCredit and MyFreeScoreNow provided credit monitoring tools to credit repair businesses and directly to consumers—making them ideal partners to expand LevelUp Score’s reach.

If she wanted to get to 1,000 credit repair companies using LevelUp Score in just 10 weeks, a viable pathway would be partnering with some of these software companies. Maybe even just one could get her to 1,000 clients.

Initially, she was too afraid to call these companies. *They’re way bigger than me*, she thought. *They won’t want to talk to me.*

A few days into her fear and hesitation, Alicia was on one of her “one-off” cold calls with a credit repair company, walking them through LevelUp Score. The person she spoke with was immediately impressed and committed to integrate LevelUp Score into their process. Not only that—he also offered to connect Alicia with a dozen or so contacts at other credit repair companies who he knew would be just as excited about the software.

Alicia graciously accepted this man's offer, but then told him about her desire to partner with software companies to expand LevelUp Score's reach to thousands—or even tens of thousands—of credit repair companies. The man quickly responded, “I have someone for you,” and introduced her to a friend who owned a credit software company called Credit Repair Junkies. Their software was already being used by over 8,000 credit repair companies to manage and improve their client experience.

The very next day, Alicia was on a call with the owner of Credit Repair Junkies.

At first, he was skeptical, assuming Alicia was trying to sell him something. However, after listening to his needs and learning more about his company, Alicia introduced LevelUp Score—not as a competing product, but as a complementary tool that could be integrated into his software to significantly enhance its value and service.

The man's quiet response was, “*This is going to be big.*”

“Yeah, I know,” Alicia humbly replied.

With over 8,000 clients, each potentially generating 100-plus outputs per month using LevelUp Score, he immediately saw the potential. Integrating it into his software wouldn't just enhance services for his clients—it could also generate nearly \$1 million in monthly recurring revenue for his business.

With one conversation, Alicia secured a deal that could scale LevelUp Score from 10 credit repair companies to over 8,000. The partnership opened the door to massive growth and positioned LevelUp Score for industry-wide impact.

Ten clients to 8,000+ in a single conversation, through a single partner.

Alicia's impossible goal enabled her to filter and find a powerfully scalable pathway. Through that better path, she created more progress and growth in LevelUp Score than if she'd spent almost a decade with her previous approach making cold calls.

Impossible goals are powerful because they *require* the most innovative pathways. Dr. Denise Rousseau, a Carnegie Mellon management researcher, wrote:

[Impossible goals] motivate high performance by mandating creativity and assumption-breaking thinking. . . . Where performance expectations are elevated well beyond the limits of past experience . . . and where previously successful frameworks are questioned, revised, or discarded, prior experience is often a poor guide for [impossible]-goal

achievement . . . [and this] shifts the performers' attention away from old routines and assumptions toward novel and creative approaches.³

“Once I had that conversation,” Alicia told me, speaking of her call with the owner of Credit Repair Junkies, “I had no problem calling anybody.”

Alicia quickly expanded her reach even further by partnering with another software company with another 8,000 users—similar to Credit Repair Junkies. She also caught the attention of the largest credit repair software company, which serves approximately 25,000 users, further positioning LevelUp Score for massive growth in the industry.

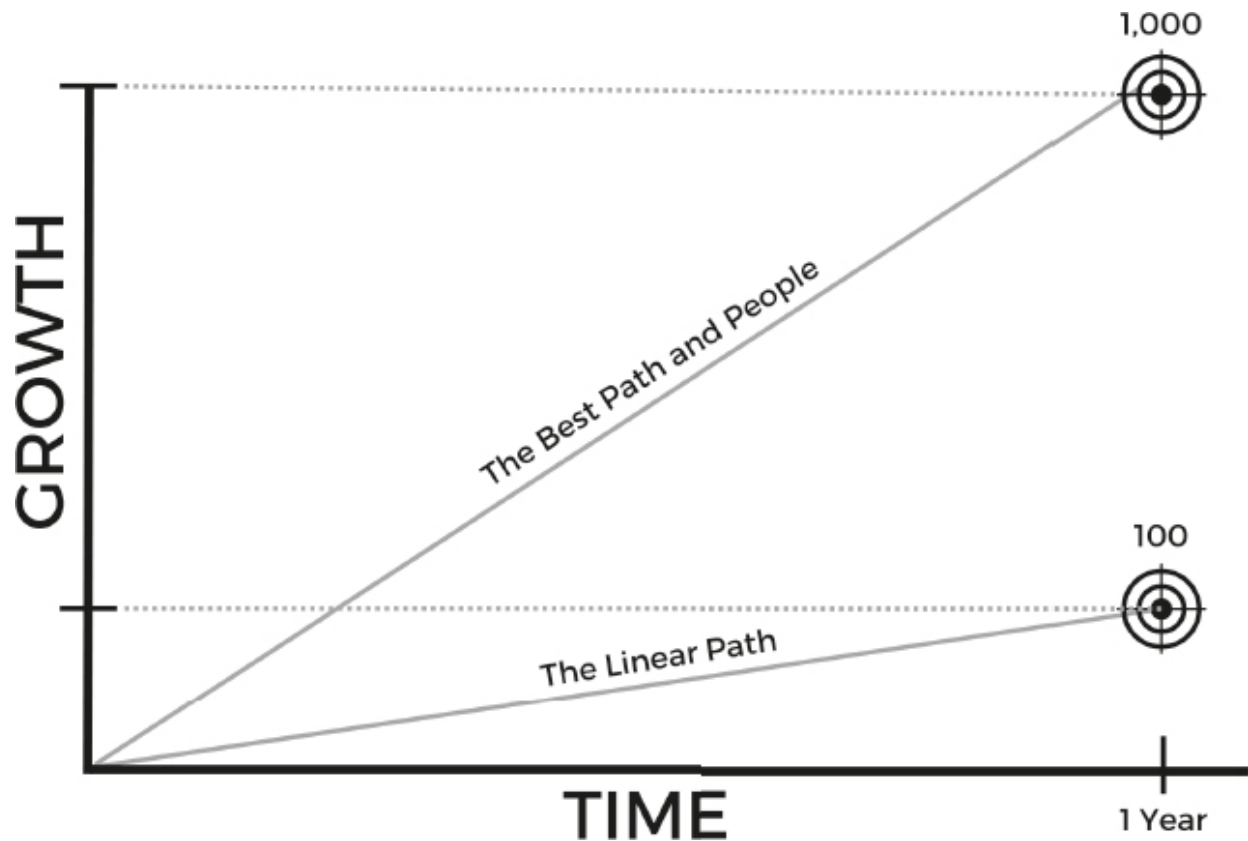
By the end of 2024, Alicia sold her prior coaching business, which she'd had for over 20 years. LevelUp Score was making waves in the entire credit repair industry, with tens of thousands of credit repair companies using it monthly.

Beyond that, Alicia also recognized a new pathway for scaling—partnering with banks and credit unions. One large credit union agreed to implement LevelUp Score and is currently in the process of integration through all their branches. This is facilitating broader adoption within the financial sector.

Her objective for the next few years is to scale LevelUp Score so that it becomes a trusted tool used by banks and credit unions across the United States, as well as by the majority of credit repair companies.

In a single year, LevelUp Score went from sitting on the proverbial shelf to having tens of thousands of users and generating millions in revenue. Alicia's profound growth was made possible because she committed to an impossible goal, which she used to filter and find more potent paths and partners.

The remainder of this chapter will help you better understand why impossible goals are such a valuable and crucial element of scaling. It will challenge you to elevate your thinking *much bigger*. The seemingly impossible goal will force you to more aggressively filter your focus and enable you to create the best path you otherwise couldn't have taken.



The goal shapes the process. When you change the goal, you change the process. Making your goal massive—even seemingly impossible—forces you to find a much better path, including more effective partners.

CLARIFYING THE SCIENCE (AND POP SCIENCE) OF GOAL-SETTING

You can expect the future to take a definite form or you can treat it as hazily uncertain. If you treat the future as something definite, it makes sense to understand it in advance and to work to shape it. But if you expect an indefinite future ruled by randomness, you'll give up on trying to master it. Indefinite attitudes to the future explain what's most dysfunctional in our world today. Process trumps substance: when people lack concrete plans to carry out, they use formal rules to assemble a portfolio of various options.

Before we go further into *The Science of Scaling*, Alicia's story highlights the importance of clarifying the confusing and even controversial subject of "goals" and goal-setting. There is much debate on the subject, as well as countless theories and myths.

Due to a lack of more foundational understanding, there are four common mistakes people make in regard to goal-setting:

1. They avoid explicit goal-setting altogether.
2. They set low and achievable goals due to fear of failure.
3. They avoid the reality of trade-offs and opportunity cost while pursuing conflicting goals.
4. They pursue and even can succeed in the wrong goals.

These common mistakes make it incredibly difficult and unlikely for a company to scale. Only the fourth point above can lead to scaling, but unfortunately the scaling of the wrong thing, which can be just as costly as not scaling at all.

In breaking down these four common and ineffective approaches to goals, I will explain the deeper science of psychology and systems dynamics. By so doing, you'll more fully appreciate the unique and distinctive power of committing to the right impossible goal.

With the right impossible goal, you'll be enabled to simplify both your system and your focus, such that scaling aggressively is the natural byproduct.

Mistake #1: Avoiding (or claiming to avoid) goal-setting altogether:

Because goal-setting is a highly complex subject, and because there are a lot of emotions associated with pursuing, missing, and hitting goals, many have concluded that having "no goals" at all is the higher and more enlightened way. Consider the words of the Stoic author, Ryan Holiday, from

his 2024 blog post entitled, “This Is Why I Don’t Have Goals (and What to Do Instead)”:

I don’t have goals. I know that might seem a little crazy, but it’s true. . . . I don’t fault other people for having goals—if that’s what motivates you, enjoy. . . . They’re just not for me. I’m much more focused on process. That is to say, I focus on doing the thing as opposed to achieving some particular thing. . . . You don’t have to end up number one in your class. Or win everything, every time. In fact, winning is not particularly important. What matters is that you gave everything, because anything less is to cheat the gift. The gift of your potential. The gift of the opportunity. The gift of the craft you’ve been introduced to. The gift of the responsibility entrusted to you. Immerse yourself in the work, in the process, in the daily practices that make up the bulk of your life. Forget goals. Be process-oriented. Be internally driven. Be Every Day.⁵

Holiday’s advice of “not having goals” is quite common among people *who have already reached the mountaintop of their goals*. From their vaulted position, they’re content with where they are at. They also realized that hitting their goals didn’t actually make them happy, and that happiness is an inside game. They then inappropriately associate unhappiness with the setting and pursuing of goals.

Interestingly, two years prior to the quote above, Holiday wrote in his 2022 book, *Discipline Is Destiny*, “If we didn’t have ambition—some big goal we are after—how would we know what little things, what distractions, to say no to?”⁶ Though clashing with his more recent musings, this second statement is not only more accurate and effective, but also more truthful.

I say truthful, because in reality, *it is impossible for a person to not have goals*. Even Holiday.

Truth #1: Psychologically, everything a person sees and does is based on their goals:

All human action is goal-driven, even if the goal is simply to “relax.”⁷ This is a fairly cutting-edge psychological insight: that our actions and decisions are *based far more on our future than our past*. More directly, our

actions and direction—as well as our motivation and meaning—in the present are *based on our goals*.⁸

Research shows that we spend huge amounts of our time considering our future and the paths forward we will take.⁹ The psychological term for thinking about the future is *prospection*.^{10,11} We weigh nearly countless prospects or options for our future, and then generate viable pathways to those prospects.¹² Ultimately, we make decisions about directions we will take and pathways to get there. Of this, the clinical psychologist Dr. Jordan Peterson explained:

All of our perceptions are biased, and they're biased toward our goals. When you look at the world, basically what you see is a pathway forward to a goal that you're pursuing. And then you see the things in the world that will either help you along that pathway or get in your way. Everything else is turned into irrelevance. Obviously, when we look at the world, we don't see most of it. We see what's right in front of us. But more specifically, we see a pathway to a goal, and things that move us towards that and things that get in the way.¹³

Pathways thinking is a person's ability to find or create multiple pathways to a goal.^{14,15} The better a person gets at pathways thinking, the faster their progress. The first step of pathways thinking, or strategy, is realizing that the goal you set determines the pathways you'll take.

Pathways thinking relies on an even deeper psychological insight known as *selective attention*, which is our human ability to mentally filter for the most relevant information while ignoring all other data.^{16,17} Put simply, the quality and clarity of your goal, as well as your commitment to it, shapes both what you see and the actions you take.^{18,19,20}

Mistake #2: Setting low and achievable goals due to fear of failure:

Psychologically, the future is not an external reality. Instead, the future is a *mental tool* we use to direct our attention and decisions *in the present*. Goals, then, are simply a tool used to guide our filtering and decisions here and now.

For a goal to be an effective tool, it must be an intense filter. The goal must force you to be far more rigorous and honest with yourself about everything you're currently doing.

To restate John Doerr's brief and accurate remark, "A goal properly set is halfway reached."²¹ The reason a goal properly set is halfway reached is because the right goal immediately enables you to bypass the majority of dead-ends, distractions, and noise that could otherwise derail you. Moreover, the right goal enables you to filter and find the most effective pathways forward.

Returning to Alicia's story: It wasn't until she committed to the goal of getting LevelUp Score "out there" that she began prioritizing it. In early 2024, she began making cold calls and introducing credit repair companies to it. It's important to note that her process was generating exactly the outcome she was committed to—"getting LevelUp Score out there."

It wasn't until she learned the science of impossible goals through The Scaling Framework that her process radically shifted. In early Q2 of 2024, she decided to 10x her clientele and have 100 clients using LevelUp Score within 90 days.

She quickly realized that goal lacked the power to transform her process and business. So, she 10x'd the goal, pushing it into the boundaries of "impossible goal" territory.

For her to have 1,000+ clients using LevelUp Score within 90 days would require a radical new approach to anything she was then doing or considering.

Yet, in thinking and operating from the goal, rather than toward the goal, it dawned on her that a viable pathway could be partnering with other software companies that already serve thousands of credit repair companies. Within weeks of that insight, LevelUp Score was being utilized by thousands of credit repair companies.

Not all goals are created equal.

The purpose of goals is to filter decisions, remove dead-end distractions, and enable you to find the most powerful paths you otherwise couldn't.

Low goals, then, are a bad modeling of the future because they aren't effective filters.

Low goals don't enable you to separate the signal from the noise.

They don't enable you to find the most effective pathways forward, as Alicia was able to do once she established a seemingly impossible goal and

deadline.

Truth #2: Goals are the driver and shaper of all human systems:

Not only do our goals shape our psychology, but our goals are also what shape the systems we built—whether the systems of our businesses, families and societies, or our own habits and processes. Of this, the Harvard systems scientist, Dr. Donella Meadows, wrote in her classic text, *Thinking in Systems*:

One of the most powerful ways to influence the behavior of a system is through its purpose or goal. That's because the goal is the direction-setter of the system, the definer of the discrepancies that require action, the indicator of compliance, failure, or success toward which balancing feedback loops work . . . Systems, like the three wishes in the traditional fairy tale, have a terrible tendency to produce exactly and only what you ask them to produce. Be careful what you ask them to produce . . . If the goals are defined inaccurately or incompletely, the system may obediently work to produce a result that is not really intended or wanted . . . Be especially careful not to confuse effort with result or you will end up with a system that is producing effort, not result.^{[22](#)}

A system is simply the organization of efforts and processes toward a specific outcome. The goal is the why and what; the system is the how and who.

In order to generate an effective system, you've got to start by specifying the right outcome. If you have several competing outcomes, what you'll have is a *complex system* going in several different directions.

You cannot scale a complex system. If you have multiple competing goals, you have a complex system that won't scale.

If you have the wrong goal or an unclear goal, then your system will produce either the wrong outcome or an undesirable outcome.

The purpose of establishing an effective and powerful goal is that it immediately simplifies both your focus and your system. If you want to scale, you must have a clear focus and a simple system that effectively produces the desired result.

Mistake #3: Avoiding the reality of trade-offs and opportunity cost while pursuing conflicting goals:

If you have several competing outcomes, what you'll have is a complex system going in several different directions. This is the state of most businesses and organizations. They're radically unclear on what they're actually trying to accomplish and are unwilling to let go of lesser goals in service of higher ones.

The author Robert Brault wrote, "We are kept from our goal not by obstacles, but by a clear path to a lesser goal."²³

When you set an impossible goal, it forces you to reckon with your conflicting and lesser goals. For example, one early reader of this book, a successful entrepreneur in real estate, told me that after reading *The Science of Scaling*, he clarified his impossible goal. It was owning a huge number of rental properties in a particular category within three years.

I asked him, "With a goal that big, how much growth does that reflect on your current trajectory?"

"That's about ten to twenty years of growth on my current path," he replied.

I then asked, "Do you see a pathway to get there in three years?"

"I think so," he replied. "I'd have to get really good at getting funding."

He then said, "I really want to do a podcast. I think that might be a viable pathway to hitting my goal."

I pushed back, "Tell me more. In what way do you think having a podcast can get you the funding you need for such an aggressive and massive goal? Are you sure that's a viable pathway? Or is that a lesser goal you're not sure you can let go of?"

"Um, I'm not sure. I think the podcast would more be for people who are already in my network, as a way for me to build trust," he said, unsure.

"I'm not telling you what you should or shouldn't do," I continued. "I'm just wanting you be very honest and rigorous with yourself. With an impossible goal at the level you've stated, you can't justify weak pathways or distractions. You embrace decision, rather than stall it."

I could see he was really thinking about it.

"Look," I said, "you have to ask yourself: Do you want the ten thousand units within three years or do you want the podcast? You probably can't have both, unless you can absolutely say the podcast is essential to the goal."

He wasn't yet ready to make that decision.

Whenever you see a person or a business doing many different things, what you are seeing is a complex system that lacks the ability to scale in a meaningful direction. The deeper thing you see is a person or group without clarity of purpose and unwilling to truly define their purpose and objective.

In order to create a simple system that can scale, you've got to establish a singular and specific goal or frame.

You cannot scale a complex system.

Truth #3: Committing to a seemingly impossible goal forces you to redefine who you are, simplify your focus, and become the best at what you do:

An *impossible goal* is so high (or urgent) that almost nothing you're currently doing is relevant, and therefore falls below the floor.

It's a singular goal that forces out all ineffective pathways and processes.

It forces a higher degree of honesty and transparency in all that you do.

It forces you to first simplify and then focus solely on the paths and partners that have efficacy to the higher goal.

April Graves is a great example of this. April is a high-end photographer and owner of Light Dawn Studios. Before applying The Scaling Framework, her average large wall art pieces went for approximately \$8,000.

In early 2024, April wanted to differentiate herself further from the thousands of other photographers in her market. She began exploring different art forms, and how she could combine those in a mixed-media format with her photography. Oil painting really stood out to her, and she decided to study and develop her skills there.

In Q4 of 2024, April joined our training program and learned The Scaling Framework. Before joining, she'd successfully signed two oil-painted photography commissions. While an exciting achievement, this was a very small percentage of her business at the time.

April decided to set the goal of raising her average commission from \$8,000 to \$10,000, but then quickly realized this linear goal wasn't strong enough to change her system and process. So, she raised the goal of having the average commission of her business be \$15,000 before the end of 2024 (within 90 days). At the time, this felt impossible to her.

The immediate effect of setting this single impossible goal was, in April's own words, "I had far more clarity and peace."

The byproduct of the goal was that she could no longer do the dozens of different photography forms and sizes she offered. At that price point, she could no longer cater to a wide variety of clients. She felt she could only sell one concept: her new oil-painted photographs. Thus, the new goal forced her to simplify her business model and stop offering her many previous product offerings.

The same day she set that goal, April secured her first \$15,000 commission. Within two months, over 50 percent of her revenue was oil-painted photography. She was no longer offering her former concepts. As she explained to me in a follow-up interview:

I have spent much of my professional career seeking ways to improve both my art and my business skills, attending conferences in my industry along with consuming book after book and eventually hiring a coach. The coach I had encouraged me and my team to set goals for each genre of photography that we worked within. At the time, I had many different types of portrait options and sizes, from fairy-tale sessions that encompassed fairies, angels, aviators, princesses, and unicorns, to family sessions, head shots, and high school seniors. By setting goals for each session type, I was essentially saying I would take \$X dollars for this type and \$Y for the next. I was spreading myself and my team thin and optimizing for varying goals. For instance, I had an annual goal to photograph 20 fairy sessions. I also had prospecting goals, such as 100 portrait sessions. I had a goal for each aspect of the business. By changing to optimize for one goal, the \$15,000 average sale with a mixed-media piece at the core of the sale, I no longer have to set my numbers based on session type. That one goal simplified everything in my business.

In simplifying her business model from dozens of products to one, April reframed her business and far more clearly redefined herself and what she offered. Rather than a photographer, it was more accurate to define herself as an artist, and she quickly began to be seen that way by others, even highly reputable artists in her Chicago area.

During that interview, I asked April how changing her goal improved her process. She replied:

My process improved dramatically. It felt so much more authentic. I've been able to be a lot more thoughtful about who I work with. I'm far clearer about what I'm offering, and why it's unique and special. I was confusing people with too many options. I'm able to go so much deeper into the process with those I work with, and I simply enjoy what I'm creating a lot more. Charging the higher fee really pushes my creativity and the standards of my work, and I've gotten so much better at what I do in just two months. It's not even comparable.

By setting a much higher goal—one that she initially felt impossible—April reframed who she was and what she did in a much clearer and more specialized way. She became far more *defined* in her work, and she could more clearly say, “We do *this*.” Not “We do these twenty things.”

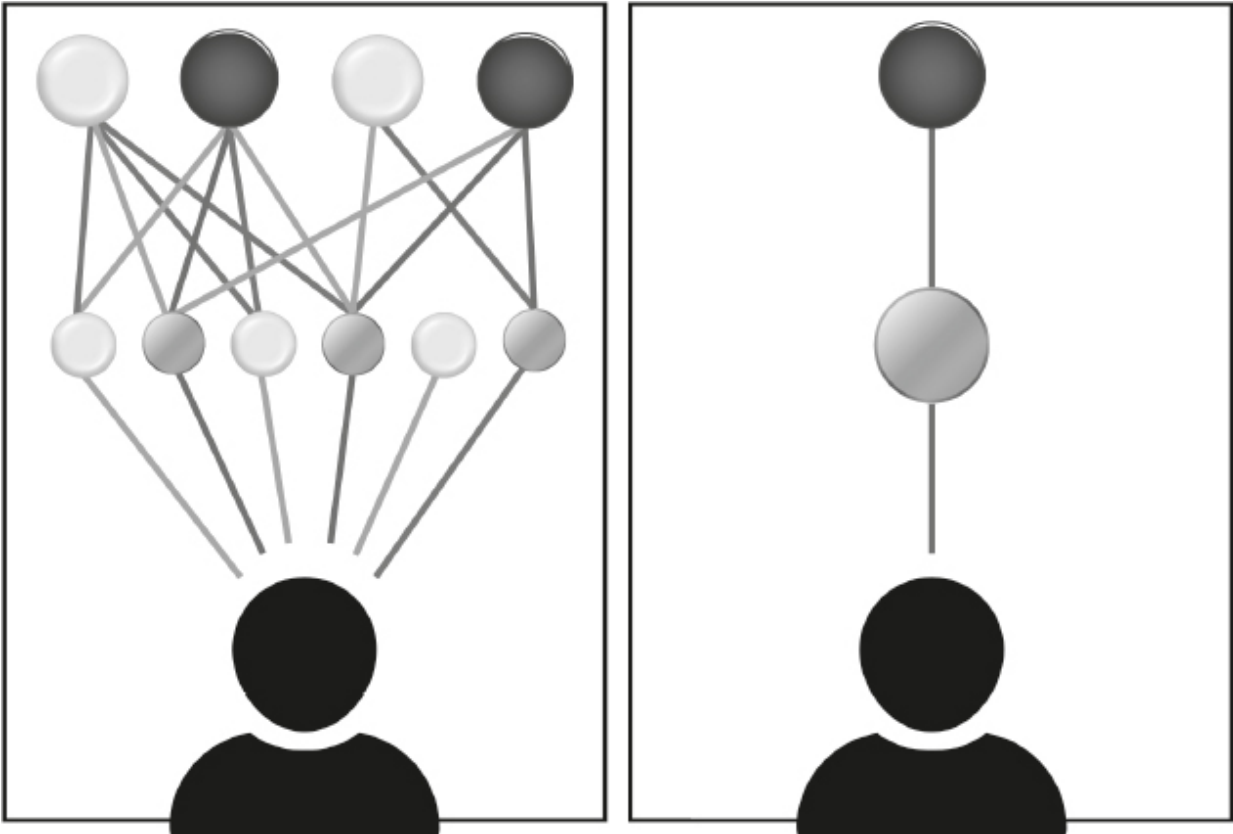
If you're doing several competing things, you're undefined.

If you're undefined, you have a complex system that can't scale.

If you have a complex system that can't scale, your work is far from world-class.

In Seth Godin's book *The Dip*, Godin explains the importance of becoming the best in the world at what you do. The returns are 10x or more for being #1 vs. being #10 in most domains, Godin explains.^{[24](#)}

To be the best in the world, you've got to eliminate all the noise in your life—what Godin calls “dead ends.” You stop optimizing dead ends that shouldn't exist, and instead, you go through “the dip” of mastering what will make you the best in the world at what you do.



The goals you have shape your process and system. Complex systems have many competing priorities and agendas, and countless constraints or bottlenecks to solve. You cannot scale a complex system. In order to scale, you have a singular objective that's framed so well it makes obvious the many things you're now doing that could never reach the goal. The right impossible goal enables you to simplify your system and path such that you can scale 10x to 100x within the next three years. The question is, are you willing to commit to your convictions, or will you remain diluted and unfocused?

Mistake #4: Pursuing and even hitting the wrong goal:

Optimizing for the wrong thing is just as ineffective as optimizing for many things, and may even be more destructive. Given that our psychological reality as well as the systems we create are based on our goals, it's vital that we select the right goal.

If you have too many competing goals, you'll have a complex system that can't meaningfully scale but will instead stagnate. If you choose the wrong goal, you will scale in the wrong direction.

A prime example of the latter is Steve Balmer, who was CEO of Microsoft from 2000 to 2014. Despite having much of the technology in-

house that would eventually become the iPhone, Balmer optimized Microsoft for increasing shareholder value. He did this by defending and prioritizing their Windows products. In 2007, when the iPhone came out, Balmer even laughed, stating, “There’s no chance that the iPhone is going to get any significant market share. No chance.”²⁵

He succeeded in his aim, increasing annual revenues from \$25 to \$70 billion, as well as increasing net income by 215 percent to 23 billion. Yet, it’s been noted, even by himself, that he was likely optimizing for the wrong thing and that, despite succeeding in his aim, it likely cost Microsoft 5x to 10x what they could have gained.

The market value of Microsoft dropped from \$600 billion in 2000 to \$350 billion in 2014. Under Balmer’s leadership, the overall value of the company stagnated as the company failed to make key shifts in mobile computing.

In 2014, after Balmer stepped down, Satya Nadella became CEO. Nadella shifted Microsoft’s focus back to growth, focusing on cloud computing, AI, and service-based subscriptions. By leading in these markets, Microsoft’s market value has nearly 10x’d, now valued at over \$2 trillion.

Key point: Choose the right metric to optimize for, or even if you do succeed in your aim, it will have been a very costly “success.”

Market Summary > Microsoft Corp

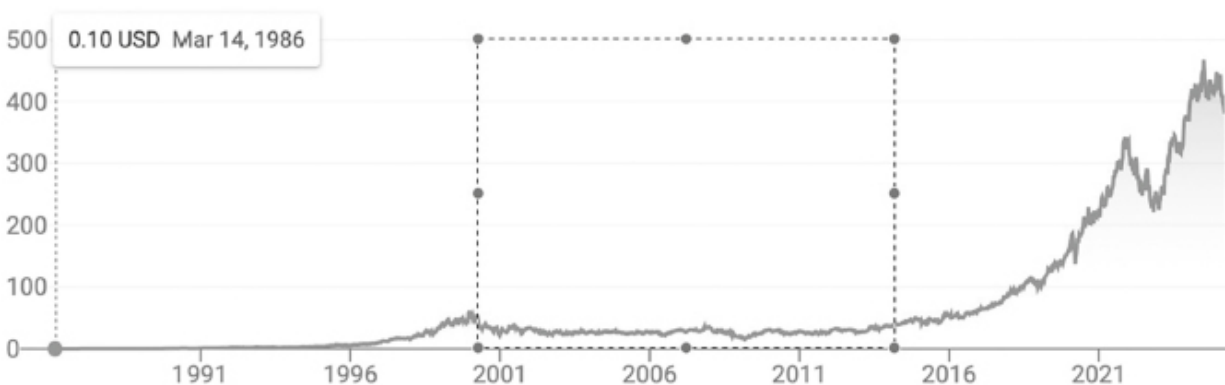
383.27 USD

+383.17 (383,170.00%) ↑ all time

Closed: Mar 13, 8:39 AM EDT • Disclaimer

Pre-market 382.50 -0.77 (0.20%)

1D | 5D | 1M | 6M | YTD | 1Y | 5Y | Max



From 2000 to 2014, Microsoft's market value stagnated under Steve Balmer's leadership as CEO. Though he effectively increased the profitability of the company and value for stockholders, Balmer's priority cost Microsoft 5x to 10x what he gained them in lost opportunity.

Truth #4: Committing fully to the right impossible goal leads to the most innovative process and the highest form of leadership:

Bringing this conversation full circle, we will detail some insights from Josh Waitzkin, a globally recognized chess prodigy and learning expert. During a conversation with Dr. Andrew Huberman about the neuroscience of *performance*, Josh shared his regret in confusing many people about this subject. As he stated, "One of the things I feel badly about is: When I wrote *The Art of Learning*, I spoke a lot about process and outcome, and it had a big impact in the chess world. Then what happened was there were generations of parents who had young kid chess players who would go to compete and the parents would say it doesn't matter if you win or lose. All that matters is the process."²⁶

Waitzkin then explained both the contradiction of this "all that matters is the process" and the confusion it generated. It was a contradiction because it was dishonest. Of course the outcome mattered. These were kids at elite chess tournaments. If it didn't matter, then why do all the training and why compete at all? From Waitzkin's perspective, the parents actually cared so much that they feared the effects of pushing their own desires for success on their children. For the kids, the confusion came from the fact that in order to compete at the absolute highest level, they had to fully commit themselves to winning.

Waitzkin shared his true feelings on the subject. Yes, the process matters a lot, but he feared many people get overly attached to a particular method or identity.^{27,28} He further explained, "If we don't care about the results, the process doesn't work." It's by *being all in* to something bigger that your process becomes both effective and, sometimes, even innovative.

The research on impossible goals is clear. For an "impossible" or even challenging goal to be effective, it must be outcome- or performance-based as opposed to learning- or process-based. It is by fully committing and trying to solve a tangible goal, such as putting a man on the moon or running a

four-minute mile, that an individual or organization can both develop and realize the best process.^{[29](#)}

Not only do impossible goals lead to the best process, but they also create the best teamwork. As Steven Kerr, former chief learning officer at General Electric and Goldman Sachs, stated:

If done right, a stretch target . . . gets your people to perform in ways they never imagined possible. It's a goal that, by definition, you don't know how to reach. You might, for instance, ask people to cut costs by half or reduce product-development time from years to months . . . [in order to] find dramatically new ways of doing business.^{[30](#)}

Concluding this section on clarifying the science of goals:

- Human perception and behavior are driven by goals.
- Human systems and their outcomes are driven by goals.
- The quality of our process and results comes down to the quality of our goals and our level of commitment to them.
- If you have conflicting and competing goals, you'll have a complex system that can't scale.
- If you're trying to justify too many competing priorities, you're not facing the hard truth that you're operating below the floor.
- If you have the wrong goal, you'll scale in the wrong direction.
- When you have the right impossible goal, it will simplify your focus and enable you to bypass the noise and distractions that would slow your growth.

CONCLUSION: PLAYING TO WIN VS. PLAYING TO PLAY

*The heart of strategy is the answer to two fundamental questions:
where will you play, and how will you win there?*

— A .G. LAFLEY, FORMER CEO OF P&G, IN *PLAYING TO WIN: HOW STRATEGY
REALLY WORKS*^{[31](#)}

In 2004, investor and entrepreneur Nick Kokonas and his wife went to dinner at Trio, an upscale restaurant 30 minutes outside of Chicago. Nick was very informed and interested in the restaurant industry and loved going to really good restaurants.

Though Trio was already well established as an award-winning and excellent restaurant, Nick was shocked by the food being presented to him that night. It was elegant, beautiful, delicious. Some of the best and most inspiring food he'd experienced, and it wasn't what he was expecting from Trio.

"What's going on?" Nick asked his waiter, speaking of the radically high and innovative level of the food being served.

"We've got this kid from the French Laundry, and he's blowing our minds."³²

As Nick explains it, speaking literally not figuratively, "[Trio] was just the best restaurant in the world at that time, and nobody knew it."

That night, as he often did, Grant Achatz, the young executive chef, went out to greet some of the patrons. When he got to their table and asked Nick and his wife, "How was everything?" Nick replied, "If you ever want to open a restaurant of your own, I would like to help you."

Grant had grown up in Michigan making basic dishes in his parents' diners. He had an increased interest in adding flare and uniqueness to the dishes but was told "food should be cheap and fast." Wanting to take his food to different places, he enrolled at the Culinary Institute of America in Hyde Park, New York.

After culinary school, Grant worked for a time at Charlie Trotter's, one of the top restaurants in the United States. He didn't like the hostile and backstabbing environment at Trotter's, so he got a job at the French Laundry in California, a three-Michelin-Star restaurant and among the top in the United States.

Though he loved and learned an enormous amount from Thomas Keller, the chef at the French Laundry, over the next few years it became clear to Grant that he needed to move on again. He really wanted to push the creative boundaries of food and was finding that his expression was limited.

That's when Grant moved to Trio, where he was executive chef. Grant took it from an already award-winning restaurant to something special, getting rare awards. That's when he met Nick.

Four days after meeting in Trio, Nick got an e-mail from Grant at 5:30 A.M. saying, “If you’re serious, I’d like to talk to you about this.”

Nick woke his wife up and said, “We’re going to build a restaurant with Grant.”

While googling potential logos for the restaurant, Grant came across the alinea symbol, and as he looked up the meaning, it was perfect for the experience he wanted to create: “A new train of thought.”

They decided to call the restaurant Alinea. The whole philosophy of the restaurant would be, “This is new. And it’s new, and it’s new again.” The goal would be shocking and surprising the guests at every turn, from how they entered the restaurant to every element of the experience.

Though Nick was a businessman and investor, admittedly, he didn’t envision Alinea’s potential. He saw in Grant rare talent and ability but assumed their venture would be a one-year thing, as most restaurants don’t make it much further. Yet, in his words, “It became evident to me it was more important than I thought it was.”

For several months before opening, they acquired a location for Alinea and began the interior design. Grant selected a top-tier staff and worked on the innovative menu they’d begin with. Before opening, he told his staff, “Everybody just needs to believe the fact that we’re about to open the best restaurant in the country. And anything less will be a failure.”

A week later, they opened.

The first night, the most important food critics in the country sat in the dining room.

In Grant’s words, “On night one!”

They got three pages in *The New York Times* two days after they opened.

The top food critic in the world called Grant and said, “We’ve selected you for the top restaurant in the country.” Alinea also jumped into the top 50 restaurants in the entire world. All of this almost immediately upon opening.

This wasn’t an accident.

They weren’t just testing the waters.

Grant came out swinging from the beginning.

His intention and commitment were clear—they were operating from the beginning as the best restaurant in the country. “Anything less would be a failure.”

The goal shapes the process.

Consider Tom Brady. He, unlike the other NFL quarterbacks, was far more committed to *winning Super Bowls*.

Of course, it may be assumed that every quarterback is optimizing for winning Super Bowls, but that's not actually true. Most quarterbacks, when you truly dissect it, are optimizing for other things, whether that be money, fame, personal stats, etc.

Maya Angelou famously advised, "When someone shows you who they are, believe them the first time."³³ All you have to do is watch what people *do* to know what they are optimizing for. Their words will often tell you the opposite.

Sure, the NFL quarterbacks may all love the game.

But they aren't playing *the same game*.

Because Brady was committed to winning as many Super Bowls as possible, he filtered and played the game differently from other quarterbacks. His process and system were *very different*.

Despite easily being able to be the highest paid quarterback, he actively chose a much lower salary for himself. He did this to enable his team to invest more in the quality of his offensive line, as well as the backup offensive line.

Brady knew that to win Super Bowls, an elite offensive line was key.

Yet he also knew that if he, as the quarterback, absorbed a huge percentage of his team's salary cap, that they couldn't have a quality *backup offensive line* as well. He felt that having incredible backups was *essential*, because linemen regularly get injured. And an injured lineman can cost you a game or a season.

Additionally, because his goal was to win as many Super Bowls as possible, longevity became a part of his process, far more intensely than perhaps any other quarterback. Brady's health and nutrition regime have become mainstream, as they enabled him to play at an elite level to age 45.³⁴ He won his seventh Super Bowl with the Tampa Bay Buccaneers at age 43.

Brady fully focused on one goal: winning Super Bowls.

His commitment to such a high goal enabled him to play chess while the other quarterbacks and teams played checkers.

His high goal produced an extremely high floor. If you weren't serious about winning, you could go play for another team.

There wasn't any messing around with Tom.

His goal shaped his process, and his process was fundamentally different from the other NFL quarterbacks, who optimized many things that from Tom's frame shouldn't exist.

In the Pulitzer Prize-winning book *On Grand Strategy*, Dr. John Lewis Gaddis explains that theory serves practice, and practice corrects theory.³⁵ All of us have a "theory." That theory is our frame or perception, which is based on our own biases and goals, and directly shapes our decisions and actions.

Put simply, your "theory" or thesis is the future you're actively creating—what you believe, why you believe it, the goals you pursue as a result, and the path and process you take.

The power of a better future is that, if you let it, it allows you to look more honestly and critically at what you're now doing. Though what you're now doing may be good, the bigger future invites you to stop most of that and focus on something better.

Benjamin Franklin famously said, "An ounce of prevention is worth a pound of cure."³⁶ Putting adequate energy into your frame or goal determines everything that occurs downstream. You'll prevent and save yourself from years or decades of wasted energy by committing to a much higher goal, which will immediately free you from all ineffective paths and processes.

Of this, Dr. Stephen Covey explained:

It becomes obvious that if we want to make relatively minor changes in our lives, we can perhaps appropriately focus on our attitudes and behaviors. . . . But if we want to make significant, quantum change, we need to work on our basic paradigms. . . . We can spend weeks, months, even years laboring, trying to change our attitudes and behaviors and not even begin to approach the phenomenon of change that occurs spontaneously when we see things differently.³⁷

The goal determines the process—what is signal and what is noise. The more effectively you are at framing your future, the more powerful your process will be *in the present*. This is scientific fact, and it cannot be denied.

JOURNAL PROMPTS & APPLICATIONS

- What is the goal shaping everything you're now doing?
- Looking honestly and critically at your existing business, is your system simple or complex?
- Do you have multiple competing goals or one singular purpose driving everything you're doing?
- What "impossible" goal would enable you to simplify your system and focus in the right way?
- Go to scaling.com/book1 and complete the form to evaluate your current readiness to scale.

CHAPTER 2

Set a Timeline So Short You Think It's Impossible

We like to bully deadlines. Pick on them; make fun of them; even spit on them sometimes. But what a terrible thing to do. Deadlines are actually our best friends.

— JASON FRIED, FOUNDER OF 37SIGNALS¹

When Richard Bryan was 28 years old, he was prematurely thrust into the CEO role of his family's 100-year-old truck and car dealership in Bristol, UK. His father had become incredibly ill and was forced to retire.

Despite grossing over \$100 million in annual revenue, the company was losing nearly \$4 million per year. The organization lacked clear leadership and had no succession plan in place.

As CEO, Richard was floundering, but with the guidance of a mentor he was able to define and own his role as leader. He built a strong leadership team over the next 10 years, and the company grew and thrived in a competitive market.

In 2008, Richard sold the business to another UK-based dealer group and transitioned the family ventures into real estate investment and development.

After the sale, Richard and his wife, Melissa, and their two children—ages 10 and 12—moved to Colorado to be near Melissa's family. With their work in the UK, they planned on staying just one year, but they grew to love the United States and wanted their children raised there.

Over the next 15 years—from 2009 to 2024—Richard flew back to Bristol several times per year and spent a month at a time away from his family,

working.

In April 2024, I was in Whistler, Canada, training a group of 80 CEO coaches, all of whom had previously been CEOs or founders themselves. Richard was among them. For the prior few years, he'd become passionate about and started advising CEOs as a side hustle to his commercial real estate investments. He specifically guided family businesses on their leadership and succession processes.

During my training, I taught these CEO coaches The Scaling Framework, and it altered how most of them viewed their own goals, as well as how they guided their clients.

I taught them the science of impossible goals, and a crucial element is the person's view of *time*. Specifically, I taught them that psychologically, time isn't the same as how we view it externally on a clock.

Psychologically, *time is a tool* for making decisions.

Rather than separating the past, present, and future, as we typically do, I explained to them that how they frame their own past and future directly shapes their present decisions and actions.²

- **Your past is a tool to improve your present.**
- **Your future is a power tool to improve your present.**

The future holds far more weight in the decisions we make than the past does.

Therefore, to utilize time more effectively, specifically the future, you want to 1) make it much bigger, as discussed in [chapter 1](#), and 2) make the deadline far more aggressive—even seemingly impossible.

To prove to them that time, particularly their own future, is a “tool” they can use to scale much faster, I asked them to write down a big goal they had for themselves. This particular group embraced Jim Collins's “BHAG” (Big Hairy Audacious Goal) concept, which Collins explains as a long-term and highly compelling goal, meant to stretch an individual or organization beyond its current capabilities. Collins suggests that BHAGs are so big—often seemingly impossible—that they likely take 10 to 30 years to realize.³

I used the BHAG language they were raised with to shift them from their old management model into the new *science of scaling*.

Richard wrote down where he wanted his life to be by his 65th birthday, 11 years from that time. In 11 years—by 2035—Richard planned to sell off his investment portfolio in Bristol, have far more time to travel and be with

Melissa, and be a *New York Times* best-selling author and full-time business coach.

I then asked the group how they would achieve their BHAG *if they only had three years to do it*.

“How would compressing the timeline alter your strategy and focus here and now?”

Initially, Richard rejected my question.

“There’s no way I could do this in three years” was his immediate reaction, considering his 11-year plan.

Sensing some anxiety and concern among group members, I invited them to suspend judgment and stress. “Look, I’m not telling you that you *have* to do this in three years. I’m just asking you to ponder how you *would* solve this if you *did* commit to it in three years. Don’t take this too seriously. Use time as a tool, not a reality.”

Because I gave the group a few minutes to journal about this, Richard began entertaining the idea of shifting his 11-year BHAG into an “impossible” three-year goal.

He stepped out of the room to grab a drink. While letting the idea sink in, he realized there probably *was* a way he could reach his goal in three years. But he’d have to go about it in a totally different way from his current 11-year plan.

Though he’d never considered it before, rather than continuing to focus on and grow his investment business as he’d been planning, he would need to sell off that portfolio sooner. If he sold off those investments, he’d no longer continue spending three to four months per year in Bristol, away from Melissa. Instead, he could reinvest that money into more passive investments in the United States and shift his focus entirely to being with Melissa and being a full-time coach and author.

Whoa.

It started to make sense in his mind, and he began feeling pretty good about it.

He walked back into the room where people were finishing up their journaling and table discussions.

I pulled the group back together and asked how changing the timeline for their BHAG altered their strategy here and now. Richard raised his hand and explained what he believed would be required to realize his BHAG in three years.

I pushed back on Richard, asking what would need to happen if he went for his BHAG in just *one year*, turning his everyday goal into an impossible goal.

Same as before, Richard's back straightened and his eyes widened. His initial reaction was to simply reject the idea entirely, somewhat put off that I'd even ask such a question.

I reminded him again to think of time simply as a strategic tool, intended to cut the noise and nonsense from his thinking.

"I'm not worried about whether you think it's possible or impossible," I told him. "Does shrinking the timeline from three years to one change *anything* about the priority or process here and now?"

"I'd need to sell my portfolio business ASAP," he replied, "and go all-in on what I really want to do."

As Richard's final words tumbled out of his mouth, there was an audible and collective gasp in the room.

"Interesting," I replied. "So, *if* you make your eleven-year goal a one-year goal, *then* your portfolio business falls below the floor, becoming noise. Is that right?"

"Yes, it would no longer make sense to keep it," he replied.

That night, after the meetings and dinner ended, Richard went back to his hotel room. He timidly called Melissa and told her about his idea and plan to realize his impossible goal in one year. Surprisingly, she was completely on board and supportive.

"Maybe now we can go do new things and not be so rushed," she said. "Maybe now, we can roam."

Over the last decade, Melissa and Richard had become overly routinized even in their vacations, going to the same places and staying in their comfort zones. Melissa sensed that if they sold the portfolio business, and Richard was home more, that they would have more time together now, not in 11 years.

Freedom.

With Melissa's blessing, Richard committed.

When he got back to Colorado, his first order of business was calling his longtime accountant and advisor in Bristol. Richard told his advisor he wanted to sell off the entire real estate portfolio and reinvest it in a more passive way with his advisor in the United States. His accountant was

completely shocked—as this was a 180 to everything they’d built together the prior 15 years and to what their long-term plan was.

“How could you do this?” his accountant asked. “How could you sell off your jewel assets?” Indeed, over the years, Richard had acquired many sought-after properties in Bristol, even boasting the government as tenants.

After explaining his thinking and his goals, ultimately his accountant understood, and they began the process of listing all the properties.

A few months after our meeting in Whistler, I gave Richard a follow-up call. Here’s what he reported: nearly half his real estate portfolio was sold; he’d spent an entire month traveling throughout Europe with Melissa, their niece, and nephew; he’d lost 10 pounds, hitting what was once his 12-month body-fat goal; and finally, he’d made enormous progress building his coaching business.

With excitement and awe, Richard reported to me, “I think I’ll be very close to completing my goal in one year. By April 2025, the entire portfolio should be sold, my book finished, and I’ll have taken several more trips with Melissa.”

“This is incredible,” I replied. “How would you describe the core difference between who you are now versus who you were before utilizing time as a tool?”

“I’m far more aggressive with my vision and growth,” he stated.

During a second follow-up call near the end of 2024, Richard reported that nearly all of his property was sold and that his coaching business was thriving. Furthermore, he told me that because he was focused on it, his vision for his coaching business had expanded dramatically. He now planned on being the top trainer and coach in the world on family business and succession planning.

Had Richard not utilized time as a tool, he would have spent the next decade traveling to Bristol, missed many vacations with his wife, and his coaching business would still be an idea, not a reality.

Instead, the system of his life is scaling dramatically toward what truly matters for Richard: his family and guiding family businesses.

In [Chapter 1](#), you learned that the primary thing driving our lives is our goals. You learned that our present experience is filtered by the goals we have, including the pathways forward we take and the systems we create. You learned that impossibly higher goals are the most effective for scaling

because they force you to find the most potent pathways. They force you to create a simple and optimized system, free of dilution and contradiction.

The remainder of this chapter builds off the insights you gained in [Chapter 1](#), helping you realize that the scale of the goal isn't enough. You've also got to have a deadline that is so pressing it seems impossible.

The purpose of having an impossible goal with an impossible deadline isn't to stress yourself out. On the contrary. Consider Melissa's response when Richard sheepishly told her he wanted to achieve his 11-year BHAG in one year, and that in order to do it, he'd have to sell the investment business.

Melissa was *relieved*, not stressed.

Having an impossible deadline is a tool. Its purpose, as you'll see, is to filter out the false requirements you've placed on yourself and to isolate what strategy expert Dr. Richard Rumelt calls "the crux."⁴

APPLY TIME AS A TOOL, GIVE YOURSELF LESS TIME

If a timeline is long, it's wrong.

— ELON MUSK⁵

The year 2018 was a crazy one for my family.

After three years battling the foster system in court, we were miraculously granted adoption in February 2018. One month later, in March of 2018, two other big things happened. After years of fertility treatments, our round of in vitro worked and Lauren became pregnant with twins who were born in December of 2018. I also published my first major book, *Willpower Doesn't Work*, in March 2018. After the adoption, we moved to Orlando, Florida.

It was a whirlwind.

Yet, in the midst of that whirlwind, one thing didn't happen: *progress on my dissertation*.

I was nearly five years into my PhD program and had already completed all my coursework and exams. All that remained between me and being Dr. Benjamin Hardy was completing my dissertation. And as you may know, there aren't deadlines for these.

In April of 2019 during a marriage therapy session, Lauren expressed her concern that my PhD wasn't going to get complete, and that if I didn't make it a priority, it might never get done. She could see that I was making no progress on it, that I was busy running a training program and being a dad of five kids. She could also see that it was weighing on me.

During that therapy session, we agreed that if I didn't drive back up to Clemson and make that my full focus, it might never get done. I'm thankful to a wife who is willing to not only tell me straight, but also to say, "Look, go up there and finish this, even if it takes you two months. We'll be here when you get back."

Though it was hard to leave my wife and kids, I drove the eight or so hours from Orlando up to Clemson and stayed in the guestroom of some friends. Three weeks later, my dissertation was complete and I was scheduled to defend it.

I can absolutely say that had I not gone and just laser-focused on it, that I probably wouldn't have completed it. When it comes to big projects and deep work, if you're split-focused and have zero deadline for completion, you're stagnating and losing years, probably decades.

Yet, with an aggressive deadline and a singular focus, you can move mountains. You can do in weeks what might have taken years, decades, or in all honesty, might never get done at all.

According to Parkinson's law, "*Work expands to fill the available time.*"⁶ From this principle, if you give yourself a month to do something, it will take a month. If you give yourself a day, it will take a day.

How does this work?

The brain naturally saves resources by procrastinating. People procrastinate until the reality sets in that they *have* to get something done. Even if you don't feel ready, a deadline forces you to *become* ready.

Though deadlines can be self-imposed, they are far more effective when externally imposed, such as Lauren's ultimatum.⁷

Though deadlines aren't anything new, the obvious question is: *Why don't people use them more aggressively?*

The beauty of a deadline, and particularly one that seems impossible—such as Richard's one-year goal—is that they force you to strip out the steps of the goal that aren't necessary. This same principle holds true with meetings.⁸ If you give yourself half the time to have a meeting (or less),

you're forced to identify and isolate only the most crucial items and remove the fluff.

If you give yourself too much time to do something, it's almost certain you're optimizing things that shouldn't exist. You're not focusing solely on the most crucial elements toward the goal.

Elon Musk is a master of simplifying complexity and removing what he calls "false requirements." Over the years, he's developed what he calls the Five-Step Algorithm, which he uses to strip out unnecessary steps and simplify a system so it can scale.⁹ His five steps are:

1. Question requirements ("Most requirements are dumb.")
2. Remove parts or process steps ("The most common mistake of a smart engineer is to optimize a thing that should not exist.")
3. Simplify and optimize the system
4. Accelerate time-to-learning cycles
5. Automate

Musk's first step is to question requirements.

Most of the requirements we assume for our goals are just that, assumptions. More often than not, what we think is required is false.

This is where both impossible goals and impossible deadlines can be beneficial tools. They force you to question your assumptions and the requirements.¹⁰

It's no secret that when someone has a gun pointed at their head, almost everything falls to insignificance.

The same is true with extreme deadlines, especially when there is external accountability tied to them. Quickly, you're able to cut most of the fat and false requirements from your thinking. You're able to simplify and strip out what doesn't matter, optimize your focus, and accelerate your progress on what has the most direct effect.

Take, for example, Xavier Martine, a young attorney in Minnesota. Xavier passed the bar exam in 2019 and opened his law firm that year. In 2021, his firm did \$500,000 in annual revenue. In 2022, after getting coaching and guidance, Xavier's firm did \$1 million in annual revenue.

By early 2024, after reading many books and considering his future, Xavier decided he wanted to get his firm to \$100 million in 10 years.

Certainly, a massive vision. However, it wasn't until he joined our program that October and learned The Scaling Framework that he began to really scale.

The Scaling Framework taught Xavier the importance of applying time as a tool in the form of seemingly impossible deadlines. Following the process, he decided to take his 10-year goal and make it a three-year goal.

When he did this, three things immediately happened for Xavier.

1. He became far more aware of everything going on in his business, and a lot of it wasn't pretty.
2. He began developing an actual plan and process to get to \$100 million, which he wasn't doing before when it was so far away.
3. Connected to points one and two, he began eliminating people and processes that were below the floor relative to the \$100 million plan, and he began adding better team members than he ever had before.

In his own words:

When I moved the ten-year goal to three years, I was immediately forced to look a lot more critically at everything going on in the firm. It quickly became obvious that we were incredibly inefficient in many ways, which I wasn't aware of, and which I wouldn't have become aware of for a long time had it not been for the aggressive deadline.

In digging into the data of his company, Xavier found that his English-speaking sales team was converting at one-third the level of his Spanish-speaking sales team. This had been going on for quite a while, but he hadn't been aware of it. His English-speaking sales team consisted of eight employees based in the Philippines.

He put the spotlight on the English sales team and held them extremely accountable for their performance. Within a month—before the end of October—they'd doubled the conversion rate of getting qualified leads to sign up for a consultation call, from approximately 30 percent to 60 percent. Despite doubling their performance basically immediately, this team didn't want to be held accountable, so they all quit, leaving Xavier in a pickle.

Yet an important move he made almost immediately after moving his 10-year goal to three years was hiring a phenomenal general manager. This

general manager was, by all accounts, a rock star who knew the industry extremely well. He also was deeply inspired and excited by Xavier's impossible goal of going from \$3 million to \$100 million in revenue in three years.

This general manager, rather than Xavier, found a new English-speaking sales team in the United States. In less than a month with this new team, even before the end of 2024, their conversion rate of qualified leads to consultation calls was matching their Spanish-speaking team at 90 percent. The general manager also hired a strong marketing director, operations manager, and three additional attorneys.

Meanwhile, Xavier was digging deeper into the various systems within his business. He found increasingly more inefficiencies he was completely unaware of. He realized the team was missing 30 to 40 percent of all calls coming into the office. He further found that 15 to 20 percent of the calls the sales team got were from existing clients simply asking basic questions that should have been answered by a secretary.

In considering his strategy and focus on reaching \$100 million, it became clear to Xavier that they were taking on way too many different types of cases. Nearly 20 percent of the cases they took were what they called "petty misdemeanors," which weren't as profitable. They stopped doing child support cases and adoption cases, among others. Instead, they decided to fully focus on a few key types of cases, such as felony, divorce, and custody cases. They were going to become the best in the world at these.

Before the end of 2024, less than 90 days after applying The Scaling Framework, Xavier's entire business was transformed. In 90 days, his team was far better. The systems were more efficient. The focus of the company was much sharper. The result was that in those 90 days, the revenue in the company shot up over 30 percent. The profitability of the company grew nearly 50 percent.

Xavier and his team are all fully committed to \$100 million in three years and are making the moves to do so.

In a report published by McKinsey in 2014 titled "Grow Fast or Die Slow," they analyzed the life cycles of 3,000 software and internet companies.^{[11](#)} What they found in their study was that high-growth companies yield 5x greater returns for their shareholders than medium-growth companies. They also found that growth predicts long-term success. The "supergrowers" whose annual growth was over 60 percent when they

reached \$100 million in revenue were 8x more likely to reach \$1 billion revenue.

Put simply, if you're not growing fast, you're unlikely to grow much at all. The reason for that will be detailed in the next section of this chapter.

The McKinsey study found the same thing Elon's Five-Step Algorithm teaches: after you've simplified your focus, you've got to *accelerate* like crazy. Fast-feedback loops are where rapid growth happens, and without rapid growth, you're stagnant and stalling.

RE-EXAMINING KENNEDY'S SEVEN-PLUS-YEAR MOON MISSION, APPLYING TIME AS A TOOL

You will have a much harder time dealing with a gnarly challenge if you have not distilled it down to a crux. No one solves a problem they cannot comprehend and hold in their mind.

— DR. RICHARD RUMELT, STRATEGY PROFESSOR, IN *THE CRUX*^{[12](#)}

We now return to President Kennedy's "We Choose to Go to the Moon" speech, discussed in the Introduction of this book.

But this time, for a different reason.

Without question, this story is perhaps the most famous example of a leader using *time as a tool* to realize an impossible goal.

With absolute respect for Kennedy, NASA, and what was accomplished, we're going to review NASA's process of getting to the moon. Though they achieved the impossible and changed the world as a result, the truth is that NASA's process of getting to the moon was linear and suboptimal.

Though Kennedy used time as a tool, he could have been more aggressive. His deadline of 1970 was arbitrary, even political, less than strategic. Humans like round numbers, and completing a mammoth impossible goal by the end of the decade was a clean and simple framing. It was a great *story*.

Like a company with a 10-year vision, Kennedy's deadline was somewhat lazy.

First, let me give a little context. While writing this book, I interviewed a NASA engineer of over 30 years. She explained that NASA's values are "Safety, Integrity, Excellence, and Teamwork," with safety being *by far* NASA's greatest consideration.

She further told me that NASA's systems engineering process is purposefully "linear, repetitive, and iterative." They aren't focused on efficiency, but instead, ensuring safety as well as customer and congressional satisfaction.

Finally, she explained that given NASA's position as a governmental agency, a massive constraint on NASA is how it receives funding. Despite often establishing 5- to 10-year plans or missions, NASA receives its funding *annually*, and often isn't approved for what its larger goals require.

Given this information and for the purpose of learning and achieving our own impossible goals effectively, let's dig into NASA's process of getting to the moon.

Could NASA have gotten to the moon faster than the nearly seven-plus years Kennedy gave them?

Isn't it interesting that they barely made their allotted deadline? Not really. Given Parkinson's law, it's almost predictable they achieved the goal just in time.

So, what if Kennedy had said, "We will get to the moon in five years, by 1968"?

Or what if he had said, "We will get to the moon in three years, by 1966"?

How would a more compressed timeline have altered NASA's process?

Would it have helped or hurt?

It's no secret that when a person or organization has an open-ended or large amount of time to accomplish something, they spend the majority of that time distracted—whether on peripheral or other issues.

Only when the deadline and its consequences loom near does one's attention laser in on the essential components to be solved.^{[13](#)}

Research shows that individuals and organizations typically devote less than 10 percent of their total time to value-added work, while the rest is consumed by unnecessary steps or unbalanced operations.^{[14](#)}

In the case of the 1960s moon mission, NASA was no different.

Despite achieving the impossible, their extensive seven-plus year deadline, coupled with their linear and overly conservative process, led NASA to optimizing many things that weren't essential to reaching the

moon. By having a tighter deadline, they could have bypassed the noise and focused more quickly and more directly on the signal or core constraints of their goal.

The strategy expert Dr. Richard Rumelt calls the core constraint or bottleneck of a particular goal “the crux.”¹⁵ He drew that term from rock climbing, wherein the crux is the most difficult “problem” or obstacle of the climb.

If you don’t solve the crux, you can’t complete the climb, no matter how excellently you can do the other aspects of the climb, and no matter how much time you’ve invested on those other aspects.

Mastering the crux is how you solve the problem.

When it comes to business and other objectives, people often struggle identifying the crux, let alone optimizing their path and system around it. Instead, they invest large amounts of time and resources on fringe issues—many times optimizing things that shouldn’t exist and that don’t produce the intended result.

Had a shorter time frame been agreed upon, NASA would have been forced to identify the crux of the moon mission *faster* and to optimize their process on that.

For instance, NASA did excessive test flights during the Mercury and Gemini missions. These programs were preliminary to the main Apollo program and intended to provide foundational learning and innovation that would enable Apollo’s success.

The Mercury missions, from 1961 to 1963, focused on basic spaceflight and orbiting. The Gemini missions, from 1965 to 1966, tested things like docking and longer flights.

Though these introductory missions provided important learning, they were also expensive, overly conservative, and very bureaucratic.

With a more intensive timeline, they could have radically simplified the steps to their goal. They could have jumped straight to solving and optimizing the crux of the Apollo-specific systems, which was landing the lunar module on the moon as well as ascending from the moon and reuniting the lunar module back to the main command module.

By understanding and optimizing the crux *from the beginning*—rather than waiting to the end—they could have *simultaneously* solved the intermediary aspects of orbiting and maneuvering far more efficiently. They likely could have skipped the Gemini missions altogether, as well as the

development of prototype rockets unfit for the actual goal, such as the Saturn I.

Furthermore, with way too much time on their hands, the astronauts engaged in enormous amounts of noncritical training activities. These included extensive general survival training in deserts and jungles, PR and marketing, detailed simulations unrelated to the lunar landing, as well as simulating highly unlikely and unrelated scenarios.

An important factor to realizing goals is known as *readiness to change*.^{16,17,18} Put simply, until a person is ready, they stall and avoid needed learning and work. They distract themselves and justify a lack of progress. They celebrate effort over results.

A key factor to increase one's readiness is a heightened awareness of the consequences for changing or not changing.

The reality of time and its consequences is the most potent lever for readiness.¹⁹ Deadlines, although uncomfortable, force readiness. They force you to face the brutal facts. They force you to stop putting your energy in noise and distractions.

Deadlines are a feedback loop that forces results.

They force you to *find the crux* of the issue and to solve it, because now the consequences are real, and we're not just messing around.

Had NASA had half the time to get a man on the moon, they would've solved the crux faster. They would have *had to*, but it would have been in a different (and better) way. Much of what NASA did during those nearly seven years probably wouldn't have happened, as it would have been deemed noise.

I've seen this with organizations and leaders at all levels. For instance, one company I advised was doing over \$100 million in annual revenue and seeking to reach \$1 billion. When I asked the CEO when they planned to reach \$1 billion in revenue, he told me they'd get there in 10 years or less.

I hear this a lot. Ten years seems like just the right amount of time to achieve something big. The truth, though, is that overly long-term goals misuse time as a tool. The future is better viewed as a psychological and strategic tool, rather than a concrete reality.

The purpose of the future is to impact, shape, and direct the present.

A 10-year goal isn't a powerful enough rendering of "the future" to make a sizable impact on the present.

I asked him, "What does that ten-year goal require of you today?"

He had no response.

“What happens if you give yourself three years or less to reach one billion dollars?” I asked.

“Well, we’d have to get moving!” he replied.

“Not only would you have to get moving, but you’d have to find a better path than you’re on now,” I replied. “The shorter timeline would force you to simplify your focus to the crux and scale that.”

Another person I recently spoke to, a young and ambitious 22-year-old, told me about his dream of one day owning a European soccer team. I asked him when he’d realize that, and he told me, “When I’m fifty-five years old.”

“What if you gave yourself to age thirty?” I asked.

He got uncomfortable.

“There’s a lot of things I want to do before that, like get a PhD and run a firm,” he told me.

“If you committed to own the European soccer team by age thirty, how much of what you plan to do between now and fifty-five (the next thirty-three years) would become irrelevant?” I asked.

“I’m not sure, I really want to get that PhD,” he said, honestly.

“I understand,” I replied. “It’s hard to choose between conflicting goals. But if you committed to own the soccer team by thirty, rather than fifty-five, how important is that PhD? Is the juice really worth the squeeze? Is it really essential, or is it a false requirement you’ve placed on yourself?”

“I’ll think about it,” he replied.

When it comes to running a company, if you give yourself too much time to do something, you can’t filter the present hard enough.

The purpose of the impossible goal and deadline is that the filter becomes *extremely intense*! If you only have 18 months to do what you thought you had 10 to 15 years to accomplish, you can’t waste your time on nonsense.

Going back to McKinsey’s Grow Fast or Die Slow model, there’s an important reason for this. If you’re not going fast, that likely means you’re unfocused. It likely means you’re optimizing things that shouldn’t exist—false requirements.

An inherent problem with long-range goals is that they justify you making bad decisions today.^{[20](#)}

If you have 10 years to do something, it doesn’t matter that much what you do today. You can, therefore, keep poor team members on your team, keep conflicting or irrelevant products or objectives in your system, etc.

These unforced errors that come through uncritical filtering compound over time, making it increasingly less likely that you'll scale in the future.

Consider Xavier from earlier in this chapter. It wasn't until he gave himself an unreasonable deadline that he was able to critically filter all aspects of his business, including his team, the types of cases they did, and the processes.

Had he not given himself the extreme deadline, he wouldn't have been required to fix these situations for possibly years in the future! What would the outcome of that have been?

Maybe he would have grown linearly the next few years. But his bad processes and bad decisions would have compounded, becoming worse. Like an addict who doesn't fix the problem quickly, the addiction can get to a level where correction almost becomes impossible.

The same is true of companies trying to scale.

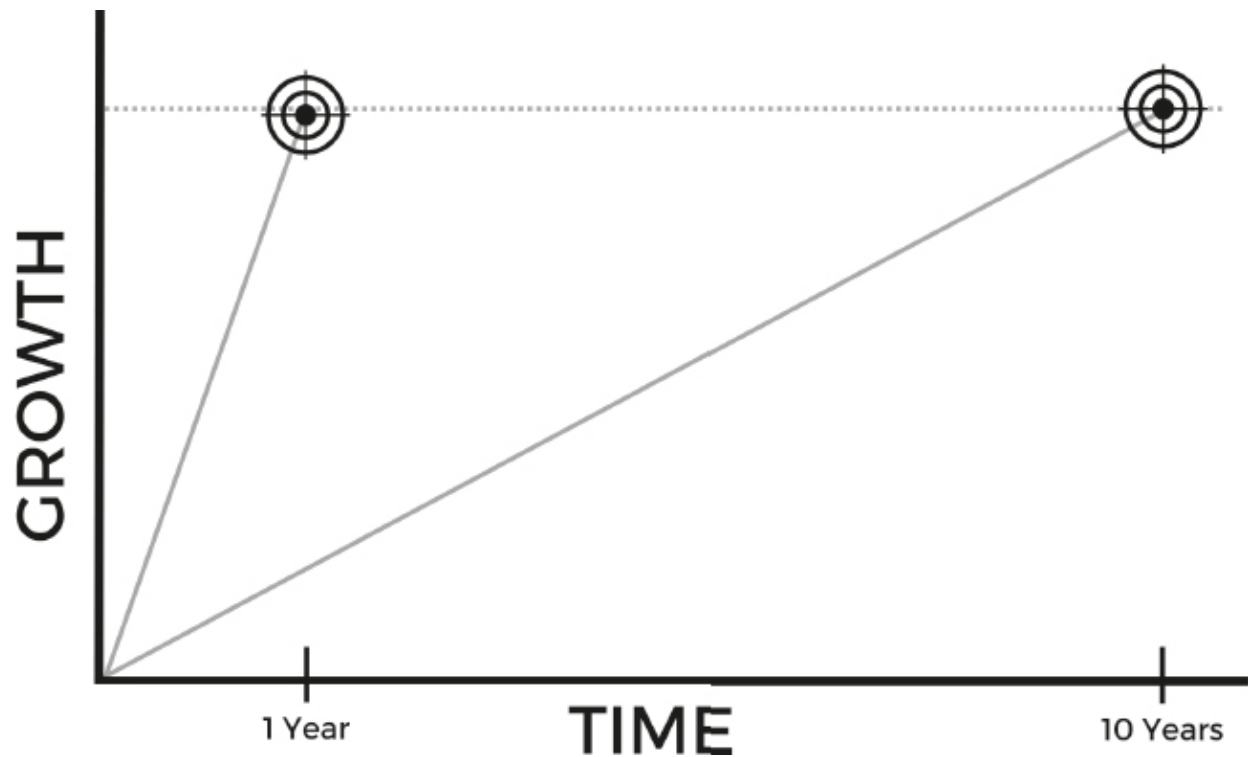
If you're not scaling quickly, you're likely making lots of bad decisions all around that will eventually sink you. Unlike NASA with the U.S. government behind you, you likely don't have unlimited resources. You can't get away with optimizing stuff that shouldn't exist.

Aggressively utilizing time as a tool will force you to weed out the false requirements and lesser goals you've placed on yourself. The unnecessary "means goals" will get in the way of the end you want to create.

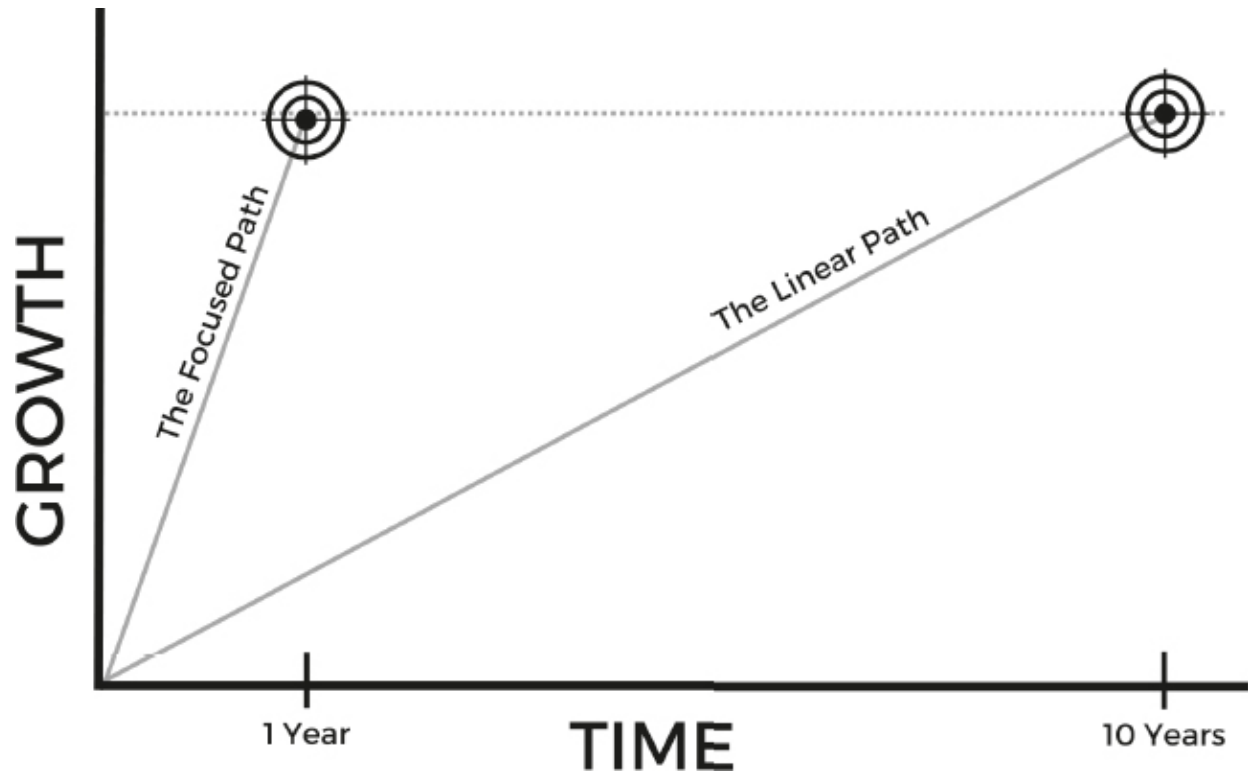
Aggressive deadlines will enable you to isolate the crux faster, and to simplify and optimize your system around that.

By bringing your goal much closer to the present, you'll filter your present much better. You'll simplify and accelerate your focus on what has the highest leverage and impact.

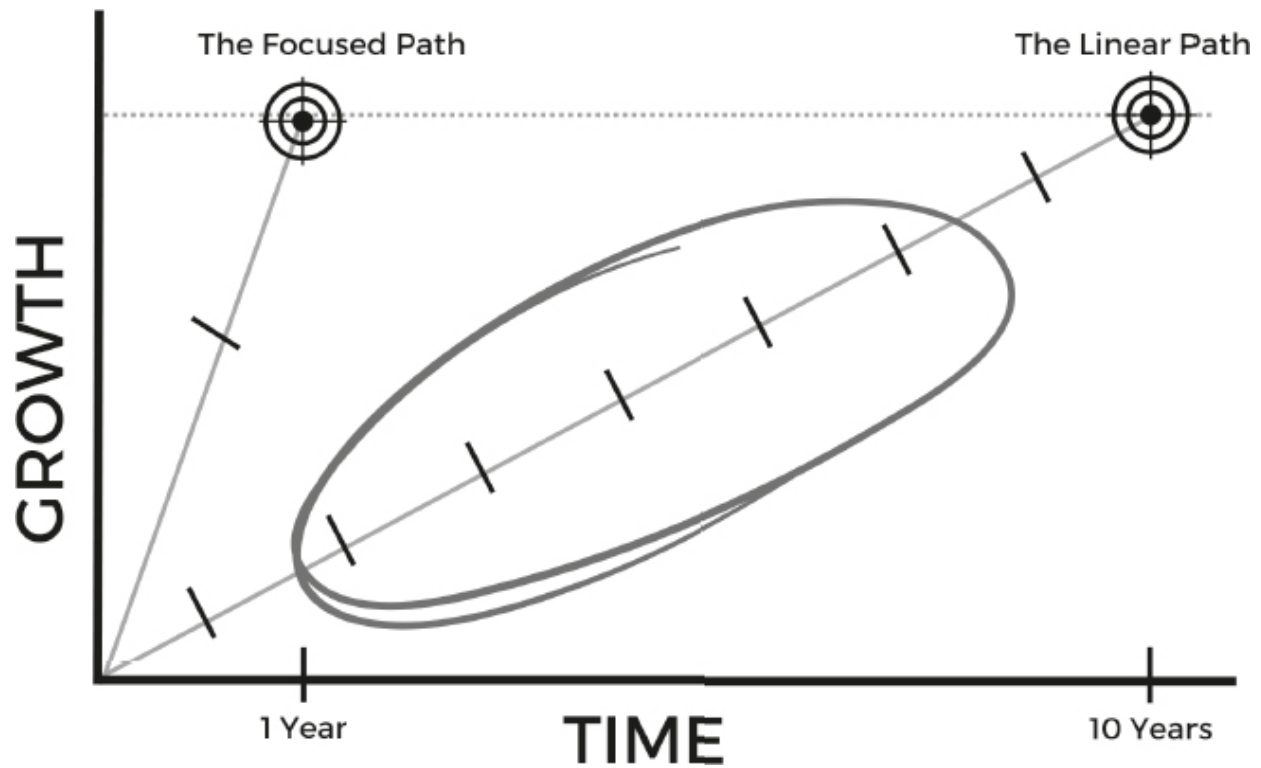
Quickly, you'll see that you can achieve more in months than you previously planned in decades.



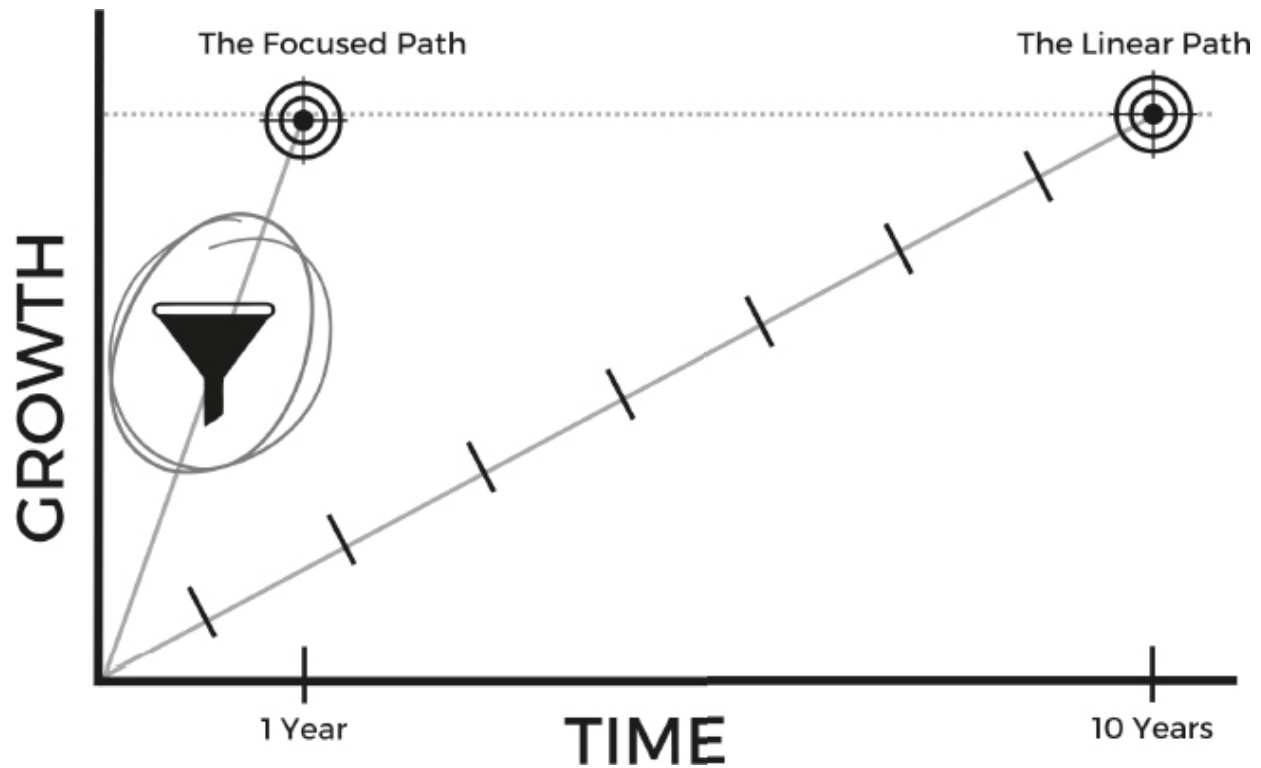
This image highlights the important fact that when you pursue the same goal with a significantly shorter timeline—even a seemingly impossible timeline—that the pathway to achieve the goal will be *different*. People often assume you can get to the goal faster using the previous pathway, just exerting more effort. No. The pathway will be very different for the radically quicker achievement. But importantly, just because it is different, doesn't mean it's harder. Just different.



It's important to note that timelines are typically arbitrary. For example, "10 years" to achieve a goal is a guess. But it's also a poor use of time as a strategic tool. The linear path is when you're basing your trajectory and the amount of time a goal will take on your past performance or current circumstances. Conversely, when you use time as a strategic tool, utilizing seemingly impossible deadlines, it forces a more focused pathway and process.



By utilizing time as a tool and creating a much shorter timeline, you quickly see that most of what you thought was “required” on the former linear path becomes irrelevant. Most of the “steps” of a linear path are improper means that aren’t directly associated with the desired end. Those “means goals” are typically false requirements, the optimizing of things that, when you operate from a better frame (including time frame), become noise that should not exist.



When you apply time as a tool and give yourself far less time than you think you need, you're forced to find the crux or core bottleneck or constraint to solve much more quickly. By identifying and solving the crux from the beginning, rather than the many false constraints that are noise, you'll scale radically faster. Few are willing to choose a focused and optimized path.

JOURNAL PROMPTS & APPLICATIONS

- What is the biggest and most important goal you have in your business?
- What if you gave yourself half the time to achieve it?
- Or, like Richard, what if you gave yourself 12 to 18 months to achieve it?
- How would that change your process and focus?
- What would you be required to eliminate?
- Are you willing to be that honest and rigorous with yourself? Or, are you comfortable maintaining a complex system that is unlikely to scale?

- How focused and simple is your system and business model? Is it focused on the crux that actually matters, that is the highest lever to your goal?
- Go to scaling.com/book1 and complete the form to evaluate your current readiness to scale.

PART 2

RAISE YOUR FLOOR



CHAPTER 3

Be More Honest with Yourself and Quit the Wrong Stuff Faster

For individuals, character is destiny. For organizations, culture is destiny.

— TONY HSIEH, FOUNDER OF ZAPPOS, IN *DELIVERING HAPPINESS*¹

In 2019, leading up to the NBA draft, Zion Williamson was the clear and obvious number 1 pick.

Expectations were sky high for Zion. He had features and characteristics you simply don't see in a single individual. Built like an NFL linebacker, he was 6 foot 6 inches tall and weighed 285 pounds. Yet, he had the speed, agility, and vertical of a point guard. He was an absolute force to be reckoned with.

Zion played high school basketball for Spartanburg Day School in South Carolina. He was dominant, the number 2 high school recruit in the nation heading into college. His senior year of high school, he averaged 36.4 points, 11.4 rebounds, 3.5 assists, 3.0 steals, and 2.0 blocks per game.²

At Duke University, Zion's power and dominance surged.

He played only one year in college, and during that year, he was a unanimous first team All-America honors and the ACC Player of the Year, and led Duke to the Elite Eight.

He broke several college records during that single season, including averaging 22.6 points per game on 68 percent field goal shooting, with 8.9 rebounds per game.³ Put simply, if you got Zion the ball, he was probably going to score. No one could guard him.

He was a freight train of power.

During one particular game, now an iconic meme, Zion destroyed his Nike shoe trying to pivot directions. The sole of his shoe literally exploded, exposing his full foot; the shoe couldn't withstand Zion's force. Nike's stock immediately plunged.⁴

Going into the NBA, people expected Zion to replace LeBron James as the face of the league. It was a clear progression: Michael Jordan passing the torch to Kobe Bryant and Shaquille O'Neal, who passed the torch to LeBron James and Stephen Curry. It was now Zion's time.

Again, no one had seen anything like Zion coming into the league.

There was just one nagging concern—Zion's Achilles heel: *Could he stay healthy?*

With that much raw power and strength and Zion's insane vertical jumping ability, people were worried about the wear and tear on his body. A body that massive isn't meant to move that fast, pivot that hard, or go that high. The weight crashing down to the ground from six feet up seemed to defy logic and physics. It boggled the mind.

Alas, by 2025, five years into Zion's NBA career, though he's produced record-breaking numbers, he's been largely a disappointment. He hasn't been able to stay healthy, playing only around 50 percent of his possible games as a pro.

Put simply, he lacks consistent availability to play.

There was even a clause in his 2022 contract extension with the New Orleans Pelicans that if he plays only 40 out of the 82 regular season games, he gets only 40 percent of his \$197 million contract. Another clause therein was that if he ever weighs over 295 pounds, he can receive reductions in his guaranteed pay.⁵

There's never been a contract like this before.

The reason for these stipulations in his contract is that Zion has made a habit of returning from the offseason weighing up to 330 pounds (50 pounds over what he was at Duke), looking overweight and lethargic. It's been clear he hasn't taken his conditioning or diet seriously.

Regularly, when Zion is on the court, he looks incredibly out of shape for a professional athlete. Despite this, he still shows intense flashes of otherworldly talent, scoring at will and doing things no one else can do. But almost always, due to his lack of care and discipline, he naturally gets hurt—

way *more* than he should—sometimes requiring surgeries that put him out for several months, even a year at a time.

For the first five years of Zion's NBA career, he's been a financial liability to the New Orleans Pelicans' franchise, who have invested hundreds of millions into him only to have him play basically a third of his games.

It's clear to the franchise, his coaches, and his teammates that Zion cannot be relied upon.

He cannot be trusted.

Whereas in the past, the team planned their team and season around Zion, now they plan for him *not* to be on the court. The team stopped mapping their future projections or plans around him, let alone *with him*, and have publicly stated they're willing to trade him.⁶

The reason for Zion's lack of availability isn't his raw and intense power, though of course those are a factor. The dude literally explodes shoes. The problem, and to the frustration of people who recognize Zion's rare and sky-high ceiling, *is his low floor*.

It doesn't matter what you're supposed "potential" is, if you don't raise your floor, *it's all in vain*.

Zion hasn't been available because Zion *hasn't been accountable* to his team.

He hasn't been accountable to *winning* in the pros.

George Bernard Shaw famously said, "Youth is wasted on the young"—meaning when you're young and have the energy and drive, you're almost always too immature to maximize on it, saying yes to all sorts of distractions that derail your focus and commitment.⁷

Zion's plight isn't new. Going from college to pros exposes a lot of people. You can get away with a lot at the college level that you simply cannot at the professional level.

At the professional level, everyone is talented. What separates those who succeed from those who don't at each level is not their ceiling *but their floor*.

The floor defines what you don't do.

The level of discipline to *consistently and continually* perform at the highest level, rather than only sometimes, is what makes a professional. That's a core difference between an amateur and a pro—the amateur doesn't want to be held accountable. They're willing to let others down, miss

deadlines, miss practice, make excuses for lack of performance—whatever the case.

A pro is accountable at all levels *and wants to be held accountable*.

The core element of jumping to a higher level of performance and results in any discipline is *raising your floor*, which means stripping out what no longer fits, even if it did before. To reach the highest levels in any discipline, field, or craft, *it becomes more about what you're not doing than what you are doing*.

To be exceptional, you can't engage in average anything.

Keeping your floor low, and therefore maintaining aspects of your life that conflict with your goal, keeps you inconsistent and jumbled in your performance.

With a lower floor, you have far too many bad days and off nights. Your “best” performances are fewer and farther between. You're not locked in at a super-high baseline and able to see how high you can possibly go.

As Sir Percy C. Buck, a prominent professor of music at the University of London, wrote in his 1944 classic, *Psychology for Musicians*, “An amateur practices until he can do a thing right, a professional until he can't do it wrong.”⁸

According to Garnet Morris, a near-billionaire whose Canadian life insurance company does more business than any other competitors by a factor of 10, the reason people don't scale is because they constantly *lie to themselves*.

They lie to themselves about their own performance.

They lie to themselves about the consequences of their actions.

They lie to themselves about their trajectory.

They justify not being accountable to themselves or others.

There's a story in the Old Testament about two brothers, Esau and Jacob. Esau is the older brother and rightful heir to his father's birthright, which in those days meant the larger inheritance and blessings of the father.⁹

One day, Esau was exhausted from working in the fields. Famished, he asked his brother, Jacob, for some lentil stew. Jacob agreed to give it to him but only if Esau traded his birthright to Jacob. This was obviously a crazy proposition, one only a madman would accept. Yet, driven by his intense hunger, Esau agreed to trade his birthright for the stew.

A famed term comes out of this story, that Esau sold his birthright “for a mess of pottage.”¹⁰

The moral and backbreaker of this biblical story is the brutal truth that *all of us are like Esau*, giving up what could be our highest destiny or “birthright” for something far less: a “mess of pottage.” Until we realize we’re being like Esau, we aren’t learning the lesson.

We’ve got to raise the floor and stop saying yes to whatever “mess of pottage” we’re accepting. Raising the floor means elevating the standard and therefore saying no to increasingly more. Only the highest signal is worthy of our time, energy, and investment.

For Zion, his “mess of pottage” is bad friends, eating junk food, playing video games, and not taking his career or life seriously.

The question you should be asking yourself is what is the “mess of pottage” you’re currently saying yes to that’s stopping you from operating at the level you could?

What are you still saying yes to that *you know* is below your floor and that is costing you far more than you’re willing to admit?

Remaining below your floor is extremely risky, though it feels the opposite. It feels risky to let go of stuff that’s important to us—whether friends, team members, clients, habits, and so on—because we’ve come to depend on these things. Always, getting to a next level of performance, impact, and growth means *giving up* much if not most of what got you where you now are.

The truth is, most people won’t raise their floor. Or if they do, they wait far too long and the opportunity cost is a heavy price.

This, more than anything, is the core reason people don’t scale.

Despite whatever potential they have, they’re mired in the distractions of everything around them, and they haven’t yet faced the truth that they can’t have it both ways. They can’t maintain the level of contradiction that is their life and go to new levels of scale and results.

Raising your floor is tough, because it means exposing yourself. Exposing the sides of you that are good but not great. Exposing the chinks in your armor. Exposing the sides of yourself that you’d rather keep hidden and private.

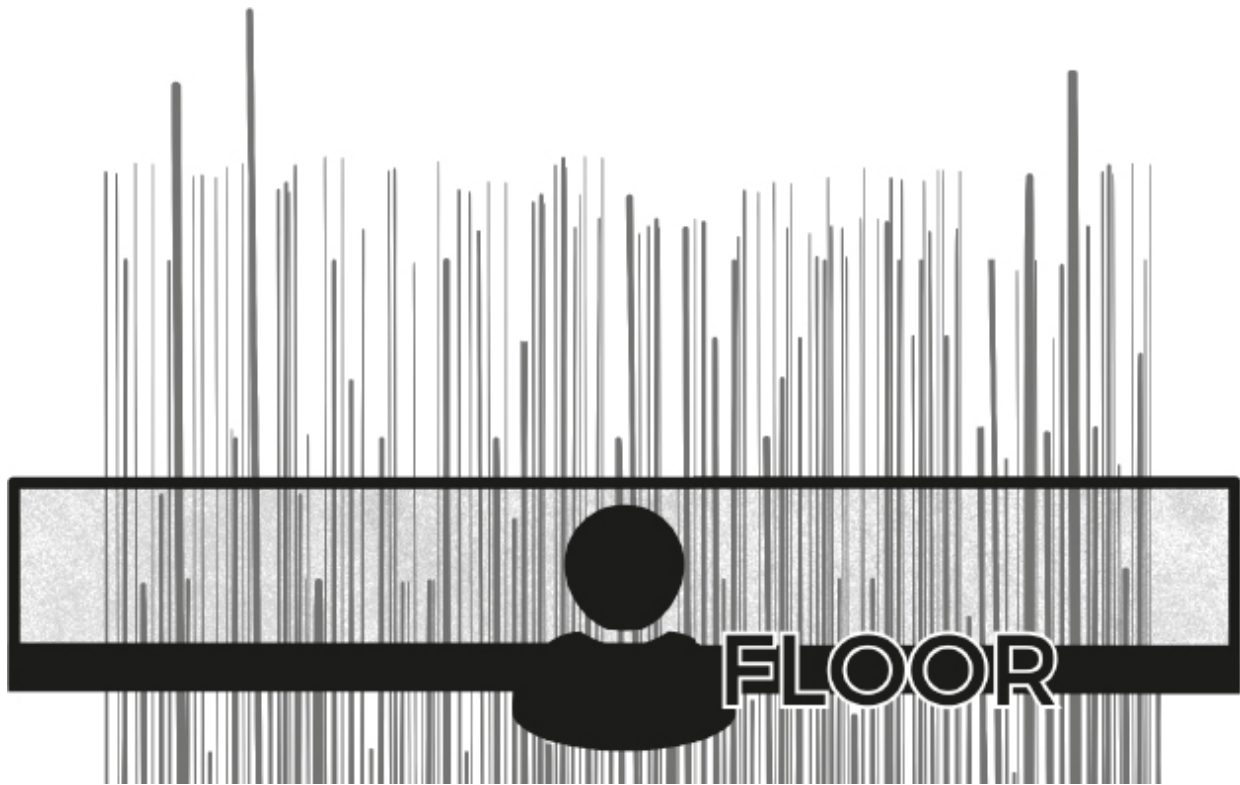
This is what most people get wrong about growth. To elevate to a totally new level of results and performance, the immediate effect is exposure. It almost feels like you’re naked. It’s immediately obvious that you’re not yet what the new level *requires* you to be.

The question now becomes: Are you willing to own that?

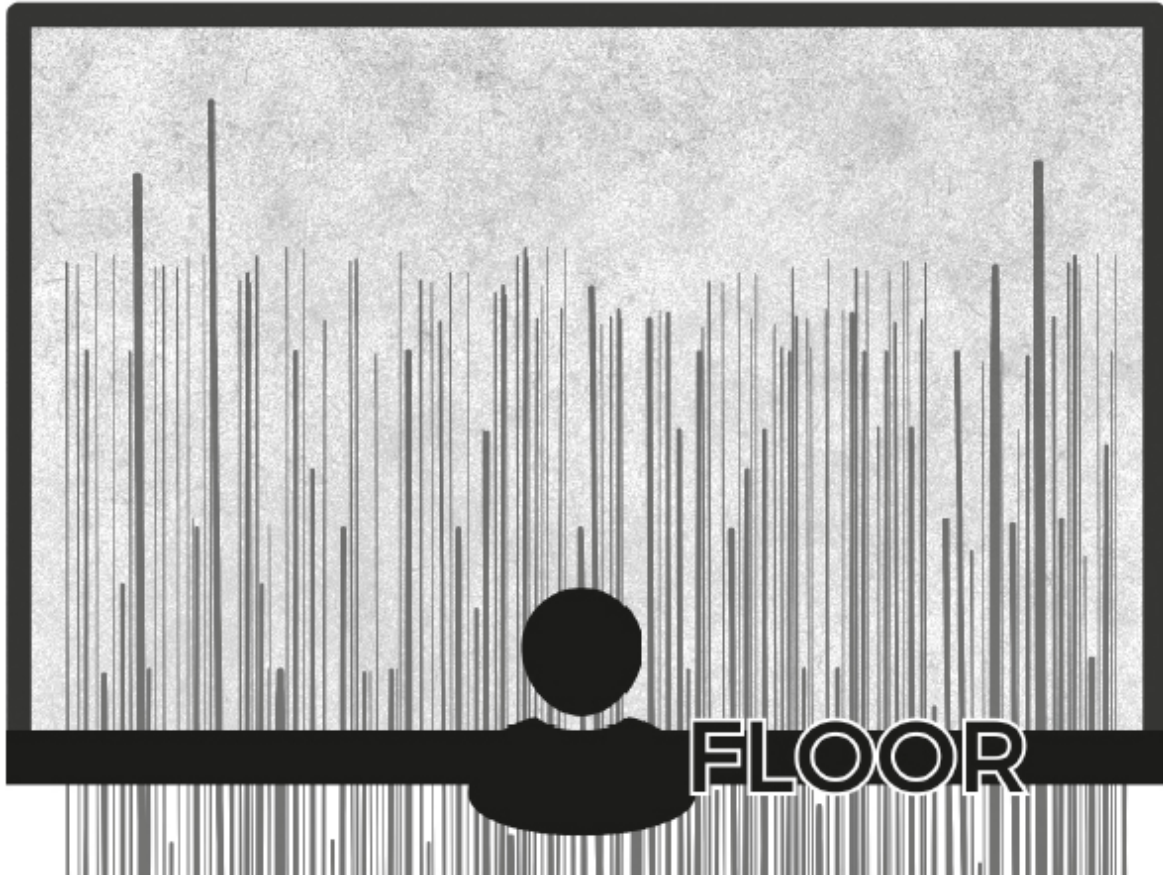
Are you willing to be exposed where you currently are, rather than pretending you're where your ceiling is?

The truth sets you free. It's not a weakness owning your current deficiencies. The weakness is in continuing to lie to yourself: in not being accountable, not raising your floor and normalizing a new level of performance, and not weeding out what no longer fits.

Once you raise your floor and eliminate anything and everything that contradicts the level of performance and results you want, your growth will explode.



When your frame is low, your floor is also low. When your floor is low, you're saying yes to all sorts of things that contradict scaling. With a low floor, there is a lot of noise and distraction in your life. Until you eliminate it, scaling isn't a reality for you, only a potential.



Even if you “raise your frame” or vision for yourself, you will not realize higher results until you raise your floor. Despite sometimes showing flashes of what you could be, more often than not your performance will be subpar. You’ll still be caught up in noise that holds you back, more than you even realize. Your performance will suffer, and you won’t be able to reach the level of consistency your goal demands. Going below the floor means you’re effectively lying to yourself. In Alcoholics Anonymous (AA) there’s a phrase: “All progress starts by telling the truth.”¹¹ Until you’re willing to face the truth and even fully expose where you really are in this moment, you’re not ready to scale. Until you’re willing to take a hard look at everything you’re currently saying yes to and remove everything stopping you from being accountable to the new goal, you’re lying to yourself.

RAISING YOUR FLOOR = RAISING YOUR CHARACTER AND MATURITY

Commitment is key to consciousness. Not more commitment. Clear commitment. You can tell what you’re committed to by the results you are producing. . . . Everyone is 100 percent committed. You

can't get any more committed. You're committed and the evidence of your commitment is the results you're producing. This is both unnerving and liberating. It's unnerving because we are confronted with the reality of our results and it's liberating because we can clarify and change our commitments. We are empowered.

— JIM DETHMER, COACH, SPEAKER, AND AUTHOR¹²

While writing this book, I interviewed a man who is regularly hired by government leaders throughout the world to analyze and help them with their economic systems. Because of his position, I'll simply call him Quinn. Quinn's been involved in the development and change of economic systems for entire countries, both developed and underdeveloped.

When I asked Quinn, "What's the primary difference between countries that are thriving economically and those that aren't?" he replied: *Accountability*.

He then elaborated:

The wealthy countries have much higher levels of accountability and transparency in the system as well as by the leaders of those systems. The struggling countries don't have high accountability from the system or their leaders. This trickles down to the culture of the people. In underdeveloped countries, there's far less accountability, less productivity, and more crime.

A client of mine is the founder of a successful private equity firm that invests in midsize technology companies. They regularly buy companies doing between \$20 and \$50 million in revenue and then aggressively scale them 10x to build them into category leaders.

He told me that when they purchase a new company, the leadership team has to also scale and increase their capabilities to run a larger enterprise. And in looking to put "the best players on the field in every game," not everyone in the original C-suite may be able to keep up. Not because the former team members aren't capable but because they aren't capable *enough* to reach the next level and largely because they are too committed to the past.

One of the businesses they purchased is a digital communication, compliance, and surveillance company called Smarsh. At the time of acquisition, this software as a service (SaaS) company was generating almost \$40 million in annual revenue. The reason for its success was largely

based on the founder Steve Marsh's relentless focus on the quality and innovation of the product.

In 2001, when Steve started the company, he helped clients comply with new and important regulatory requirements for financial services companies to archive, store, and monitor their electronic communications. Back then, the communications data primarily consisted of e-mail.

Steve worked tirelessly to make the software the absolute best-in-class offering for the company's clients. He long dreamed of one day being the leader in the communications and surveillance software market for the biggest banks in the world.

In 2012, Steve sold a majority stake in Smarsh to a publicly traded company called Quest Software (NASDAQ:QSFT), which in turn was then purchased by Dell Computers (NASDAQ:DELL), which was also publicly traded at the time. Over the years and under corporate ownership, the Smarsh management team broadened their reach beyond the financial services industry, horizontally marketing their services to a wide range of other sectors. While this diversification increased the total addressable market (TAM), it also diluted the differentiation and impact of Smarsh's offerings, which are custom tailored for regulated markets.

When the private equity firm later carved out Smarsh in 2016, they refocused its commitment to the financial services industry. They knew that with increased focus and innovation in regulated markets, Smarsh could organically and rapidly scale by selling a broader array of products and services that are purpose built for this vertical market. The go-to-market motion was simplified and customer acquisition costs were much more favorable with a narrower focus.

They also made strategic acquisitions to boost Smarsh's technological capabilities, acquiring leading technologies funded by other venture capital firms.

In 2018, the company acquired Actiance, which allowed Smarsh to expand its enterprise-grade offerings to some of the largest banks in the world. Today, 18 out of the top 20 global banks (excluding China) are clients of Smarsh.

In 2020, Smarsh acquired Digital Reasoning, which enhanced the company's ability to apply artificial intelligence to actively surveil the communications data captured and stored in its archives. Both venture-

backed acquisition targets were posting substantial operating losses at the time of acquisition and required significant effort to integrate.

In six years, Smarsh went from less than \$40 million in revenue to over \$300 million. About half of the growth was organic, based on laser focusing on the financial services industry. The other half was through acquisition.

Management worked hard to profitably integrate these acquisitions while continuing to build on their cutting-edge technologies. As the company neared a 10x growth in revenue, Smarsh needed another floor raise to maximize its full potential. The company needed to redefine its culture and its north star as a unified business.

The owners of Smarsh recognized its potential to become a billion-dollar company, but achieving this goal required making difficult changes. It didn't matter how cutting edge and innovative the technology was. Smarsh needed a level of *leadership* it hadn't seen before—one that raised the focus, commitment, and accountability of the entire system and culture.

A rigorous and intensive search to find the right leader began. It ultimately came down to two people, and Kim Crawford Goodman was chosen. Kim had a successful executive track record, but never as a CEO, yet the private equity firm believed she could lead Smarsh to a more profitable and undisputed category-leading position.

Kim became CEO of Smarsh in June 2022. She and the private equity firm were in complete alignment of vision regarding Smarsh—to make it a high-growth and profitable business as well as the undisputed global leader in advanced communications surveillance, with a multibillion-dollar valuation. To realize that vision, Kim knew she needed a world-class team with a culture of high performance and accountability—throughout the organization, not just within the leadership team.

Kim noticed that the culture was based too much on legacy and not enough on performance. Many within the company had come to expect large bonuses and raises, regardless of the metrics.

Eight weeks into being CEO, Kim cut Smarsh's workforce by nearly 20 percent, laying off hundreds of employees.

This wasn't a popular decision.

The company's financial performance was not communicated to the broader staff. Most remaining team members had no information about Smarsh's financial position and felt Kim had acted too hastily in her

decision. While some knew Smarsh wasn't efficient, they didn't know how to fix it.

It was a difficult time for the company.

Kim also eliminated many cloud-based vendors Smarsh had been using. She closed several of the company's satellite offices, letting go of leases and real estate where the company wasn't producing excellence.

A few months later, Kim made another round of aggressive cuts of hundreds more employees. Kim wasn't cutting for the sake of cutting. She was very methodical and rigorous in remodeling Smarsh, removing all aspects that couldn't become a billion-dollar company.

The team not only had to be world-class, operating as the global leader in its space, but also have the product as *the* focus. Sure, Smarsh's technology and services were strong, but they needed to continually innovate and get *better* if they wanted to be both high-growth and profitable.

In addition to raising the culture and excellence within Smarsh, it was clear to Kim she needed to raise the floor and maturity in how they approached their clients, especially their biggest clients. Too often, some of Smarsh's biggest clients tended to call the shots, pushing Smarsh around and asking for all sorts of services that weren't commercially viable for the enterprise software vendor.

In the past, Smarsh approached client relationships with the mindset of just being grateful to work with them. Kim had several open and uncomfortable conversations with these clients, renegotiating the terms of the relationship. Kim wanted to make sure that the clients fully understood the value of Smarsh they received, and that if the company was expected to stay ahead of their requirements, the deal would need to be fair. Smarsh had historically given away much of their product for free, and that would hurt the partnership in the long run.

Though some clients were initially frustrated and upset, Kim helped them understand that by operating in a more systematic and clear way, the service Smarsh provided them would improve, not lessen. The company now handles over 100 different types of communications, from e-mail to mobile texts to WhatsApp to chats and voice, to name just a few.

Kim was willing to lose some clients if that was required to elevate the maturity and position of both the company and the services they provided. She was willing to disappoint or upset both clients and team members, not to be difficult but to be clear, professional, and world-class. She knew Smarsh

could never be a global leader if it didn't have a clear and high floor in how it operated all around.

Without a clear and high floor, no one wins.

Within 18 months of Kim becoming CEO—from June 2022 to December 2023—Smarsh went from less than breakeven to over \$100 million in annual profits and \$400 million in revenue. It is now forecasted to reach over \$500 million in annual revenue and \$200 million in profits in 2025. Kim Goodman is now one of the top CEOs and leader of one of the largest privately held technology companies in the United States.

By the end of 2024, Smarsh was valued as a multibillion-dollar company, just two and a half years after Kim became CEO.

Smarsh was recently recognized with a first-ever Legacy Award for ranking among the Inc. 5000 fastest-growing companies for a record 17 years in a row. Routinely recognized as the leader in its space in Gartner's Magic Quadrant research, Smarsh had been strong for a long time. But its most explosive growth and profitability came with an intensive raising of the floor.

Raising the floor—in the maturity, accountability, and capability—*was the crux* of Smarsh's explosive innovation and profitability. The level of scaling Smarsh experienced could not have happened without the commitment and leadership of Kim Goodman. She raised the floor all around in Smarsh—from the team and culture, to the quality of the product, to the systems and processes of how they served their clients.

Everything Kim did was filtered by the frame of Smarsh being *the* unquestioned global leader in its space, valued at billions of dollars.

Nothing less was acceptable.

In order to get Smarsh where it could be, Kim had to face the absolute truth and reality of where Smarsh then was when she became CEO. Facing and owning the truth of where Smarsh was—the good and the bad—gave Kim the power to make hard decisions others weren't willing to make.

In the book *The 50th Law*, the strategy author Robert Greene details the life of rapper 50 Cent, who grew up in the streets, got shot, and chose a better life. He ultimately became one of the top rappers in the world and even now is among the top businessmen in his industry.^{[13](#)}

One of the core lessons Greene drew from 50 was fully accepting, even embracing, the harshest and rawest truth possible. As 50 Cent stated,

“Reality is my drug. The more I have of it, the more power I get and the higher I feel.”

Greene summed it up this way: “If I could simplify the whole game of power and strategy in one equation, it would all hinge on the capacity to see events around you exactly as they are. The closer your mind is to reality, the better your strategies, your responses in life.”

Scaling a system—whether an entire country, a business, or even your own life—requires raising the floor, as Kim Crawford did at Smarsh.

Raising the floor ultimately means *raising transparency and accountability*. Again, as stated by Kim, most of Smarsh’s remaining team after her first round of aggressive cuts didn’t realize how inefficient Smarsh then was. Hard filtering every aspect of the system and being radically honest about what couldn’t scale was part of Kim’s superpower. She embraced reality, then transformed it.

For a system to scale, that system must have extremely high transparency and accountability. Often, people won’t want a higher degree of accountability for their performance or transparency in what they’re doing. Those are the types of people who get eliminated when the floor is being raised.

In an organization, the “culture” and floor are ultimately one and the same. The culture is the agreed-upon level of transparency and accountability in the system. When you raise the floor, you raise the culture—who is in the organization, what the expected performance is, what the consistent results are.

To scale, you’ll need people who *want* to be held accountable, who are willing to fully expose themselves, especially in their mistakes.

Are you willing to raise your floor?

Are you willing to cut everything from your system that can’t or won’t reach the vision you’re committed to?

FILTER FASTER

Lessons are repeated until they are learned.

— CHERIE CARTER-SCOTT, IN *IF LIFE IS A GAME, THESE ARE THE RULES*¹⁴

In her book *Quit: The Power of Knowing When to Walk Away*, Annie Duke, a professional poker player and expert in decision-making, explains that professional poker players play far fewer hands than amateurs do.¹⁵

Whereas amateurs play lots of hands that are doomed to fail from the beginning, the pros are fast folders. They *filter out* far more bad hands than the amateurs.

Because their floor is much higher, when they *do* play, they hit the bull's-eye much more often. Hence, they make far more money while the amateurs lose more money.

Duke explains the *escalation of commitment* that occurs for amateurs who, once invested even in a bad hand, can't let it go.¹⁶ They keep piling more into it, even after they become aware they're better off folding.

Escalation of commitment is a byproduct of sunk-cost bias, and it keeps you on a course of action far longer than helpful.¹⁷ The phrase to describe this is "throwing good money after bad."

If you're ready to scale, sunk-cost bias can't be your game.

You can't keep holding on to what was, just because you're invested—maybe even heavily invested. The question isn't whether you were previously holding a winning hand. The question is, is it *still* a winning hand?

In order to scale, you've got to become a pro at letting go.

This can't be a long and delayed process. Like professional poker players, you've got to fold fast when it's time to move on. You've also got to fast-filter and skip the bad hands that distract or delay your growth.

Blake Erickson, the co-author of this book, is a master of high-filtering and fast folding. As a young missionary in Lima, Peru, Blake started his two-year mission with the personal and impossible goal of baptizing over 100 people into the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. The average missionary in Lima at that time baptized approximately 10 people during their two-year mission.

Nearly one year in, Blake had baptized *four people*. He had a decision to make: keep doing what he was doing or raise his floor.

He decided to filter much more aggressively every person he talked to. He created three filtering questions to determine whether someone was even capable of being baptized, let alone wanted to: 1) Do you work on Sunday? 2) Are you married? 3) Will you attend church this Sunday?

These filtering questions were essential because if a person wasn't willing or able to come to church, they weren't a good candidate to make a commitment like baptism. If they wouldn't come *this week*, they probably weren't ready to commit.

If they weren't married but living with a partner, they weren't a good candidate for baptism unless they were willing to get married. Living with a partner you're not married to goes against the teachings of the church.

Because Blake was committed to his impossible goal of baptizing over 100 people during his mission, he realized he had to filter the people he taught more aggressively so that he could actually find people who not only wanted to be baptized but were also ready to be.

Admittedly, for the first year of his mission, like the amateur poker players, Blake was spending lots of time teaching people who enjoyed his visits but were never going to get baptized. He'd often spend weeks, sometimes months, visiting and teaching people he loved but who weren't ready for commitments to God.

Many missionaries become satisfied being busy doing service and teaching. But Blake, like Tom Brady referenced in [Chapter 1](#), reached the level of commitment that has a singular objective. He wanted to *baptize*.

He didn't want to broaden his focus on metrics of success.

By establishing this unconventional yet effective filtering process during the second year of his mission, Blake *did not teach anyone* who wasn't both capable of and desirous of being baptized. He spoke to literally hundreds of people daily on the busy streets of Lima, Peru. During the first 30 seconds, he hard-filtered the people with his filtering questions.

If they didn't pass the three questions, he moved on.

No harm, no foul. This wasn't about convincing people to join but instead about finding the people *ready and wanting* to join.

Thirty seconds or less is how fast Blake could filter a person, while other missionaries continued investing days, weeks, and sometimes months teaching people who were never going to be baptized.

Playing bad hands.

Not raising the floor fast enough.

The result was that Blake ended his mission with *118 baptisms*, 18 over his impossible goal. To get there, he had to raise his floor, because until he did that, he wasn't ready or committed to realizing his impossible goal.

Until he raised his floor, his commitment was to the activities and the results he got during the first year of his mission.

Raising the floor meant truly learning the lesson, such that Blake could walk away from his former way of doing things.

The chess prodigy and tai chi world champion Josh Waitzkin wrote in *The Art of Learning* (quoted previously in [Chapter 1](#)), “I have long believed that if a student of virtually any discipline could avoid ever repeating the same mistake twice—both technical and psychological—he or she would skyrocket to the top of their field.”¹⁸

Raising the floor is *the crux* of scaling. It’s the hardest part and until you do it, you’re fooling yourself. But once you do it, your growth literally explodes.

The faster you raise your floor, the less you’ll be caught up in the noise that will ultimately pull you down.

When you’re operating below your floor, it’s psychologically stressful, creating tension. You know intuitively you’re saying “yes” to something holding you back. Especially if you’re a caring and empathetic person, it can create feelings of guilt holding the floor and saying no to people, whether team members, friends, clients, etc. Yet, your floor represents your level of accountability, honesty, and transparency. Thus, by being honest and clear, you may disappoint people but they will ultimately respect you because they know you’re being honest.

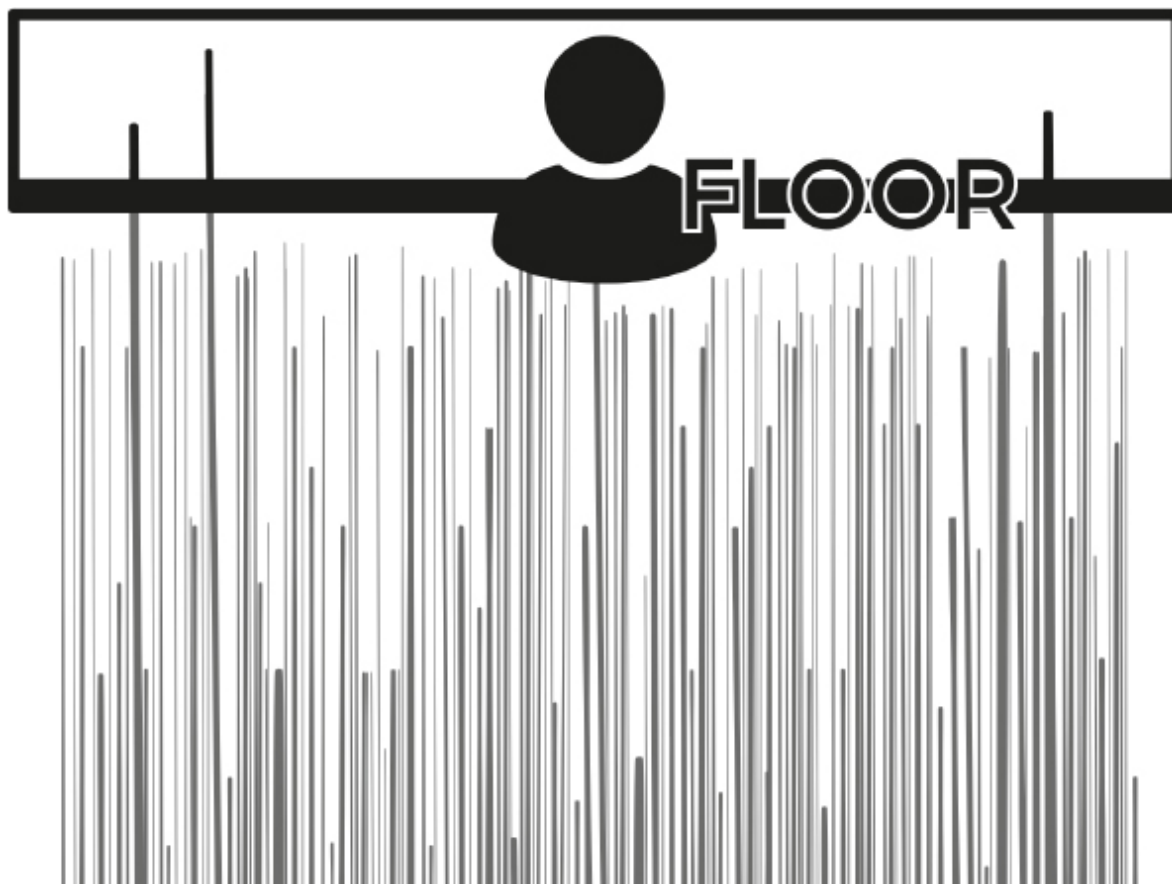
Here’s what will happen for you as you actively eliminate what’s below the floor, or say “no” faster to things that somewhat scare you to say no to. When you do it, the tension will dissipate. Almost immediately, you’ll experience relief and a jolt of energy. This is the natural byproduct of increasing your accountability and honesty, especially with yourself.

No matter how “successful” you get, this lesson won’t go away. You’ll have to continually raise your floor if you want to keep growing; otherwise, you’ll stagnate. And the risk of stagnation isn’t just remaining where you are.

Actually, raising the floor becomes increasingly important *the more successful* you become. As you become successful, the yeses become more expensive. One wrong yes—such as taking on the wrong client or project—could put at risk everything you’re now doing. It might even cost you your health or family.

If you don't raise your floor, the risk isn't just missing your potential. The risk is complete failure. We've all seen this—people who said yes to the wrong things and it ultimately sank their lives.

The powerful and beautiful thing is that raising your floor not only increases your maturity and character as a person but also literally elevates everything you're doing. It makes you a better person. A better partner. A better leader.



When you raise your floor, it means you're no longer justifying things in your life that hold you back. You're making uncomfortable, sometimes unpopular, decisions. You're letting go of something that was acceptable before but no longer is. You're increasing your character, maturity, and standard in all you do. This is crucial to leadership, culture, and scaling.

JOURNAL PROMPTS & APPLICATIONS

- What in your life or business do you already know is below your floor?
What do you feel the biggest risk of eliminating this is?
- What have you delayed eliminating for far too long?
- What conversation have you delayed for far too long?
- Go to scaling.com/book1 and complete the form to evaluate your current readiness to scale.

CHAPTER 4

Simplify Your System

Simplicity enables change. I think it is the primary source of real agility. Agility means to do something. It does not mean to do it over. It does not mean to redo it. It does not mean to undo it. It means to do it. It means that I am here, and I am going to go there. . . . That is agility. And if you are dragging an elephant around, you are never going to be agile.

— RICH HICKEY, CREATOR OF THE CLOJURE PROGRAMMING LANGUAGE¹

In the early 20th century, Argentina was one of the wealthiest and most prized countries in the world. Known as the “breadbasket of the world” with its rich natural resources, growing exports of quality beef and grain, and its cosmopolitan cities, Argentina’s wealth rivaled the United States and Australia.

Less than 100 years later, its economy was a dumpster fire—*one of the worst in the world!*

From 1946 when Juan Domingo Perón became president all the way through 2023, Argentina has been plagued by corrupt, careless, and misinformed leadership.

Perón, though popular during his presidency, introduced expansive welfare programs and labor policies that, even decades after his reign, crippled Argentina’s economy and culture. He created dependency by giving too much government assistance. He destroyed entrepreneurship by exerting state and governmental controls over several industries, facilitating inefficiency and corruption.

Then Argentina went through a series of dictatorial presidents who overinvested in military and ballooned the nation's debt by nearly a factor of 10 during the late 1970s to mid-1980s. Policies were put in place to de-industrialize the economy, favoring imports over local production. The byproduct was a plummeting industrial sector with huge job losses.

By the late 1980s, loose monetary policies and extreme debt led to hyperinflation—up to *nearly 3,000 percent*—driving the peso's value to practically nothing.² Despite attempts to peg the peso to the dollar to stabilize the economy, these attempts failed, and the economy entirely collapsed. Prices skyrocketed and people couldn't afford basic things like groceries. The wealthy class fled to more stable countries.

At rock bottom in 2001, Argentina defaulted on its sovereign debts, causing nearly all of the world to lose both trust and interest in the country. It was one of the most extreme and devastating freefalls witnessed in modern times, from an economic and cultural leader to the absolute dregs, with zero credibility from within or without.

As if this weren't bad enough—more than a generation of people's livelihood was stolen from them by poor leadership and mismanagement—the next 20 years didn't get any better.

During the 2000s, all the way to 2023, the Argentine government increased government policies, making business and economic growth nearly impossible. These policies increased inflation and further reduced Argentina's appeal to foreign investors.

During the 2023 presidential elections, the economy was again on the brink of complete collapse.

Inflation was over 140 percent for the year.

More than 40 percent of the population was in deep poverty.

A bloated public sector with far too many government workers ate up nearly 40 percent of the country's entire GDP (gross domestic product).

Their foreign reserves—such as foreign currencies, gold, and government bonds—were at record lows, with the country threatening default on its looming debt repayments.³

It was clear to the Argentine people they needed change.

Drastic change.

And quick.

Javier Milei, a well-known and somewhat extreme economics professor and business consultant, felt that God had called him to fix the situation. For

over two decades, Milei taught growth economics at multiple universities throughout Argentina. He gained prominence as a television pundit, criticizing Argentina's political and economic establishment.^{4,5}

Milei felt strongly that the government was the main obstacle to Argentina's prosperity.

He felt it needed to be hacked and stripped down to the studs. Which is why as part of his 2022–2023 presidential campaign, he would regularly come on stage with rock music and a chainsaw in his hand screaming profanities and saying the government needed to be cut down.

Economic liberalization and anti-establishment comprised Milei's bold message.

It resonated.

Milei was inaugurated president of Argentina on December 10, 2023. Over the next 12 months, Argentina experienced perhaps the greatest economic shift of all time. His key initiatives were dollarizing the economy (replacing the peso) and radically minimizing government. He wanted to turn the state into a facilitator of growth rather than a participant.

During 2024, Milei simplified the 24 government ministries down to eight, eliminating key positions in education, health, and social development. He eliminated over 300 government regulations, targeting ones that restricted agriculture and small businesses. He dissolved the complex tax system within the government and replaced it with a simplified, flat-tax structure administered by a streamlined agency.

Finally, to scale Argentina's economic growth, Milei intensified the focus on Argentina's strengths, which are agriculture and natural energy. To incentivize growth and foreign investment, he slashed taxes on agricultural goods. Through his deregulations, he created an entrepreneurial environment where startups could attract foreign partnerships.

To further increase the economy in Argentina, Milei formed strategic and economic alliances with countries like the United States, the European Union, China, and others, seeking to get foreign investment rolling again into Argentine products and services.

By the end of Milei's first year as president, inflation had gone from 140 down to 2.7 percent. For the first time in over 50 years, the government had achieved a fiscal budget surplus, with over \$3 billion in surplus cash. The peso had largely stabilized and the default risk dramatically shrank,

increasing the confidence of other countries, which led to billions of dollars in new foreign investment in Argentina's economy.⁶

Although Milei has basically done the impossible the past 12 months and created incredible progress, the jury is still out on whether he'll ultimately succeed. What he's attempting is reversing 100 years of bad leadership and corruption. But the moves he's making are in line with good strategy, system design, and scaling principles.

In order to scale a system, you've got to simplify it.

Simplifying a system is extremely rigorous work—especially emotionally. You've got to make uncomfortable and unpopular decisions that impact not only you but also others.

There's an unattributed quote: *The system is designed to defend the system.*

This will always be the case when simplifying a system so it can scale in a new and better direction.

Milei wants Argentina to scale. His impossible goal is that it becomes one of the thriving economies and cultures of the world again. To do this, he has to simplify the system and strip out the complexity keeping Argentina broke.

He's got to increase the transparency and accountability of the system. This is why he wants to get on the dollar system, which is inherently a more accountable currency. He's got to laser focus on the few key initiatives where growth can explode, then make massive swings to get increasing resources that fuel the fire.

In the previous chapter, you learned the hard truth about scaling: it doesn't matter how high your vision is; if you don't raise your floor, *you won't scale*. The hardest part about raising your floor is being fully honest with yourself and then removing everything in your life and business that's holding you down.

In this chapter, you'll learn the next layer of raising your floor. This will require simplifying your system or business further than you think necessary.

You may not be in a situation like Argentina where simplifying your system is essential for survival. Maybe your business is doing quite well. But the truth is, you won't be able to radically scale, say 10x to 100x or more, without stripping out much if not all of what you're now doing.

Scaling always involves simplifying and remodeling, then aggressively moving forward on the new and innovative pathway.

STOP TRYING TO OPTIMIZE SEVERAL THINGS

Simple can be harder than complex: you have to work hard to get your thinking clean to make it simple. But it's worth it in the end, because once you get there, you can move mountains.

— STEVE JOBS⁷

When Steve Jobs returned to Apple in 1997, Apple was in serious trouble, losing over \$1 billion per year.

At the time of Jobs's return, Apple had around 350 products. Jobs's first move was to cut it down to around 10 connected products, refocusing the company. He also secured a \$150 million investment from Microsoft, helping restore confidence in the company.

By 1998, just a year after his return, Apple reported a \$309 million *profit* for the fiscal year. The turnaround was solidified with the launch of the iMac G3, which became a massive success.⁸

Steve Jobs said, “People think focus means saying yes to the thing you’ve got to focus on. But that’s not what it means at all. It means saying no to the hundred other good ideas that there are. . . . Innovation is saying no to 1,000 things.”⁹

Simplicity is essential to scaling.

Most systems aren’t simple enough *to* scale. There are far too many things going on in the business, whether tiered product lines, multiple competing offers, etc.

Scaling requires focus.

Focus requires simplicity.

In a talk titled “Simplicity Matters,” the computer coder and inventor Rich Hickey explained that simplicity is essential for *changing* something—whether a country, a business, a habit, or even a piece of written code—whereas complexity makes it both difficult and unlikely for change and growth to occur.¹⁰

The word *simple* comes from the Latin root *simplex*, which means “one fold” or “unentangled.” Conversely, the word *complex* derives from the Latin root *complexus*, meaning “braided” or “twisted together.”

Something simple can stand and be understood on its own.

Something complex involves interwoven components that cannot be separated, making it harder to manage or change.

During Hickey's talk, largely directed to computer coders, Hickey discusses "the elephant" that naturally emerges when they begin a new project or business. As he states:

As we keep working, what happens is: there is a new participant in our stand-up. It is growing in the corner of the room. It is this elephant. It is called "the software we have already written." The elephant of the software we have already written is actually going to completely dominate what we do. So we are asked to do more, right? . . . That first iteration is a breeze. We can do something. But as we move forward, we have to take what we already have and make it, that elephant, do more, make it do it differently, make it do things better.

What Hickey is explaining is that, *naturally*, all systems become complex. The greatest obstacle to a system advancing or scaling becomes *itself*.

If you're a coder, the "elephant" is the code you've already built, which is now a complex hairball you're trying to drag around with you, or trying to manipulate, as you attempt adjusting and moving into the future.

You may not have 350 products like Apple had when Steve Jobs returned, and which he needed to strip away to simplify Apple.

But chances are, your system is far too complex to scale.

Chances are, you're doing far too many things, most of which are holding you back.

You may not think they're holding you back.

You probably think everything you're doing makes logical sense, and that it all fits together. That everything you're doing *synergizes*.

Trust me, I thought the same thing, until a dear friend and mentor of mine, Chad Willardson, called me out hard.

He said, "Ben, I feel like you're one of the best authors in the world. But I see you doing so many other things. You make YouTube videos. You do coaching calls. Keynotes. Consulting. All of those things you're quite good at, but not like your writing. What if you quit all of that other stuff and truly focused on writing more and better books? How good do you think you could get, and how far do you think you could go?"

This brutally honest conversation was near the end of 2023.

Chad was inviting me to think far bigger about my own future self. What could I become if I actually focused?

Did I trust myself enough to cut out the majority of what I was doing?

Being honest with myself, why was I hedging so much?

Why was I doing so many things?

The shocking truth was that I thought I was focused! Yet, with my fresh eyes, and Chad's directness, it was obvious I wasn't. I was trying to optimize far too many things.

My lack of focus highlighted a lack of conviction and commitment on my part. It also highlighted my own floor—because I was saying yes to things that were good but would never be great. I was saying yes to dead-end pathways, such as a YouTube channel, which even if it scaled 10x to 100x, wouldn't have the power to produce the results I wanted.

Take all the pathways and pursuits you're currently focusing on and mentally scale each of them up to their highest potential. When you do that, does each pathway actually give you what you want?

For me, thinking about my YouTube channel, the obvious answer was no. Thinking about my coaching program, the answer was no. Same with the consulting to several big and interesting companies. So, I removed them, focusing instead on the pathway I felt could take me the furthest and that resonated with where I wanted to go. When I publicly quit my YouTube channel and let go of the marketing team managing it, I got all sorts of e-mails and texts from people, shocked. "How could you get rid of that?" they asked. "It was starting to grow really quickly."

They couldn't see the scale of my goal and that even the seemingly great things I was doing were mostly distractions. I was stripping out my own elephant's added weight so I could focus far more intensely.

Chad himself has recently simplified his own wealth management business. Already a high-end firm, he manages over a billion dollars for entrepreneurs. Yet, as he looked at his 150 client base, around 100 had between \$1 and \$10 million with him. The top 50 of his clients—which made up 90 percent of the overall money he managed—each had well over \$10 million, often closer to \$50 to \$150 million invested with him.

He decided to sell the portion of his business that was \$10 million and below. Though he loved and cared for those people, he wanted to simplify his business model even more so it could scale to the next level. He wanted

to go deeper in their firm's ability to truly support their top family office clients.

Wildly, on literally the day they sold the 100-client portion of their business, a man walked into Chad's office wanting more information about their experience. In learning more about this man, it turned out he is anticipating a pay day of over \$1 billion and wants a family office. He was looking for a specialist like Chad and his team to manage his family office money coming later in the year. This was exactly the type of person Chad wanted to work with, and it was exactly the type of work he wanted to further optimize their systems and capabilities around.

This brings up a very, very important point, one that is both psychological and spiritual. Until you remove the complexity from your system that reflects your past but not your desired future, you won't be able to powerfully filter for what you want. Your filter will be too dull, as you'll be mired in the complexity of everything below your floor that you're still systemizing. Spiritually, though, once you make bold moves and live on a higher plane, like Chad, you immediately *become a magnet* for radically bigger and aligned opportunities that can't be yours while below your floor.

GOOD STRATEGY MEANS CHOOSING WHAT YOU'RE OPTIMIZING FOR

The essence of strategy is choosing what not to do.

— DR. MICHAEL PORTER, HARVARD STRATEGY EXPERT^{[11](#)}

Warren Buffett, the CEO of Berkshire Hathaway, once said, "Diversification is protection against ignorance. It makes little sense if you know what you are doing."^{[12](#)} What Buffett means is, if you're overly diversified *in your focus*, then you don't really know what you're doing.

If you knew what you were doing, *you'd fully focus and commit*. We've heard it said that if you want to be wealthy, you need to have multiple income streams. But wealth comes through concentration of focus, not diversification of focus.

This brings up a crucial question: *What are you optimizing for?*

Your answer to that question, whether you can clearly articulate it or not, is what is shaping the system of your life and business.

If you're trying to optimize for several things, you're optimizing for none. You have a complex system that isn't scaling the way it could. You're likely experiencing 1/10th to 1/100th the growth that could be yours.

Again, honesty is a key to scaling.

You can't scale if you're still chasing vanity metrics.

Whenever I see someone doing tons of different things, I know they're lying to themselves. They've convinced themselves they're focused, but they're not. They've convinced themselves they have a synergistic system of multiple focuses when they have a complex system that's less scalable than they realize.

In his book *Good Strategy Bad Strategy*, Dr. Richard Rumelt wrote:

Having conflicting goals, dedicating resources to unconnected targets, and accommodating incompatible interests are the luxuries of the rich and powerful, but they make for bad strategy. . . . Strategy is at least as much about what an organization does not do as it is about what it does. . . . Strategy is scarcity's child and to have a strategy, rather than vague aspirations, is to choose one path and eschew others.¹³

Rumelt is right. To have strategy means to make a choice, or a decision. Making a decision means cutting away alternative options or pathways. It means choosing one path rather than fifty.

To scale 10x to 100x where you're currently at, and to achieve that growth in just a *few years* rather than a few decades, you must eliminate *most* of what you're now doing.

You've got to simplify and remodel your system so it actually can scale.

You've got to get rid of the elephant you're trying to drag around with you, making your system far more complex than you realize.

In 2018, Rory Vaden, a marketing and branding strategist, received a call from Lewis Howes. They'd known each other for years, and Lewis felt he could use Rory's expertise. Though from the outside things looked like they were going well, the truth was that Lewis was a bit overwhelmed. At the time, Lewis was regularly speaking and doing his own live events; had a mastermind, coaching programs, and a membership site; had just released a new book; and was considering another coaching program.¹⁴

All told, Lewis had 17 different streams of income.

Also at that time, his podcast was growing extremely well, with over 30 million downloads. In dissecting each part of Lewis's business, it became clear to Rory that Lewis viewed the podcast as a fringe part of his business but not the core of it. "What if you just focused solely on scaling your podcast?" Rory asked.

Lewis was immediately excited and decided that for the next few years, he would say no to practically everything that wasn't his podcast. He began systematically eliminating what he'd been doing, from his elite masterminds to his coaching programs, etc. He walked away from millions of dollars of easy revenue to focus. Over the next two years, with relentless focus on his podcast, it went from 30 million downloads to over 500 million downloads, becoming one of the biggest in the entire world.

In order to scale, you've got to strip out the elephant of your complex system. To raise the floor and simplify, you start from the frame of an impossible goal. That goal is what shapes and simplifies the focus of your new system. Of course, letting go of the elephant, despite being needed to scale, can be emotional.

Take, for example, Stephanie (mentioned in the Introduction of this book), who is the CEO of a family business that provides a highly specialized product. This product was invented and patented by her father over 50 years ago. Though he passed over a decade ago, the company continues to serve their clients and, in 2023, made approximately \$30 million in revenue.

Since her father's passing, Stephanie has felt that transitioning the business to provide services, not just their niche products, would be important for the growth of the company. The product side that's been the basis of their company, though amazing, doesn't really have much potential to scale from where they're at.

Stephanie knows this.

She's wanted to make some acquisitions to bolster the services side of the business, maybe a nearby industry partner they've worked with for years. Despite being in entrepreneurial training programs for over a decade, Stephanie has never been able to pull the trigger on any acquisitions.

Stephanie joined our program in early 2024 and learned The Scaling Framework. She was challenged to set an impossible goal and to utilize that goal to reframe and remodel her business to scale. She changed her 2024 revenue goal from \$35 million to \$70 million.

Once that goal was established, it became painfully obvious that she couldn't grow that fast focusing on the products that defined their company. She couldn't get to \$70 million in even a decade, let alone 12 months, simply by attempting to scale their products.

The impossible goal made it dead obvious that to scale the company that high and that aggressively, she'd need to finally get serious about the services side of the company, which she'd known for many years was the right pathway.

As part of the program, Stephanie committed to making the acquisition of her industry partner within 90 days, even though she had no clue whether the other company would even be willing to sell.

She called the owner, who had been a long time friend. "Hey, are we going to keep dating, or do you want to finally get married?" She was talking about merging the companies.

He laughed.

After their discussion, she was amazed how cheap she was actually able to acquire the company. The owner wasn't a good business operator and preferred just having a salary. So, getting acquired was actually great for him as well.

In buying this company, Stephanie now had an incredibly talented and capable team, including the services they provided. All of this was a quantum leap to the services side of Stephanie's business, and they were now ready to really begin scaling.

During a follow-up conversation I had with Stephanie during this time, she reported to me the moves she was making. She told me of the acquisition and integration of the new company. She told me they were increasing their focus on the services side of the business.

I asked her, "Are you willing to simplify your business and focus to achieve your impossible goal of \$70 million in revenue this year?"

She replied, "With new technologies, we can shift our product side of the company over to e-commerce and, honestly, not really think about it. Instead, we can focus on scaling the services side of the business, which I believe can get us to our \$70 million goal."

I then asked, "What would happen if you simply sold the product side of the business?"

Audibly, she let out a loud and surprised, "Whoaaaaa!"

It had never dawned on her that she could fully remove the main product, simplify and remodel their system, and scale in a totally new direction. Her plan was to keep and maintain the product side of the business and to just largely ignore it.

After pondering for a bit, Stephanie replied, somewhat thinking out loud, “What’s interesting about what you’re saying is, since we’ve acquired our competitor, we’ve set up a new holding company separating the products and services sides of our business. Also, we have a strategic partner we’ve had for over 40 years that would love to buy the product side of the business.”

I then asked her another zinger: “Stephanie, what if the goal of your company was hundreds of millions in revenue, rather than the \$70 million you’ve established? Do you see a way of getting there if you solely focused on the services you’re offering?”

“Absolutely,” she replied. “In fact, there is another company similar to the one we just acquired that is about to go bankrupt, and it is chock-full of PhD-level talent that would be incredibly expensive and difficult to get one at a time. I could see that if I sold off the product side of the company, I could begin making strategic acquisitions like this, and could likely surge to hundreds of millions quickly.”

That’s where our conversation ended.

Stephanie’s story is extremely common. Her company is doing well, with multiple eight figures in revenue. Yet, to 10x or more, she’ll need to simplify and remodel the business and take it in a new direction. That new direction becomes clear when reverse engineering an impossible goal, which in her case would be doing hundreds of millions in revenue within three years.

If she operated from the frame of an impossible goal, the pathways to that goal begin to emerge. But also, it becomes obvious which pathways *won’t scale to that level*. In her case, it is the elephant of her father’s products and the identity of what the company has been.

Dr. Mitsuru Igami, a Canadian economist focused on innovation, reviewed the data published in the classic book *The Innovator’s Dilemma*, by Dr. Clayton Christensen. After reviewing the data, Dr. Igami concluded that Christensen’s thesis wasn’t exactly right.¹⁵

Christensen’s core argument is that successful firms get disrupted *because* they are doing a good job, not a bad one. By increasingly specializing their services and the value they provide to higher and higher end customers, the

“bottom” of the market becomes available for disruption. In due time, smaller firms bring in new technologies, etc., which the bigger and specialized firms fail to adopt, and over time, take over the entire market.¹⁶

Although this is true, Dr. Igami’s dig into the data showed something interesting. The bigger firms didn’t get disrupted *blindly*. They had become aware long before being disrupted about new technologies or directions they could take. From their vaulted position, they actually had a better look at where the future was going. However, these firms made the conscious decision not to begin planning for the future, and instead, continued focusing on what they knew was quickly becoming an outdated model and process.

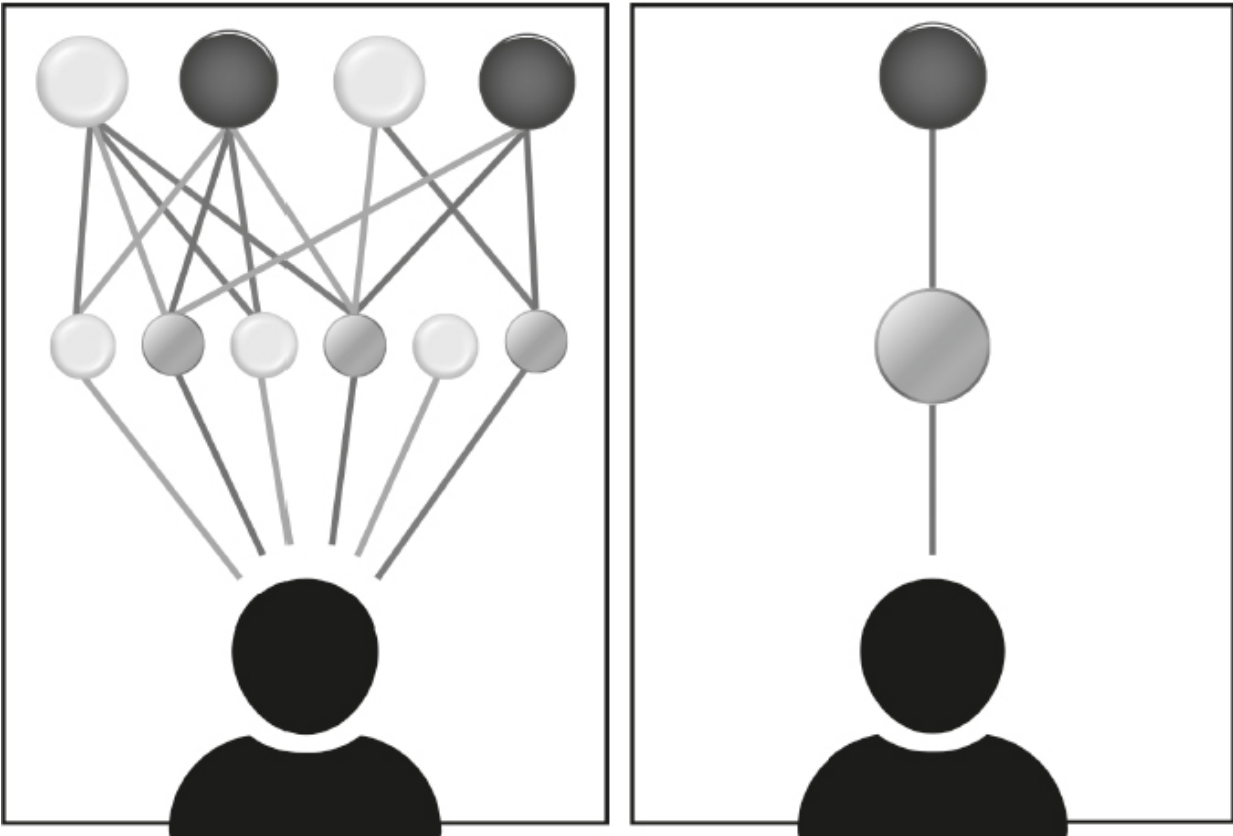
Pivoting is often extremely painful and seemingly risky for companies because it means “cannibalizing” their existing business or clients, and most are unwilling to face that short-term cost for the next level of scaling. In business, *cannibalization* is when a company’s new product or service competes with an existing product or services and causes a loss in sales.

Pivoting is simply another word for raising the floor.

It means letting go of some aspect of what you’re doing to increase your focus in a better, more scalable direction.

To quote the strategy expert Richard Koch, “Success, not failure, most urgently requires change. Follow the path of natural selection—if it ain’t broke, *do fix it!*”¹⁷

In other words, if you’re not continually innovating and transforming what you’re doing, then quickly—likely very quickly—your elephant will get so big and slow that your growth will hit a brick wall.



You cannot scale a complex system. Complex systems have many competing priorities and agendas and countless constraints or bottlenecks to solve. In order to scale, you have a singular objective that's framed so well it makes obvious the many things you're now doing that could never reach the goal. The impossible goal forces a focused and better path. The question is, are you willing to commit? Or will you continue hedging while trying to convince yourself you're focused?

UNTIL THE FLOOR *TRULY* BECOMES THE FLOOR, YOU WON'T SCALE

The difference between successful people and really successful people is that really successful people say no to almost everything.

— WARREN BUFFETT^{[18](#)}

On April 20, 2023, I spoke at the EOS (Entrepreneurial Operating System) annual event in Indianapolis, Indiana, to an audience of over 2,000

entrepreneurs. In my 60-minute keynote, I taught two specific frameworks: my never-before-published holistic time model (detailed in the Appendix of this book), as well as the 10x vs. 2x 80/20 model Dan Sullivan and I developed for our third book, *10x Is Easier Than 2x*.

As I walked off stage, Tom Wood, the CEO of Floor Coverings International (FCI), a large franchise business, turned to his right-hand leader Chad and said, “We need to better understand that material!” Chad agreed.

Three months after the EOS event, I spoke with Tom on the phone for the first time. He asked what it would take for me to come out and train his leadership team for a day on the concepts I taught from the stage.

He said he was willing to invest whatever it took, because he really wanted FCI to become a billion-dollar company and felt I could help them get there.

I asked Tom, “When do you want to reach one billion dollars in revenue?”

“Seven years,” he replied, “2030.”

An arbitrary round number, I thought.

I pushed back, referencing “time as a tool,” which I taught during my EOS keynote.

“What does seven years require of you today?” I asked.

“What do you mean?” Tom replied.

“The primary value and purpose of a goal is its impact on your direction and decisions today,” I explained. “The future is a tool to simplify the present.”

“If you committed to one billion dollars in three years, rather than seven, how would that change things here and now?” I asked.

“We’d have to make some big changes ASAP!” he replied.

I was already starting to love Tom. I felt a kinship with him and wanted to be a part of his process.

That August, I did a full-day training at FCI’s corporate headquarters with Tom and his 15-person corporate leadership team. During that training, we established \$1 billion in annual revenue in three years as the new frame or “impossible” goal. From there, we established the floor to reach \$1 billion, which was having all their franchisees averaging \$2 million-plus in annual revenue. At the time, the average franchisee was doing \$700,000.

During that first meeting, I stressed heavily the importance of them raising the floor if they were to reach the \$1 billion goal. As I explained:

We know \$700,000 is your current floor because that's what your current system is designed to produce. It's also the culture of your corporate team and the culture of the franchisees themselves. "By your fruits ye shall know them."

"Your new floor of two million dollars," I said flatly, "will require you to filter out everything that stops you from systematically producing two million dollars—plus franchisees. What remains will need to be simplified. If two million dollars—plus is *truly* the new floor, then anything below that is no longer acceptable. It literally goes against who you are and what you're about. Are you serious about this or not?"

It took Tom and his leadership team around six months to fully own the new floor, meaning anything below it was literally axed.

Eliminated.

Gone.

Bye.

For the first six or so months, in Tom's words, there were only "minor demonstrations" of accountability when someone on the corporate team was going below the floor. Those "minor demonstrations" were basically *words*, not serious consequences. Tom would call his leaders out, but nothing else really happened.

As the months went by and FCI's revenue remained flat, Tom's blood began to boil. He knew accountability could no longer be simply words but needed to be more major. He began firing members of the leadership team who continued investing time in any franchisees who were uncommitted to reaching the new floor.

During the second half of 2024, Tom fired and replaced more people within a six-month period than he had the previous 10 years, over 25 percent of the corporate team. He replaced long-standing team members with those far more capable and committed to getting FCI to \$1 billion in revenue.

When Tom made public the new \$2 million floor, there was extreme resistance from the majority of the franchisees. Despite being only a 2.5x jump, most of them genuinely felt getting their business to \$2 million in revenue was literally impossible.

Tom and Chad began to develop a phrase: "The floor is the floor."

What they meant by this was, *the floor really is the floor!*

Once the floor truly became the floor, not just an idea or a metaphor, the growth in the company began to skyrocket.

For the franchisees who were defensive about their performance and committed to the status quo, they were encouraged to sell back their territories and move on. Over 30 franchisees were dismissed from the company, and their territories were purchased by other franchisees who were aggressively growing.

By the end of 2024, the entire flooring industry in the United States was down an average of 7 percent. FCI as an organization was up 31 percent of what they had done the year prior.

Moreover, they were clearly surging to their \$1 billion goal. There were 18 franchisees over the \$2 million revenue baseline, many of whom were committed to reaching \$10 million-plus within three years. Additionally, they had well over 60 franchisees hard trending to \$2 to \$5 million in the next 12 months. The nearly 100 new franchisees brought on during 2024 are already passing the majority of legacy franchisees in revenue *during their first year*.

Going into 2025, Tom and his team are aggressively filtering out all franchisees who won't grow above the \$2 million floor and are aggressively filtering for tons of new franchisees who want to build \$5 to \$10 million-plus businesses within the next three years.

None of this progress occurred until Tom stopped going below the floor.

Once the floor truly became the floor, growth skyrocketed.

As a final brief example on the scaling impact of raising the floor, consider how Richie Norton and Thiefaine Magré simplified their business, Proudct. Proudct is a full-service physical product creation company that makes over 100 products at any given time, from transformers for AI data centers to journals to yoga pants. When they started, they would take anyone with any idea, no matter how small, as a client.

After seven years of taking on any client and doing pretty well with it, it became clear to Richie and Thiefaine that over 80 percent of their clients spent less than \$25,000—such as T-shirts, toys, fly-fishing rods, etc. They decided to set \$25,000 as the new floor and immediately stopped taking new clients spending less.

By setting this floor, they went from 80 percent of their clients spending less than \$25,000 to zero percent spending less, and surprisingly, now they have many clients spending \$1 million or more per project. They made the conscious decision to optimize for much bigger clients, and immediately

began getting many six- and seven-figure projects. Projects at this scale were rare before they raised their floor.

Prouduct's revenue per client 10x'd in less than two years after raising their floor. By just making that one simple choice. By simplifying their model.

As we conclude [Part 2](#) on Raising Your Floor, there are some important questions you'll need to ask yourself.

The first question is: *What are you optimizing for?*

Most people don't have a clear and compelling answer to this question. They haven't clearly defined themselves. "We do *this*."

The second question is: *What are you currently saying yes to?*

Whatever you say yes to reflects your *actual floor*, not the required floor of your goal. People often think their floor is higher than it really is. They say their keynote fee is \$50,000 but regularly accept lower ones for various reasons. The real floor is whatever you actually say yes to, and until you eliminate everything below the required floor of your goal, you won't scale.

The third question is: *What pathways are you still investing yourself in that are ultimately dead ends?*

Mentally scale up all the pathways you're currently pursuing to their highest possible place. By doing that, which of them can truly get you where you're going? Being honest with yourself, how much of what you're doing is pursuing "lesser goals" or vanity metrics, which won't scale?

Only when the floor truly becomes the floor will you begin scaling aggressively.

This will be your superpower once you're ready.

This is what most people and most companies won't do.

Simplify to scale.

JOURNAL PROMPTS & APPLICATIONS

- What is the elephant in your life and business that you're dragging around with you?
- What aspects of your complex system are diluting your focus and stopping you from 10x'ing or more what actually matters and can scale?

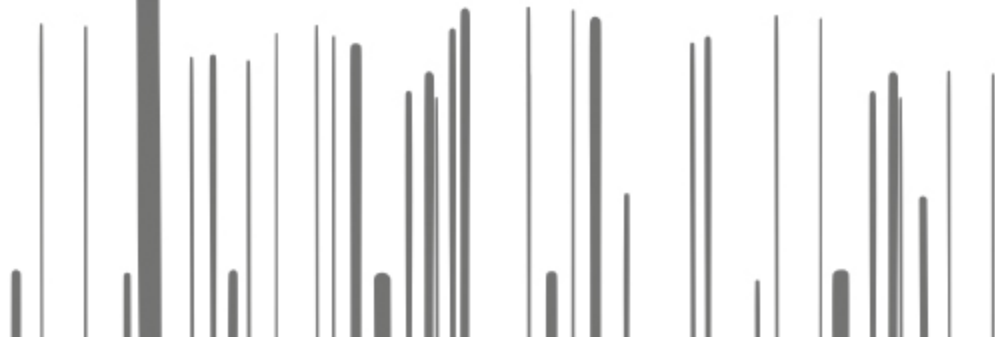
- What if the floor for a much higher future *actually became your floor*? What if you stopped saying yes to stuff that has unbelievable opportunity cost?
- Go to scaling.com/book1 and complete the form to evaluate your current readiness to scale.

PART 3

ACCELERATE YOUR FOCUS



FOCUS



CHAPTER 5

Do the Work to Engineer a Focused Path and Scalable Model

In an age of infinite leverage, judgment is the most important skill.

— NAVAL RAVIKANT¹

The company Nike's value plummeted over 50 percent (\$28 billion dollars in market cap) in just three years—from late 2021 to the end of 2024.^{2,3}

Though once a beloved American and even global powerhouse, Nike has become one of the biggest examples of *what not to do* and be in business. They've had among the worst strategy of any large and important brand in recent history.

When their public earnings were released in October of 2024, shocking the market by how bad the numbers truly were, Nike's then-CEO since January 2020, John Donahoe, stepped down. Elliott Hill, a 32-year veteran in the company known for his exceptional leadership, was named as CEO.

In his introductory remarks as CEO, Hill stated, "We're putting sport back at the center of everything that we're doing."⁴

The past several years, "sport" is not what Nike had been focusing on. *Almost everything but.*

Since at least 2017, Nike shifted its focus away from innovating the best sports gear, particularly shoes. It also shifted away from the inspiring and

empowering athlete-centric storytelling in its advertising that led the world to falling in love with them in the first place.

“*Just Do It!*” was no longer the message of Nike, nor its focus.

Rather than innovating the best-in-class footwear, Nike shifted into speculative technology like the metaverse, creating “NikeLand.” They also got involved in crypto projects, which flopped, both for themselves and their customers. They began investing lots into wearable technology and sensors, as well as data analytics.^{5,6,7}

All of this confused the market about what Nike was about.

Because their focus was widening and shifting to other sectors, naturally, the quality of their shoes nosedived—in both innovation and style.

They became lazy, relying on their older and existing popular models like the Air Force 1. Customers became fatigued and frankly bored with Nike’s shoes, as they were clearly inferior to what was being offered by other brands—such as HOKA and On Cloud in the running space and Adidas in the sports and fitness spaces.

It’s even been noted that Nike’s shoes have progressively become *uglier* and out of touch. As one commentator wrote, “Nike’s latest ‘ugly’ shoe is so bad it’s good, a bold statement that’s sure to turn heads, even if they’re not always in the right direction.”

Not only did Nike stop being excellent, but they also alienated their most important wholesale distributors. In attempts to focus more direct-to-consumer via online marketing, Nike pulled back on key distributors such as Belk, Macy’s, Dick’s Sporting Goods, Dillard’s, Zappos, Fred Meyer, Boscov’s, Big 5 Sporting Goods, and many others.⁸

Although shifting strategy based on a higher frame is essential, that’s not what Nike did. When they severed ties with long-standing wholesalers, they did so without full commitment or execution on a chosen path forward. Instead, they aimlessly drifted in many directions while the quality of their shoes went down the toilet. Not only that, but they disaffected half their customer base through extremist political marketing (more on this later).

A recipe for disaster.

Because the wholesalers were put off by Nike, they began putting Nike’s shoes on the back shelves of their stores, and instead, emphasizing brands like HOKA, On Cloud, Adidas, and others, which were massively growing in public interest and market share.

Regrettably for Nike, their anticipated growth in digital sales direct-to-consumer never eventuated. Like all things going on at Nike during this time, there was no focused execution. So even if online sales were a decent concept—whether through social media, the metaverse, crypto, or whatever pathways Nike was considering—not much really happened.

It was all noise and no signal.

No clarity.

No focus.

No leadership.

Perhaps the final nail in the coffin, beyond Nike's bad strategy of rapid diversification and poor execution, was its shift in messaging and storytelling.

For decades, Nike was one of the best storytellers in the world, inspiring people of all generations and backgrounds with their advertisements. Everyone wanted to be a part of Nike. Everyone loved the ads and the athletes and wanted to "Just Do It!" no matter how big or seemingly impossible.

Yet, in 2017, Nike shifted toward more political and divisive messaging. In 2017, they put out bold and public statements to open the U.S. borders. In 2018, they aggressively pushed their "Dream Crazy" campaign featuring the NFL quarterback Colin Kaepernick, whose recent stance of kneeling during the National Anthem cost him his NFL career.

While the NFL didn't back Kaepernick, knowing their audience—both Democrat and Republican—loved the flag and the country, Nike went all-in. The campaign's tagline was "Believe in something. Even if it means sacrificing everything." Though it may have been an inspiring message, it was now political, not athletic. It had nothing to do with Nike's products.

There have been many, many more controversial Nike campaigns on various political topics since 2017. None of these campaigns or topics is inherently wrong. They only leave the consumer scratching their head and asking:

What is Nike optimizing for?

Who is Nike's target market?

Are they an inspiring and innovative performance company for athletes, or a technology and political organization?

Nike's new CEO, Hill, has publicly stated that "to get Nike back on track," they will reduce focus on extraneous ventures such as digital. They

aim to refocus Nike on being an athlete-centric brand with a renewed commitment to developing cutting-edge products in core categories such as running, basketball, and training, seeking to regain market share lost to competitors.⁹

Hill further stated that they seek to rebuild relationships with wholesale partners and increase their marketing efforts on athlete-focused storytelling to strengthen consumer connections and brand loyalty.

The jury is still out whether Nike can turn this around. We will see whether they can actually execute on a more focused and disciplined strategy. The research on impossible goals is clear in regard to situations like Nike—Hail Marys typically don't work as a survival plan.¹⁰ When you're a sinking ship, going for radical innovations in an undisciplined manner will only speed your self-destruction.

This isn't to say Nike shouldn't deploy impossible goals. Indeed, such goals are profound and accelerating when focused on the signal.

It's just unclear, given their current momentum, whether they're willing to truly set a clear and specific frame and, from there, raise their floor and eliminate the noise that's gotten them into this tumultuous situation. Will they choose a focused path?

Impossible goals aren't for the undisciplined.

Yes, they are strategic—and lead to incredible innovation. But that innovation is *focused* and based on quality decisions.

Strategy, by definition, means focus and choice. It means drawing hard lines in the sand, first and foremost about *what you won't do*. Of this, the management guru Peter Drucker wrote in *The Effective Executive* (emphasis mine):

The job is, however, not to set priorities. That is easy. Everybody can do it. The reason why so few executives concentrate is the difficulty of setting “posteriorities”—that is, deciding what tasks not to tackle—and of sticking to the decision.¹¹

According to Dr. Richard Rumelt, *good strategy is surprising*. It's surprising because very few people truly deploy it. As he wrote: “The first natural advantage of good strategy arises because other organizations often don't have one. And because they don't expect you to have one either.”¹²

In this chapter, we will discuss the importance of choosing and following through on a *focused path*, based on your impossible goal.

CHOOSING A FOCUSED PATH

*Two roads diverged in a wood, and I—I took the one less traveled
by, And that has made all the difference.*

— ROBERT FROST¹³

Less than six weeks after his first company failed, Blake Murray, a man in his late 20s, developed a business concept that would soon be a fast-scaling company he'd sell for \$2.5 billion.

It was April of 2016 in Utah, and Murray had recently attempted his own business, which in his own words, “failed miserably.”

Though disappointed, Murray was more perplexed than anything. He simply wanted to understand how in the world he had failed so badly. Immediately after shutting his business down, he dug deep into auditing the problems of what went wrong.

What he found surprised him.

In analyzing the situation, he realized he'd never been clear or up to speed on the financials of his business while in the day-to-day running of it.

This was back in 2016, when financial reports used by business owners were typically on a 30- to 60-day lag behind real-time income and expenses. Though nonoptimal, this was just what the system was back then. By not being fully aware of his financials, Blake felt he'd made missteps that ultimately led his business to fail.

In seeking to understand everything about the financial process, Murray researched application programming interfaces (APIs) for credit cards and how they work. He looked into all existing financial tracking, reporting, and protection software.

His main questions were: *Is there something that technically existed to provide real-time and accurate financial information? And is something like this even technically feasible?*

“By feasible, what I mean is theoretically and technically possible—where the bank and the software are one and the same,” he explained in a

2024 podcast interview.¹⁴

Murray came to the startling realization that there was no simple and immediate way he could get a snapshot of the financial health of his business. The existing processes were complex, convoluted, and extremely lagging, leaving the business largely in the dark about what was going on.

The deeper he drilled into the problem, the more he saw its ubiquity.

“This wasn’t just a me thing,” he explained. “This isn’t just my problem. Everyone who has built a small business and had to manage a payroll has dealt with this. And it’s the fear that keeps you up at night: How am I going to manage payroll? Do we have enough money to operate?”

Just two weeks into this learning process, and before validating the concept with trusted friends and family, Murray began investing his own money in this new project. He felt a conviction and profound pull that this was an enormous opportunity. He couldn’t stop thinking about it. “It was not only a no-brainer. It was pulling me toward it.”

He brought on a co-founder, Alex Bean—a long-term friend who’d quit his job building software in order to join Murray—during the initial weeks of Murray’s research.

The first big aha for Murray was that there indeed was no existing real-time bridge between financial software and the banks managing the money. The existing financial software, such as Concur and Expensify, didn’t attempt to provide real-time financial data, but instead, powerfully supported the then normal process of a 30- to 60-day lag time for getting your financial data.

Though they didn’t yet have a viable business model or even a draft of the software, Murray and Bean knew they’d clarified an industry-level problem, one that effected literally every business in the United States at least, but also the world. In just the few weeks since he began exploring, Murray had obsessively gone so deep into researching the situation that his conviction was sky-high. With Bean’s software capabilities and insight, they were ready to start swinging for the fences.

One day, to test their hypothesis, Murray walked into a random U.S. Bank in Salt Lake City, Utah. He requested to talk to a bank manager and convincingly pitched her the idea of “Divvy”—the would-be name of the company. Reporting on this conversation, Murray stated:

She was blown away. She was equally as lacking in knowledge and acumen as I was, in terms of the software. But she was blown away to the extent that as a bank manager, she began making calls on my behalf. She felt this was something so unique and special that she had to go send it up the chain. It got up to the C-suite of U.S. Bank, which at the time was the fourth or fifth largest bank in the United States.

The next month, in May of 2016, Murray and Bean were in a meeting with 15 or so of the C-suite leaders of U.S. Bank. They had nothing built but a slide deck to explain their concept, in addition to their intense convictions and Murray's persuasive storytelling.

Murray described this crucial meeting on the podcast:

We walked in with the same confidence, perhaps a little too much bravado, and gave them the pitch that this was the future of where they needed to be headed. And frankly, if they didn't partner with us, that we were going to take their wallet share.

The interviewer laughed and responded, "You walk into the fifth largest bank and say, 'You can come with us, or you can get run over by us.'"

Murray continued in response, with excitement and passion:

One of the primaries, if not *the* primary job of a CEO is being, not becoming, but *being* an elite storyteller. So, before you can even give yourself permission to make that kind of claim, where you're not going to get laughed out of the room—where you actually have credibility—you have to be able to tell the story where every one of them is now leaning forward, looking you in the eye and nodding vigorously in agreement with everything you're saying. So, the presentation was predicated on convincing them that not only were we right, but that they had to work with us. Because if they didn't, someone else would.

"What was the outcome of that meeting?" the interviewer asked.

"We walked away with a master agreement from them that had a guaranteed seven-figure minimum in it. From there, that's where I began leveraging that commercial agreement into a friends and family

[investment] round. I was able to look people in the eye and say to them, ‘Look what we’ve been able to accomplish in only six weeks.’”

The “six weeks” was since Murray’s prior company had bombed, and in that time, he’d discovered and verified a massive opportunity, brought on Bean as his co-founder, and convinced one of the largest banks in the world to partner with them as an investor.

Now that Murray and Bean understood the problem they were solving and were committed to creating an innovative software that provided real-time financial data, they sought to clarify a viable business model.

Given the enormity of what they were taking on, they were going to be competing with the major banks and credit cards of the world, such as Wells Fargo, Visa, and American Express. They felt having an innovative software wasn’t enough to compete and scale. They’d also need an innovative and “no-brainer” *offer*, one that couldn’t be ignored by their target market.

While digging through contracts from a number of credit card companies, they learned something that shocked them: the credit card companies would *pay them* for every client they had both open and use their credit cards. And not just pay them, but pay them a solid percentage (1 to 3 percent of every transaction on the cards). The more their clients used the credit cards, the higher the percentage they received.

As they began doing the math, they came to a bold insight and decision—that they’d offer their robust software to the client *for free*, and that their financial model would be via the credit card companies, not their clients.

In an interview for this book, Alex Bean told me, “We actually needed to scale quickly because if we hadn’t, we wouldn’t have gotten the higher percentage of credit card expenses.”

Though increasingly popular now, in 2016 this model had never been done and went completely against what all other SaaS (software as a service) companies were doing.

Of course, when Murray and Bean explained this unique business model with their investors, they got concerned responses. “You can’t give the software away for free,” they were told.

But they were completely convicted. They knew that to cut through the noise and scale fast enough for the credit card percentage to reach maximum profitability, their offer had to be an absolute no-brainer for the small to midsize businesses that were in their target market. They would

provide game-changing new software that would massively improve their client's financial process and record-keeping *for free* but require them to use Divvy credit cards, which were linked to the software.

As Murray and Bean came to further understand the percentages of the credit card companies, it was clear they'd be making nearly 5x what the other SaaS companies were making, *without charging the client at all*. Being paid by the credit card companies was a more predictable and powerful revenue model than the SaaS itself.

Their primary hurdle was getting people to open a new credit card, which would be connected to the Divvy software. However, this proved to not be a hurdle at all for one primary reason: the offer was so clearly better than anything in existence that whoever sold it, whether Murray or Bean in the beginning, or their sales team, had complete conviction when explaining the power of the technology and the fact that it was free.

Of the marketing process, Murray explained:

If we want to compete. . . . If we want to steal customers from Chase Bank, Wells Fargo, American Express, I want to be able to go to that customer and offer them that same \$1 million line of credit that Chase Bank is offering, and then a powerful suite of software that is just loaded, that they can't ignore. That they'll get in trouble from their boss if they don't adopt this suite of software.

Once the concept and business model were fully in place, and they'd raised funding to hire and build the product, they spent the next two years—from mid-2016 to mid-2018—perfecting the software. They didn't rush to market with a minimum viable product and perfect it over time. They felt so strongly about the need of their software, as well as the power of their business model offering it for free, that the product had to be phenomenal *from launch*.

When Divvy formally launched in mid-2018, it was extreme scale from day one and no looking back until they sold three years later, in June of 2021.

In the second half of 2018, they did \$7 million in revenue.

In 2019, they did \$35 million in revenue.

In 2020, they did \$75 million in revenue.

In 2021, they did over \$150 million in revenue and were acquired by [Bill.com](#) for \$2.5 billion.¹⁵

This was one of the fastest and most aggressive scales of its kind.

Importantly, Divvy *didn't* scale anything but their core product.

In fact, when interviewing Alex Bean for this book, he told me that when Divvy sold, the software was almost the same as the conceptual model they'd presented to the U.S. Bank C-suite team with only a PowerPoint.

From the beginning, Murray and Bean wanted to rapidly scale and sell this company, and they had convictions that it would be huge. This desire led them to really thinking through a scalable business model, which was revolutionary to what everyone else was doing.

Once they had the business model in place, and after perfecting and launching the product, as a team they only had one focus: scale their singular product as fast as humanly possible.

They measured their growth via monthly revenue.

That was their only measurement.

When interviewing Bean for this book, I asked if they had any products or offerings other than their core product—the free software service with Divvy credit cards.

“No,” he told me. “We had one product, and were extremely focused on scaling only that one thing.”

“Did you ever get distracted trying other products or offerings?” I asked.

“Of course, it's nearly impossible to not be distracted. But nothing provided even a fraction of the revenue of our product, and so very quickly we'd weed everything else out and continue pushing our product as far as it could possibly go.”

SIMPLIFY TO SCALE

*I would not give a fig for the simplicity this side of complexity, but
I would give my life for the simplicity the other side of complexity.*

— OLIVER WENDELL HOLMES¹⁶

To scale a system, you must simplify it. *You must be focused.*

It doesn't matter how brilliant you are or how brilliant your solution is to an important problem. If your delivery is complex or confusing, you won't scale.

Take, for example, CellCore, a health supplement company. Started in 2017 by two highly specialized doctors, Dr. Todd Watts and Dr. Jay Davidson, CellCore provided probiotics to improve people's gut health. The supplements provided by CellCore were essential and cutting-edge.

But there was a problem: CellCore offered too many supplements for clients to know which ones were most important.

From the perspective of Watts and Davidson, *all of the supplements* they offered were essential to getting a person's gut, and therefore their health, to an optimal level.

By the end of 2017, their first full year, CellCore was doing around \$500,000 in revenue. Despite it being pretty strong growth for the first year of the company, Watts and Davidson knew they weren't suited to run or scale this company on their own. They were teachers and practitioners at heart.

They needed a CEO.

Someone who could organize, focus, and magnify what they were doing.

In January of 2018, Watts met a man from his church, Ryan Riley. On a personal visit at Watts's home, Riley stopped by and introduced himself. He simply asked, "How can I serve you?"

Watts told him, "I need to find a CEO for my company."

Riley began asking questions.

He found that CellCore had no brand. They had very minimal marketing. The sole form of marketing happening was Dr. Watts and Dr. Davidson going on online summits in the health space to talk about their products and promote them.

At the time, Riley was the CTO of a technology company, which he'd helped scale. For the previous few years, he was looking for his next big opportunity. During that single conversation with Watts, it became clear to Riley that this was something he could scale.

"You're going to get a lot more out of me than you expect," he told Watts, once they agreed he would be the CEO of CellCore.

During that first year, Riley worked literally for free, as he was on a handsome salary with his previous company, though he was required to do about five or so hours of work per month over there.

As Riley dug into the company, it became immediately obvious to him that everything needed to be simplified, especially the product offerings. Riley ultimately decided that they needed to take all of their many supplements and turn them into a *single concept*, which they called “The Protocol.”

With The Protocol, people would get all of the gut health supplements they needed in a single system, with clear and simple instructions. It was a six-month process to transform the health of its user, all in a single program.

By shifting the seven-plus supplements into a single product and system, CellCore now had a scalable product and concept. By making a scalable product system, amplifying Dr. Watts and Dr. Davidson’s profile, and increasing the marketing, Riley took CellCore’s revenue to \$5.9 million in 2018, over 10x from the \$500,000 in 2017.

In 2019, CellCore’s revenue was \$13.7 million.

In 2020, CellCore’s revenue was \$26 million.

In 2021, CellCore’s revenue was \$46 million.

In 2022, CellCore sold for \$200 million.¹⁷

During the final stages of the sale, Riley recognized that positioning Dr. Watts as both the face and CEO of CellCore would create a stronger narrative and enhance the company’s overall value. To support this vision, he chose to step down as CEO at the very end, further elevating Watts and solidifying the brand’s future.

This move alone made the company go from \$150 million in value to \$200 million.

CellCore was a strong concept before Riley became CEO. But it wasn’t focused. It wasn’t a simple enough system *to scale*. Riley came in and took something complex and made it simple, and therefore scalable. With that scalable model, Riley put rocket fuel behind it with his energy, marketing, and commitment.

This chapter brings a few crucial concepts together.

The first is that if you’re not focused, you’re going to stagnate and falter, as Nike recently demonstrated.

The second is that if you don’t choose a *focused path*, and keep the main thing the main thing, as Divvy did, then you won’t scale.

Yet, you won’t identify this “focused” path without doing the work. That work is clearly identifying an important problem, then building a powerful

and scalable solution. For Divvy, that was giving away their cutting-edge software for free while being paid by the credit card companies. No one else was doing that at the time.

Third and finally, if your business model isn't simple and focused, as CellCore's became once Riley created The Protocol, then you won't scale. You can't scale a complex system. To scale, you've got to do the hard work of taking something extremely complex and making it simple yet powerful.

JOURNAL PROMPTS & APPLICATIONS

- How focused is your path toward your impossible goal?
- Is your path based on “best practices” of what everyone else is doing, or is it based on your unique perspective and solution?
- How scalable is your business model?
- Go to scaling.com/book1 and complete the form to evaluate your current readiness to scale.

CHAPTER 6

Build Something That Can Scale Beyond Yourself

Level 5 leaders set up their successors for even greater success in the next generation, whereas egocentric Level 4 leaders often set up their successors for failure.

— JIM COLLINS, IN *GOOD TO GREAT*¹

The United States wouldn't have scaled to the superpower it has in the past 250 years without George Washington.

Not because of what Washington did, but far more importantly, because of what he *didn't do*.

After serving his two terms as the first president of the United States from April 30, 1789, to March 4, 1797, Washington *proactively stepped down* as president. Though this was the design of the republic from the beginning, even still it was tempting for people to make Washington into a king.

Washington knew that in order for America to scale, let alone survive, it couldn't be dependent on him. It couldn't be *built around* one person. That would cripple the system. It would stop the process of freedom and self-determination they were striving to create.

In the Broadway musical *Hamilton*, Lin Manuel Miranda beautifully portrays Washington's stepping down in the song "One Last Time."

"One Last Time" depicts Washington inviting Hamilton in as his scribe to write to the American people that he's stepping down as president and what

he hopes they do with the country they are building. In the scene, Hamilton is shocked and even disappointed by Washington's decision.

After going back and forth with Hamilton—with Hamilton essentially begging Washington to continue as president—Washington explains why he can't with one statement:

If I say good bye, the nation learns to move on; It outlives me when I'm gone.²

A year after finishing his second term, in 2018, President Barack Obama recorded a special version of this song, "One Last Time," wherein he read the portion of the song that directly comes from Washington's written address.³

For the remainder of this chapter, you're going to learn a crucial lesson of scaling, one that stops many people from creating something truly special.

To scale both effectively and efficiently, *you can't be the centerpiece*.

You may be the visionary. But if your business operates more like a monarchy with you as the king or queen rather than as a republic, with many extremely smart people involved and invested, your chances of scaling are slim.

If you're more committed to impact, purpose, and growth than your own role in it, then you can create something that can scale far bigger and beyond yourself.

I've had to learn this lesson from firsthand experience, multiple times. I've seen how brilliant entrepreneurs and leaders fail to cross the chasm of good to great. Because they can't get beyond themselves, they fail to attract the level of talent and teamwork needed to aggressively scale.

If you don't have the right people on your team, you won't scale.

Yes, you can have a nice business.

You can make great money.

But your results will be puny and slow compared to what they could be if you had teamwork with world-class talent just as committed as you.

SUPER WHOS ARE REQUIRED TO SCALE

A great lathe operator commands several times the wage of an average lathe operator, but a great writer of software code is worth 10,000 times the price of an average software writer.

— BILL GATES⁴

Some interesting and controversial research in the 1960s revealed that top software engineers didn't produce double or triple the average ones. They were 10 to 100 times more productive than average engineers in terms of code quality and speed. Other research consistently shows that the top 1 to 5 percent of salespeople typically generate the majority of revenue—usually over 95 percent.⁵

In the book *The 80/20 Individual*, consulting and performance expert Richard Koch explains that results in the world are generated by ultimately two things: *ideas and individuals*.⁶

Koch further explains that *individuals*, not companies, are what produce results. Of this, Bill Gates similarly stated, “Take our 20 best people away, and I will tell you that Microsoft will become an unimportant company.”⁷ Gates's statement is profound when you consider that Microsoft has nearly 230,000 employees.

Koch goes on to explain that when considering the world as a whole, less than 1 percent of the people who have ever lived have made over 99 percent of the impact on the world's direction.

The CEO of Netflix, Reed Hastings, shared how Netflix was able to scale at the level and speed it did. In the early days when budgets were tight and they needed to quickly solve a particular problem, Hastings had a decision to make, which he describes:

With a fixed amount of money for salaries and a project I needed to complete, I had a choice. I could hire ten to twenty-five average engineers or I could hire one “rock star” and pay significantly more than what I'd pay the others, if necessary. Since then I have come to see that the best programmer doesn't add ten times the value. She adds more like 100 times. . . . In 2003, we didn't have that much money but we had a lot to accomplish. We had to think carefully about how we'd spend the little we had. . . . For all creative jobs we would pay one incredible employee at the top of her personal market, instead of using

that same money to hire a dozen or so more adequate performers. This would result in a lean workforce. We'd be relying on one tremendous person to do the work of many. But we'd pay tremendously. This is the way we have hired the majority of employees at Netflix ever since. The approach has been remarkably successful. We have exponentially increased our speed of innovation and output.⁸

Hastings argues that for creative roles and results-based roles like sales, your best bet is to hire *absolutely top of market*, no matter the cost. It's been noted that no matter how much you're paying a top-level performer, you'll get ballpark 16x whatever you invest in them, often lots more.

Working with super talent does at least two things for you and your organization: 1) it elevates the expectation and floor of everyone involved, and 2) it creates slack in the system or margin for error.

Take, for example, the Golden State Warriors basketball team. On February 6, 2025, their record was 25 wins and 26 losses, placing them 10th in the Western Conference standings. During the postgame interview that night, Steph Curry was asked about a pivotal trade that had just occurred. The Warriors had traded for Jimmy Butler, a notable star from the Miami Heat who could score, defend, and energize teammates.

"How do you feel Jimmy will change what's going on with the team?" Curry was asked.

"The biggest thing it does is create expectations, which I love," Curry said with a wry smile. "I love being in that kind of environment, whether you get it done or not. That is meaningful basketball where we all thrive in."⁹

Bringing a superstar on to your team elevates the *expectation*. You can't just keep getting by. The floor goes up. If you're not looking for elevated accountability and expectation, you probably won't want to partner or work with super talent, though that's what you'll need to scale and win at the highest level.

Over the next five to six weeks, Jimmy made a massive impact on the team. During their next 14 games, they went 12-2, going from the 10th spot to the 6th in the Western Conference.

Marcus Thompson, a beat writer covering the Warriors for *The Athletic*, discussed even his own surprise a month after the Butler trade. Referencing

Andrew Wiggins, the excellent player the Warriors traded for Butler, Thompson stated:

There is a difference between an all-star and a superstar. These things are categorically different. With all the drama going on in Miami the past few years, I'd forgotten that Jimmy Butler was a superstar. . . . It's instant! He's one of those guys. And he doesn't even have to play well and you can feel it. He's just on the court, and by virtue of being Jimmy Butler on the court, he will punish you if you let him. And if you don't, then Steph will punish you. The moment he got there, you could feel the vibe change. Just by him being there! . . . He's impacting one of the greatest offensive weapons in the history of sports. You can see it, Steph is a different dude. Steph is a monster. The day they got Jimmy, Steph took 36 shots. The next day he took 32. That's the first time in his career he's taken 30 shots in back-to-back nights.^{[10](#)}

Thompson is making a few key points here. First, bringing on super talent changes the entire feel and expectation of the environment. But also, because of the extreme capability they bring, they elevate those around them. And when you're pairing superstar with superstar, such as Butler with Curry, now all of a sudden the whole game looks different.

It's been noted by Steve Kerr, the Warriors' head coach, that because of Steph's incredible abilities, he creates enormous margin for error for the rest of the team. The business term for this is *slack*. When you have slack, whether financial, talent, leverage, etc., it means you have *space*. You have degrees of freedom others don't have.

According to Dr. Sim Sitkin, having slack—particularly in financial resources—is highly advisable when committing to an impossible goal.^{[11](#)} Slack gives you the time and space to learn, innovate, and iterate your path and process as you're stretching toward the goal. Importantly, there are multiple forms of slack. And when you're creating pathways to your goal, bringing on various partners who have key leverage you don't have, whether capability, resources, connections, etc., can be the resource you need to scale. The most powerful way to create slack is by working with Super Whos, those who can create results no one else can.

Of course, there is one key challenge to bringing on Super Whos to your team, and I've seen it many times in companies I've advised. *You can't have*

rock stars working with average employees. The cultures and mindsets don't mesh.

If you want world-class Super Whos, you first have to be world class yourself. Tens don't work for eights.

You have to make a decision: you're either operating with a world-class and high-performing workforce, or you're working with average employees.

There's a clear distinction in world-class team members and partners vs. average employees. The world-class team members don't want to be managed, but they absolutely want to be led—and to lead.

World-class talent is committed and accountable to results more than process. Conversely, average employees want the security of process to fall back on because they aren't committed to results. They're committed to their own security and comfort.

This reality is a truth that organizations of all sizes have to face if they want to scale. To reach a massive new level and get there quickly, you're going to need very clear objectives and better team members than you currently have.

A lot better.

Are you willing to let go of some, or even many, of your existing team members in order to scale?

The answer for many people, based on their actions, is no. They don't have the stomach to disappoint or hurt people, so instead they have a linear business.

You can't go halfway on this. Either you're committed and will get rock stars who help you scale, or you maintain an average workforce. If you try to mix the two, it won't work.

For example, with Floor Coverings International (FCI), the flooring franchise company I've consulted with and discussed in [Chapter 4](#) of this book, we taught the franchisees that if they wanted their business to grow more aggressively, they'd need to let go of their current salespeople and hire better ones, even replacing their entire sales team with a single Super Who.

When a leader is only half-committed to an A-level player, meaning they keep the culture and expectations lower, that A-player won't stick around. This reality smacked the face of one new franchisee. He hired an A-player but didn't set them up for success. This new franchisee continued as an

operator and manager, rather than leader, and within a few short months, his A-level salesperson left, wanting a better opportunity for growth.

The Scaling Framework is three parts: *Frame, Floor, Focus*.

The frame is the objective—a seemingly impossible goal and timeline. Because the goal is so high and urgent, it forces a far more aggressive filtering process, hence the floor rises.

The floor is the new and higher cutoff on viable options, which for the impossible goal are much less than a smaller or linear goal. Thus, the natural process of attempting an impossible goal is that it forces your floor extremely high, requiring you to let go of what you were previously doing and who you were doing it with.

This doesn't mean you fire your whole staff. But if you want to see something interesting, take some time to establish a seemingly impossible goal and watch how your team reacts when you present it to them. It will be very telling who is committed and serious, and who wants status quo.

Ultimately, your ability to scale largely comes down to the people you have on your team, as well as people who partner with you.

To achieve impossible goals and rapidly scale, you'll need team members and partners who have leverage, *meaning they can produce results*.

IMPOSSIBLE GOALS → LEVERAGED PARTNERS

Give me a place to stand, and a lever long enough, and I will move the world.

— ARCHIMEDES, POLYMATH AND INVENTOR FROM ANCHIENT GREECE^{[12](#)}

This book started with the story of a politician who utilized space to achieve his political goal. It ends with an engineer who's utilizing politics to achieve his space goal.

The entrepreneur and innovator Elon Musk has been very explicit about his goal of getting humanity to Mars for a long time.^{[13](#)} That's the goal shaping his decisions and direction. That's the goal that led him to buy the

social media platform Twitter, getting involved in the 2024 U.S. election, and embedding himself in U.S. politics and government reform.

I'm not here to say whether "going to Mars" or how he's going about realizing that is a worthy or moral endeavor. Musk's story is explored for strategic and scaling purposes, not political or moral ones. No one can deny his genius at scaling.

The economist Lord Maynard Keynes stated, "Worldly wisdom teaches that it is better for reputation to fail conventionally than to succeed unconventionally."¹⁴

To realize his impossible goal of getting to Mars, Musk became willing to risk his own reputation and wealth by getting involved in the 2024 U.S. elections. Though risking his wealth and reputation aren't exactly new for Musk, becoming political led many who previously revered or respected him to strongly question and even vilify him.

Some now think he's a monster.

Following the COVID-19 pandemic, there became growing concern and debate over the topic of "censorship," particularly in U.S. politics, culture, and social media. Increasing evidence suggested the government was manipulating platforms like Facebook, Twitter, and Google to suppress information and steer public opinion.^{15,16} As Mark Zuckerberg later recounted in an interview, "It just got to this point where we were like, 'No, we're not gonna, we're not gonna take down things that are true. That's ridiculous.'"^{17,18}

Both politics and society were hard skewing toward increased regulation and conformity—wherein any form of disagreement was at risk of censorship and cancellation.

This was something Musk, as one of Twitter's biggest users, was becoming aware of and concerned about. Due to both his frequent use of the platform and the size of his audience and engagement, he noticed every algorithmic and technical change made on Twitter, even subtle ones.

As he saw various figures whose viewpoints opposed Twitter's agenda literally get censored and removed from the platform, Musk began to believe the First Amendment—freedom of speech—was possibly in jeopardy. He felt if we lost freedom of speech, all other freedoms would eventually fall with it.

The seeming regulation of speech was just one of the signals to Musk that something needed to happen. Government regulation also concerned

him, as increasing laws were limiting his ability to innovate and scale his companies SpaceX and Tesla. The final kicker was the ballooning U.S. debt, which Musk believed could lead the country to utter ruin and bankruptcy.

These converging factors led Musk to a startling realization, one that terrified even him: *He would never get to Mars if he didn't get involved in U.S. politics.*

This was not his initial intention, but he couldn't see any other way.

His commitment to reaching Mars led him to begin privately acquiring shares in Twitter in 2021. By mid-2022, the Twitter board accepted Musk's offer to buy the company for \$44 billion.

During the due-diligence period following the accepted offer, Musk was visiting his kids in California. They asked why he was buying Twitter. They didn't use it and felt him buying the platform was a bad idea. "I think it's important to have a digital public square that's inclusive and trusted," he explained to his kids. Then, after a brief pause, he goofed, "How else are we going to get Trump elected in 2024?"^{[19](#)}

Although this last comment was made jokingly in the moment, in retrospect it clearly wasn't a joke, despite him being a lifelong Democrat.

Buying Twitter was a chess move in Musk's grand strategy of getting to Mars.

Once the deal was finalized and Musk became owner, he immediately began applying his five-step algorithm to simplify and remodel Twitter, eliminating most of its then existing processes and people.^{[20](#)} Naturally, he was met with extreme resistance.

Within a month of owning Twitter, he fired 80 percent of the staff and removed much of Twitter's processes, which he stated was "painful" and "not fun at all," though necessary.^{[21](#)}

During one interview around this time, he was asked, "So how do you run the company with only twenty percent of the staff?"

Musk replied, "Well, it turns out, you don't need that many people to run Twitter."

The interviewer pushed back, "But eighty percent? *That's a lot.*"

"Yes. If you're not trying to run some sort of glorified activist organization, and if you don't care that much about censorship, then you can really let go of a lot of people it turns out."^{[22](#)}

While applying his algorithm to Twitter, he had a conversation with some of the top engineers and asked them about the apparent excess of server farms.

“Why do we have three server farms?” Musk asked. “We only need one.”

“We need all three,” the engineers insisted.

“Why?”

“We need the others for backups and cashing,” they explained.

“No, we don’t need three,” Musk said. “I want us to get rid of the two in Sacramento.”

“That will take at least six months.”

“No, you can do it in six weeks,” Musk pushed.

With a scaling mindset and utilizing time as a tool, Musk said, “You can complete this in six weeks, not six months.”

After seeing that they were more committed to Twitter’s past than its future, Musk fired them two days before Christmas.

The next day, Musk was flying on his private jet from San Francisco to Austin to be with his family for Christmas. Mid-flight, he told his pilot to turn the plane around. He decided to go up to the server facility in Sacramento himself.

The guard at the facility was shocked, not knowing why Elon Musk—the new owner of the company—was there on Christmas Eve. Musk and his bodyguard made their way to the servers. Once there, he turned to his bodyguard and asked, “Do you have a pocket knife?”

“Yeah,” the bodyguard said, handing it over.

Musk then cut the cables to the servers himself and immediately shut them down.^{[23](#)}

The changes he made to Twitter, including its name to X, were unpopular—both inside the company and in the broader culture. The company lost most of its advertisers and revenue. After nearly two years owning the company, the whole thing looked like a colossal failure. By the end of Q3 2024, X’s value had dropped from the \$44 billion he paid for it to just over \$9 billion.^{[24](#)}

Due to the seeming failures at Twitter, or X, people began to wonder whether Musk had lost his edge. Maybe he’d even lost his mind.

His leadership and mental state were questioned.

Investors, friends, and even those closest to him were becoming increasingly concerned, especially as he voiced his radical political

opinions online.

Some pundits and influencers said Musk's extreme wealth had inflated his ego to unchecked levels, leading him to make irrational and dangerous decisions.^{[25](#)}

However, as the 2024 U.S. elections loomed near, it became obvious that Musk was up to something. Despite previously opposing Donald Trump, Musk calculated that if he was ever going to colonize Mars to elevate humanity, helping Trump become president was a crucial though unexpected path.

Understanding the massive risk, particularly to his electric vehicle company Tesla, he publicly stated that he was endorsing Trump and that he felt freedom of speech, and all other freedoms, hung in the balance.

Trump was Musk's big bet to get to Mars, and it had massive potential upsides and downsides for Musk.

He further explained on the Joe Rogan podcast that if Kamala Harris won the election over Donald Trump, that he [Musk] wouldn't be able to get to Mars, and that he might even lose his companies due to government oversight.^{[26](#)} He's gone as far as saying that if Trump hadn't won, that "civilization would be lost."^{[27](#)}

As he stated on Rogan: "I think this is existential to the United States. It's existential to democracy. . . . Once you lose freedom of speech, you lose democracy. Game over. That's why I bought Twitter."

I'm not saying whether or not you should believe Musk. But clearly, *he believes himself* and has a huge vision for the future of Earth. As Sam Altman, the CEO of ChatGPT, once described a SpaceX tour Musk had given him: "The thing that sticks in [my] memory was the look of absolute certainty on his face when he talked about sending large rockets to Mars. I left thinking, 'Huh, so that's the benchmark for what conviction looks like.'"^{[28](#)}

Musk ended up campaigning heavily to support Trump's election, and Trump announced that if he won, he would place Musk as the head of a project to audit government efficiency to reduce waste and increase productivity (Department of Government Efficiency, "DOGE").^{[29](#)}

Trump did win the 2024 election.

Many believe that had Musk not purchased Twitter two years prior, and had Musk not publicly and convincingly campaigned for Trump, that there's no way Trump could have won.

Within a month of Trump's victory, Tesla's stock value had shot up over 69 percent, growing Musk's personal wealth by over \$170 billion, nearly doubling his net worth.³⁰ As one comedic meme stated, "Elon is such a [fool]. He spent \$44 billion on Twitter, and all he got was control of all three branches of the federal government."

During Trump's inauguration speech on January 20, 2025, officially becoming the 47th president of the United States, he stated, "We will pursue our Manifest Destiny into the stars, planting the stars and stripes on Mars." During the worldwide television production of this speech, the camera flashed on Elon Musk after Trump spoke these words, and Elon was as elated as a schoolboy.

True to form, and questioning false requirements, Musk strongly suggests the United States de-prioritize its goal of going to the moon and instead direct its attention straight at Mars.³¹

Given the scale of Musk's impossible goal of reaching Mars, the pathway to get there becomes extremely unique, even controversial.

Musk now has Trump and likely the U.S. government behind his Mars goal. He will likely get huge amounts of funding in this process. I tell this story purely for strategic and scaling purposes. The point is encapsulated in a quote from the leadership expert Robin Sharma: "The bigger the dream, the more important to the team."

If you want to achieve impossible goals, you're not only going to need to get an audience with some truly incredible people, but you're also going to need to *partner* with them.

Partnering with *Super Whos*, or leveraged individuals, typically involves meshing visions wherein all parties are bought in, unified, and incentivized.

If you look at rapid scaling businesses or movements, you will see key partnerships and teamwork. Often, it is just one person or partner who can 10x or more your vision.

You're just one Super Who away from scaling.

Consider the company Slack, started in 2013. After a strong initial launch, doing \$12 million in revenue in 2014, it was Slack's partnership with Salesforce in 2015 that over 16x'd Slack's revenue in just over two years, wherein it did over \$200 million revenue in 2017.

Or the famous story of Nike partnering with Michael Jordan to take it from fringe running shoe company to global powerhouse. In 1984, when Nike made the bold bet on Michael Jordan, they expected \$3 million in

revenue on the Jordan 1 during its first full year in 1985. Instead, the sneaker produced over \$126 million that year, and over the next few years vaulted Nike beyond the running brand they'd previously been. With the Jordan and what came after, they were reframed as the premier sporting brand in the world.

Now, at the end of *The Science of Scaling*, you've got some questions to ask yourself:

- What is your own impossible goal?
- How will you utilize time as a tool?
- What does your impossible goal and timeline do to your floor?
- What will you let go of that's keeping you where you're now at?
- What is your own unique pathway to your impossible goal?
- Who will need to get involved that can make your mission possible?
- Will you stagnate or will you scale?

Dr. Stephen Covey said, "All things are created twice. There's a mental or first creation, and a physical or second creation to all things."³²

Creating a new frame or impossible goal, using Covey's language, is the *mental creation*. The new future is what shapes the present. The physical creation occurs by, first, raising your floor and simplifying your system—removing everything that shouldn't be in your physical world. After removing what shouldn't exist, the next aspect of physical creation is creating a model and business that can actually realize the goal.

Considering an impossible goal doesn't need to be dramatic or scary. Time is a psychological and strategic tool, not a concrete reality. Your future is the tool you use to filter your present, enabling you to find the signal and strip out the noise.

When you truly let the future dictate and direct the present, and when you make that future seemingly impossible, the floor will go very high. It will take honesty and courage to raise your floor and remove what shouldn't be there. Then, in order to truly create the system that can scale to your impossible goal, you'll need to make big bets that others wouldn't make.

Scaling is not for the faint of heart.

But it is for you.

You can achieve what seems like 10, 20, even 30 years of growth in the next three. Just simply use time as a tool as part of your impossible goal. Use that goal to force much better decision-making here and now.

While the world is increasingly becoming caught in a sea of louder and louder noise, you can be the exception. You can be focused. You can scale.

Will you?

CONCLUSION

The Origin Story of [Scaling.com](https://scaling.com), and How to Learn More

Acute focus, open sharing, exacting measurement, a license to shoot for the moon—these are the hallmarks of modern goal science.

— JOHN DOERR, VENTURE CAPITALIST AND BILLIONAIRE¹

I started writing this book near the end of 2023, shortly after the publication of my third and final book co-authored with Dan Sullivan, *10x Is Easier Than 2x*.

While writing *10x*, it became clear to me that though transformative, it was time to move on from my collaboration with Dan. I learned an enormous amount from Dan directly, from his Strategic Coach clients, and from the process of writing three powerful books.

I saw firsthand what books could do for a business. Ours sold over a million copies and drew thousands of clients to Dan's coaching company, exceeding the "impossible goal" Dan and I had set for our collaboration project.

After completing my collaboration with Dan, I wasn't exactly sure what would come next. As always, I was prayerful yet proactive. I wanted to do something bigger than ever before.

For a time, I was both working on this book and exploring other potential collaborations. I reached out to many big-name people—people you have heard of—who I knew I could scale a training and education company with.

These people knew of and respected my work greatly. Most of them wanted to work with me.

There was just one problem.

I had a very high floor in what I was willing to accept as a business deal. I knew what I brought to the table, and I knew it would be worth hundreds of millions or even billions to whoever I collaborated with. I also brought not only a publisher, a large audience, and my writing abilities and knowledge, but more importantly I brought my faith and full commitment to whatever I did.

That's why my books with Dan worked so much better than anyone (other than me) expected. I hadn't just brought my talent and resources; I brought my full faith and commitment.

I relied on God to help me grow and produce more than I ever had.

Ultimately, I was disappointed, as all of these "big name" people decided my floor was too high and weren't willing to invest what I required to partner with them, despite knowing it would be a 10x or 100x return.

This was incredibly instructive to me. As I've reflected on it since then, it's become clear why most people, including "successful" people, fail to create the impact and scale they say they want.

Primarily, it comes down to them remaining the bottleneck in what they're building. They are still attached to being the king or queen of their project. They aren't willing to build something that can scale far beyond them. As a result, they can't get the superstar partners required to achieve impossible goals and rapid scaling.

What was so incredible to me was that many of these very high-profile business thought leaders claim to teach scaling to entrepreneurs! Yet here they were, unwilling to take the actions that true rapid scaling requires.

They might have been willing to set impossible goals, but they were not raising their floor or focusing on the investments and partnerships required to achieve their scaling goals.

This was when I realized I was truly on to something new: I had discovered something that even the biggest names teaching business theory did not understand—or apply.

During this period, I had a guy I'd met a few years prior, Blake Erickson, reach out to me multiple times. He told me he felt strongly that he wanted to work with me and elevate what I was doing.

In August of 2024, Blake asked if he could fly to Florida and present his ideas at my house. It would only take an hour or two. I agreed to the meeting, though I didn't expect much.

What he presented, though, ended up blowing my mind and becoming the basis of what is now our company, Scaling.com.

He told me that if we were going to make a sizable impact, we'd need to be singularly focused.

"We need to punch the same hole in the wall over and over until we break through," he said. "I feel *scaling* is the subject we could absolutely own."

"Interesting," I replied. "That is exactly what I've been studying and developing the past few years."

The alignment was there. He had intuited some of the very same principles I had about what makes scaling possible and saw the fact that no one was teaching it properly. Despite many gurus talking about and teaching the subject, there remained no evidence-based and battle-tested method or model for scaling.

There was a massive hole in the market.

Blake and I could clearly see it.

After talking through the business and financial logistics, such as ownership, etc., and what would make the business compelling and high-potential, Blake was completely open. "I'm not here to negotiate with you," he told me.

He then suggested something that, to me, *seemed impossible*.

We agreed that if we created a training company that taught businesses how to scale effectively and aggressively, *he* would be the primary leader and trainer of the organization, though of course I would do some training as well. My role, however, would be primarily focused on developing the frameworks and tools for the members.

Blake's wisdom intrigued me as he laid this out, though I still wasn't sure about a partnership.

"The problem, Ben," Blake continued, "is that if people join our training company, they are going to want to learn solely from *you*, not me. You're Dr. Benjamin Hardy. I still don't have the same credibility you have."

"Eh, that's not such a problem," I shrugged off. "I can position you, even within the book."

Blake sat there, calmly. “I have something to propose to you, which I’ve been thinking about the past few weeks. I’m not sure what you’ll say,” he said.

I was just listening.

“To have the credibility I need to adequately lead this company and to train it, I feel I should be an author on the book,” Blake said, now slightly bashfully.

It took a minute for his comment to register.

“Wait, what?” I replied. “You want me to put you on the book, the one I’ve been writing this past year?”

“Yes,” Blake stated, simply. “It would be good strategy for what we’re trying to build—saving us at least a year for me to build credibility. It would enable me to far more effectively own my role as leader and trainer of the company. Plus, I feel I could help you finalize the framework.”

My initial reaction was that Blake didn’t deserve such an ask, being the co-author on my book. Even if he did help me refine and improve the thinking, that just felt like too much. In reality, I just didn’t know whether I was willing to operate at that level of abundance and teamwork.

Of course, I had my concerns. I wondered whether it would be a risk to my audience or publisher. I felt my publisher wouldn’t be stoked. I’d lost my previous publisher—one of the top business publishers in the world—in order to write the books with Dan Sullivan. It felt like I might lose my publisher again if I took this idea seriously.

That being said, I could see the brilliance in Blake’s thinking. I could see it was phenomenal strategy and advanced pathways thinking. I could also see that with Blake’s help, I could refine the thinking of the book and get the material where it needed to be. He has an extremely keen ability to discern signal from noise, and I could use that.

The more I thought about it, the more it shocked me how bold Blake was. It reminded me of when I first approached Dan Sullivan—yet even bolder.

Not only was Blake’s business concept to build a training company on scaling (a bull’s-eye signal for me), but he also had the ability to see the best paths to scale it incredibly. Blake’s boldness combined with his genius in co-authoring the book and building the training company amazed me.

There was just one final question I really had to ask myself: Was I willing to be the transformational leader I never had—where I abundantly give this

guy all I've built? Was I willing to set him up for greater success than I myself would have?

These were the thoughts flooding through my mind as I pondered the gravity of Blake's idea.

He sat patiently as I processed it all.

"Look," I said. "I love the idea. It's actually genius. But I don't feel right just giving it to you. I'm bringing not only my publisher and audience, but I'm also bringing the ideas and over a year's worth of work so far on this book. That's a lot of work and a lot of risk for me. I'd be committing to you and the company you want to build. Not only do I need your help improving the framework and concepts we will teach, but I feel you also need skin in the game to get your name on this book."

"I agree," Blake said, listening.

"For you to be an author of this book, that would require a million-dollar up-front investment from you. Honestly, I could ask for a lot more. But I feel that is an adequate threshold to demonstrate your commitment to this project."

"Let me talk to my wife," Blake replied without hesitation.

We chatted a little longer and from there, Blake got in his rental car and headed to the airport to fly home to Salt Lake City.

Ten minutes after leaving my house, I got a text from Blake: "I just spoke to my wife. We'd love to make the investment."

I sat there, staring at his text, and thinking to myself, *This guy is serious.*

It took a few more weeks to fully wrap my head around it. It seemed so opposite to what I was planning on doing after departing from my collaboration with Dan.

But the more I got to know Blake, the more I realized he could be one of those special people—a *Super Who*—who if properly funneled, could do something massive. He'd already proven himself as a specially gifted missionary, as mentioned in [Chapter 3](#) of this book, baptizing 10x the average on his mission. He'd proven his ability to scale, building a sales organization from \$0 to eight figures within four years and making himself millions of dollars in the process before age 25.

His willingness to invest a huge amount of his own net worth demonstrated a level of all-in commitment that rivaled mine. But also, the more I spoke with Blake, the more I needed his vision and high floor to stretch to my own next level. Blake and I ended up running a 90-day

challenge for hundreds of business owners to achieve impossible goals, and in that process, he dramatically elevated the clarity and impact of what we were teaching.

As expected, when I went to my publisher, they were initially concerned. But ultimately, my conviction could not be denied.

I was all in and willing to lose my publisher if required. Blake and I were not only going to do one book together, but we would do an entire Scaling Framework series—*several books*. As many as it took to teach everything needed to rapidly scale businesses.

We knew that to scale, we'd have to work with only the best, with Super Whos who could make the impossible possible.

We decided to add Daniel Amato, a highly successful entrepreneur who had started, scaled, and sold many technology companies, as our CEO. Daniel was also one of the greatest men Blake and I both knew, in terms of who he was as a person and man of God.

With Daniel's deep expertise in building valuable companies, he delved into IP, business planning, and the fundamental drivers of equity value to maximize long-term growth.

With his background in business, and specifically in software (SaaS), he helped us develop a profoundly simple and scalable business model for the training company. There would only be one product offering, not the several confusing layers that most training companies had.

After acquiring the domain, we decided to name the company Scaling.com.

I now faced a hard reality. The deadline of this book was fast approaching, and I knew it wasn't where I needed it to be, organizationally. I'd let go of my editor several months before, who, even though she was amazing, couldn't help me at the level I needed.

Tucker Max had edited all three of my books with Dan. He knows writing and business books probably better than anyone on the planet. But also, he's the clearest thinker and the most direct communicator I have ever met.

There's zero noise with Tucker, only signal. Granted, he delivers that signal sometimes so directly and brutally that if you're not open, you'll be offended—but the signal is incredibly strong and useful.

I reached out to Tucker and said I needed his best editing, and fast. I only had a few weeks until the deadline. After agreeing to a deal, Tucker jumped

in and saw the brilliance of what this could be (as well as the help I needed). He committed to edit the entire Scaling series, seeing the potential for helping businesses globally.

If you want to scale, you've got to work with the best.

If you work with the best, you can't have an ego. You can't be worried about being right. To quote the novelist Stephen King, you've got to "kill your darlings."

To scale, the floor has to be extremely high on everything you do.

At every step of the way, we ourselves apply The Scaling Framework we've developed to our own company. And we intend to continue doing that.

Our impossible goal is for [Scaling.com](https://scaling.com) to transform millions of businesses throughout the world, simplifying and normalizing the scaling process. We feel that, in early 2025 as we finish this book, right now is a critical time in human history. Helping millions of companies to scale is something we feel is incredibly important for both the United States and the world. Stuck and stagnant companies aren't going to help individuals and they won't help the world.

In addition to simplifying and democratizing scaling broadly, we intend to help tens of thousands of companies directly through our rigorous training process at [Scaling.com](https://scaling.com).

[Scaling.com](https://scaling.com) is a training process unlike any other in the world. First, we have the most powerfully scaling framework, which has been refined empirically through thousands of companies we've worked with. It's also the framework we ourselves use to scale our company.

Additionally, [Scaling.com](https://scaling.com) is the only performance-based training program in the world. Not only do we expect all of our members to scale, *we hold them accountable to do so*. Their success matters to us. If they are not scaling aggressively, but we also don't keep taking their money.

By doing this, we've built one of the most unique communities in the world. It is not just a few outliers scaling such as in other training programs. At [Scaling.com](https://scaling.com), *everyone is scaling*. It is for this reason that we have a rigorous application and interview process, to ensure that only those fully committed to aggressive scaling join. If you're not serious about 10x'ing your company in the very near future, we won't accept you into the program. We understand how essential it is to be around other people

scaling, as well as the damaging impact of having the wrong people in the room.

A primary form of education and training at **Scaling .com** is decoding case studies of how our members apply The Scaling Framework to achieve impossible goals regularly. Everyone in the community—including the actual founders—all learn from each other and share experiences. The community is deep, generous, and transformative.

If this sounds appealing to you, and you want to be part of this, we are taking applications for membership at [Scaling.com](https://scaling.com).

APPENDIX

Linear vs. Holistic Time

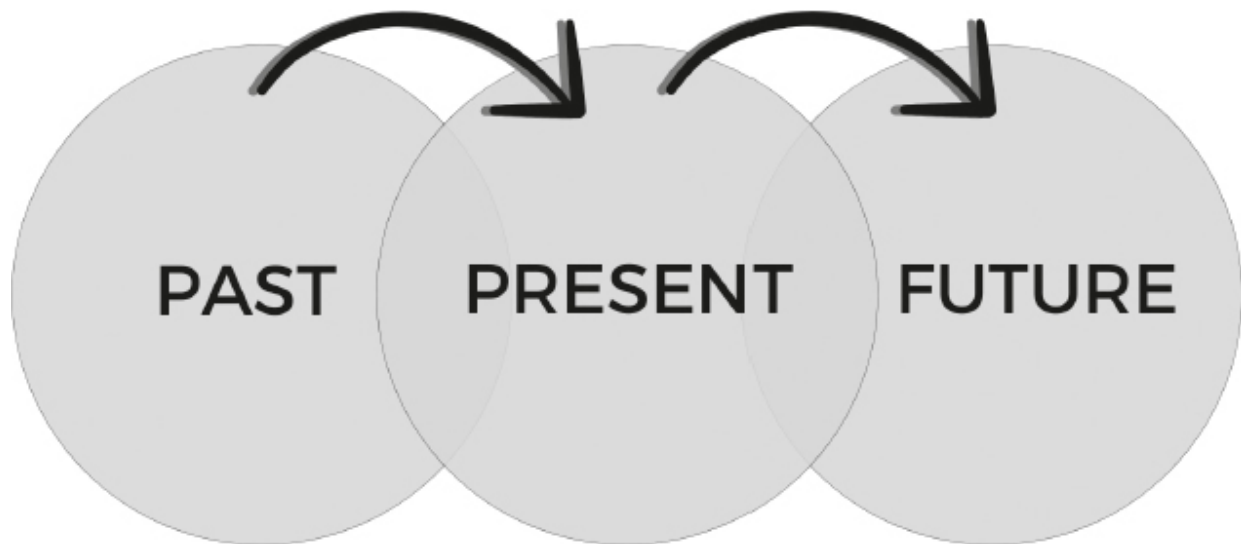
Much of the history of psychology has been dominated by a framework in which people and animals are driven by the past.

— DR. MARTIN SELIGMAN, FATHER OF AMERICAN POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY¹

In this brief Appendix, I will detail some of the foundational psychology beneath The Scaling Framework. Specifically, this section delves into the psychology of time and how it works. In [Chapter 2](#) of this book, you were taught the concept of applying “time as a tool.” There are deep psychological insights and applications here.

Let me start by highlighting the common and ineffective linear model of time, which is pervasive in psychology but also how people commonly think of and approach time.

THE COMMON LINEAR MODEL OF TIME



The image just above is a graphical representation of *linear time*. The core assumption of linear time is that the past determines the present and from there, the present determines the future.

Linear time is based on Newtonian physics.^{[2,3,4,5,6](#)} Another core assumption of linear time is that time *flows consistently and equitably*. Those were the very words of Newton's definition of time, which he published in his masterwork *Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy*, first published in 1687.^{[7](#)}

One of Newton's assumptions in regard to linear time was that, because time itself flows consistently, *the events within time* must also be consistent with each other. In other words, events in the present and future *must* be consistent with what happened in the past. The word *must* may sound strong here, but it's not.

The past is where all the power is, with this view and model of time. Dr. Brent Slife, a theoretical psychologist, explains that because linear time assumes consistency, change itself *must always* be incremental, never disruptive or discontinuous.^{[8](#)} All change moves from the past and present in a neat and orderly manner into the future. The past is the greatest predictor of the future.

Interestingly, modern research shows just how sweeping the adoption of these linear assumptions are in how people think about themselves. When people are asked to think about their own future selves—even over a decade away—the common assumption people have is that their future self will be *extremely similar* to their present self.^{[9](#)} As the Harvard psychologist Dr.

Daniel Gilbert stated, “Human beings are works in progress that mistakenly think they’re finished.”¹⁰

An obvious problem with linear time is that it has no clear direction. Instead of having a future guiding what you do, you’re letting the past and present *dictate the future*. The arrow is always forward with linear time, which makes the future as a concept both weak and unknowable. The future is a byproduct, not a cause.

Take, for example, public education. The linear model of public education is that a student naturally passes from first grade to second and on up through high school. At each successive year, the student is given what are assumed to be important benchmarks for the succeeding years, without respect for what each student’s future will be.

As the billionaire Peter Thiel writes, “By the time a student gets to college, he’s spent a decade curating a bewilderingly diverse resume to prepare for a completely unknowable future. Come what may, he’s ready—for nothing in particular.”¹¹

You can know if you’re operating in a linear model of time if you use your past and present *as the basis* for the future you’re creating. You do this when you let your previous results and performance directly dictate the goals you pursue. As an example, perhaps your company did \$5 million in revenue last year. If you’re operating linearly, then you’ll base your goals this year on last year’s performance.

This is not utilizing time as a tool powerfully, though we will get into that more when explaining *holistic time*, which is more psychologically accurate and powerful than linear time.

Interestingly, linear time is taken for granted not as *a* way of viewing time, but for most people, it is viewed as *the only* way of viewing time. Brent Slife explained that outside of physics, the majority of scientific explanations assume linear time without question. As he details in his book *Time and Psychological Explanation*:

Linear time pervades psychological explanation. . . . Linear assumptions are foundational to both the basic and applied aspects of psychology. How intriguing it is to note that this issue has virtually never been discussed. With rare exceptions, time has not only managed to avoid systematic examination, it has scarcely been acknowledged

anywhere in the field . . . How could a metaphysical assumption of this importance escape some sort of scrutiny?¹²

THE HOLISTIC MODEL OF TIME

Most creatures live in the immediate present, and their mental powers are entirely devoted to processing what is happening now.

Human beings are different, in that people are able to think explicitly about past and future events. Moreover, they use these thoughts about other times to guide their actions in the present. . . .

People think far more about the future than the past. . . .

Pragmatic prospection holds that people think about the future so as to guide actions to bring about desirable outcomes.

— DR. ROY BAUMEISTER AND CO-AUTHORS¹³

This quote above from Dr. Baumeister and his research partners is a bit thick, and if you're not careful, you'll miss what they're saying. Basically, that single quote catches you up on and synthesizes the past 30 or so years of insight in both positive psychology and neuroscience.

Breaking down what Baumeister is saying:

- Most living creatures are completely reactive to and absorbed by what is occurring in the present moment.
- Human beings are different because we have the cognitive intelligence to reflect beyond the present moment, thinking about other things. Particularly, our own past and future.
- Humans think about both the past and future for the explicit purpose of guiding and shaping their decisions in the present.
- People spend far less time thinking about their past than they do thinking about their future. We don't typically think about the past for its own sake, but instead, we think about the past's *implications on the future*.¹⁴
- *Prospection* is a term for thinking about one's own future prospects or potentials.¹⁵ As people, we spend huge amounts of time thinking about

our future and then letting our prospects or goals dictate our course in the present.

- The better we get at thinking about our own past and future—and more particularly our own future self—the better we live in the present.[16,17,18,19](#)
- Our future not only gives meaning and purpose to our present, but it also guides our path and decisions. Said directly, *the future dictates and guides the present*. This is the exact opposite explanation to the linear approach most people have accepted.
- Our goals act as the central part of our frame or perspective in the present. Our goals determine what is relevant or signal and what is irrelevant or noise. Thus, our frame determines how we filter our experience.[20](#)
- *Pathways thinking* is a central aspect of learning and goal achievement, and it reflects one's ability to both set meaningful goals and then effectively find or create pathways to realize them.[21,22](#)

All of this insight brings up some exciting and illuminating truths.

First, from a psychological position, you *cannot separate* the past, present, and future, as is done in Newton's linear and sequential model. The past, present, and future are all co-occurring *in the present*, and each impacts the others.

Time is holistic, not sequential.

As Dr. Slife wrote, "All three dimensions of time—past, present, and future—co-occur in the now. No one dimension of time can truly be a meaningful dimension without the context provided by the other two dimensions."[23](#)

Knowing that time is holistic rather than sequential, this changes the weight or impact of each dimension of time. Rather than the past being the sole driving force, with holistic time that is no longer the case.

Yes, the past is useful information. Yes, it's something you can reference and learn from. However, it is not the guidepost for decisions and actions. It's not the location or locus of control. It's not the driver. It's not pushing you around or forcing you in a particular direction.

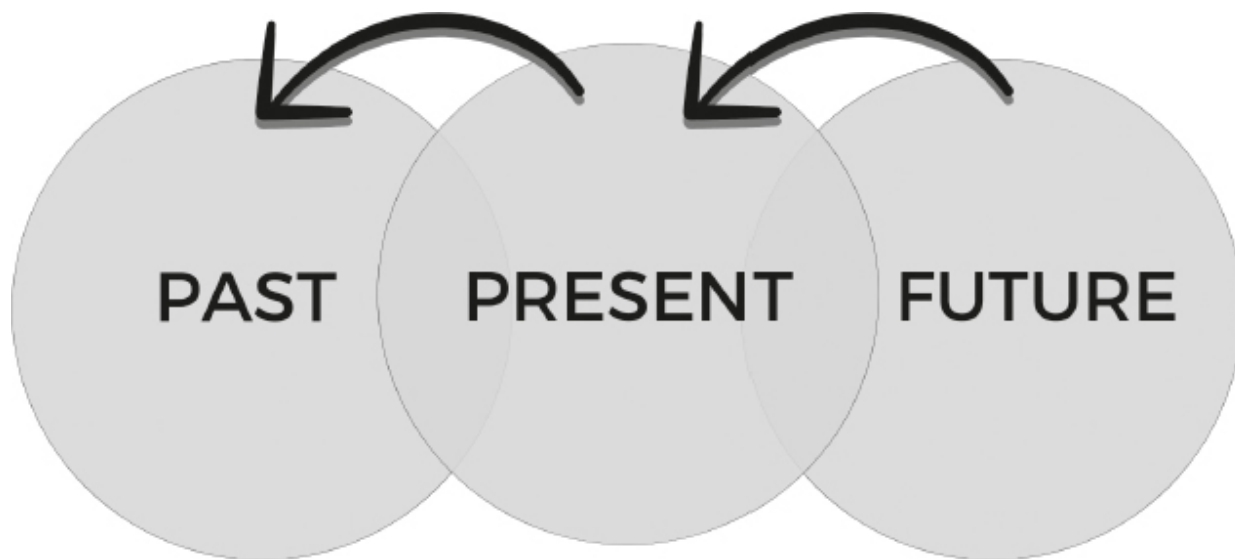
Instead, the past is a tool for making better decisions in the present and not repeating errors of judgment. It's something to learn from, not live in.

Ultimately, with greater psychological maturity, the past is something you actively frame yourself, in the present moment. Regardless of what happened—whether something tragic, a misunderstanding, or even a mistake on your own part—it is your job to frame the meaning. Research shows that it takes an internal, rather than an external, locus of control to take ownership and actively reframe your past, as a tool, rather than blaming your past.²⁴

Unless you actively frame the meaning yourself, you're likely to turn the past into the driver of your present experience. This throws you back into linear time, where the past dictates the present and future. In linear time, you cannot scale or realize impossible goals.

The past isn't a concrete reality. The past is a psychological tool. Don't place the past outside of yourself. The purpose of the past is to improve the present and the future.

Like the past, the future is a psychological tool—not an external reality.



As shown in the image just above what we call holistic time, *the future is where the majority of the weight is*. The future is the biggest factor in who you're being and what you're experiencing right now. The future, not the past, is what causes and shapes what you see and what you do in the present.

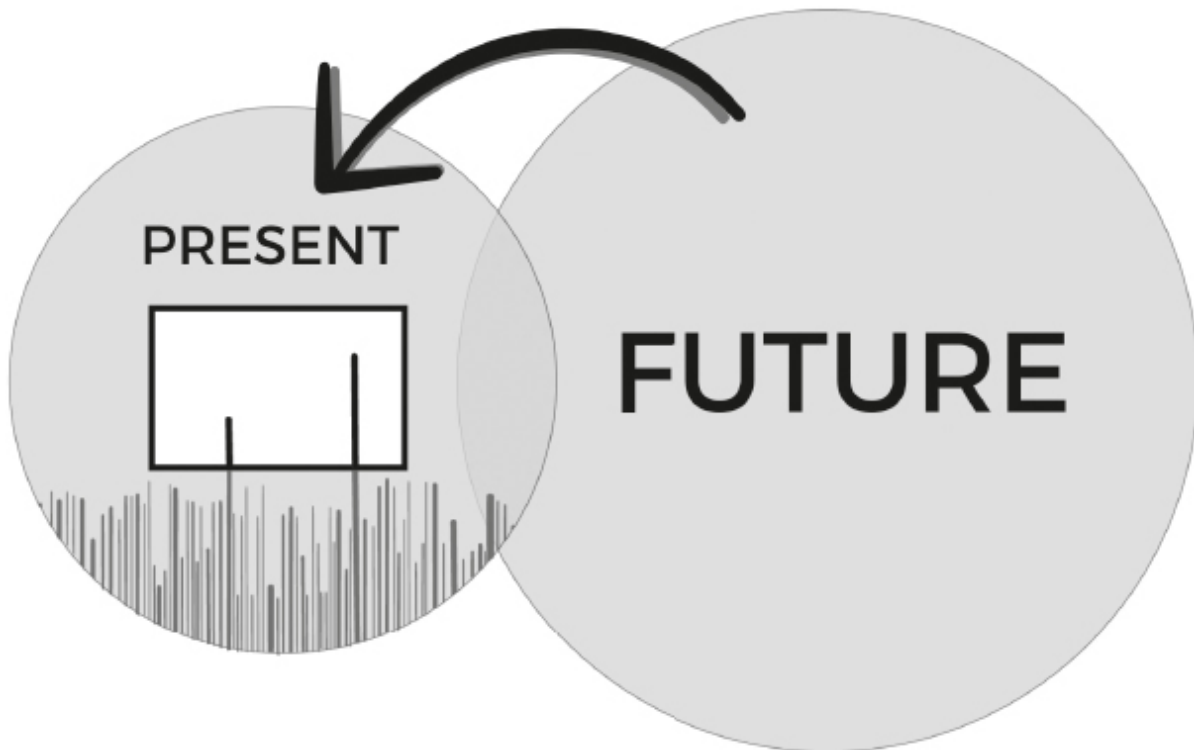
The psychological truth is that the future, more than the past, drives and shapes the present. Since the future heavily dictates the present, the primary aspect of a person's "frame" or perception is their own goals. It is our goals that determine what is signal and what is noise in our lives.

By changing our goals, things that were once signal become noise. Our goals guide and direct our mental filtering, which is called *selective attention*.

Selective attention is an extremely powerful cognitive and emotional skill. Said the neuroscientist Dr. Karl Friston:

The capacity to select is a fundamental part of intelligence and agency, because to select means you're not attending to 99 percent of the things you could select. The notion of selection is a hallmark of truly intelligent behavior.^{[25](#)}

Selective attention is the process by which you actively filter and find effective *pathways* to your goals.



As the image above shows, the quality of how we frame our future determines the quality by which we can filter our present experience. Given that our goals are the primary aspect of our frame, driving our attention and decisions in the present, it makes sense that the quality of our goals determines the quality of our selective attention, or filtering.

This is why impossible goals and impossible deadlines are so powerful. They force extreme filtering in the present, requiring you to let go of all ineffective pathways and select only the most powerful and potent ones. They also enable you to find *Super Whos* who can help you achieve the impossible.

More Resources and Training

- For resources on applying *holistic time* to your business, visit www.holistictime.com.
- For resources on connecting with *your future self*, visit www.futureself.com.
- For resources utilizing *time as a tool*, visit www.timeisatool.com.
- For resources on setting *impossible goals* and how you can utilize these to raise your floor and focus, visit www.myimpossiblegoal.com.
- For resources on increasing your *internal locus of control*, visit www.locusofcontrol.com.
- For resources on improving your *selective attention*, visit www.selectiveattention.com.
- For resources on improving your *pathways thinking*, visit www.pathwaysthinking.com.
- For resources on collaborating with *Super Whos*, visit www.superwhos.com.

Endnotes

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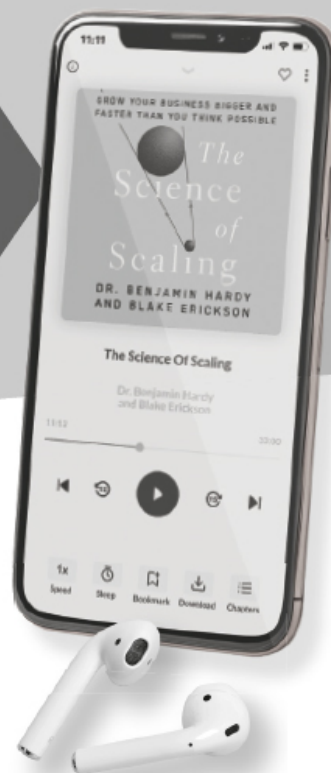
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